

UKRAINIAN REFUGEES. FIFTH WAVE OF RESEARCH

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

As of January 2026, our calculations show that 5.6 million Ukrainians remain abroad due to the war. This is 400 thsd more than the data from the end of 2024.

Between 2.1 and 3 million Ukrainians may remain abroad under various scenarios: 300,000–400,000 more than we estimated as of November 2024. The non-return of Ukrainians will have a significant impact on the Ukrainian economy, which, according to our estimates, could lose between 2.3% and 9.5% of its GDP annually, depending on the baseline data and methodology.

The EU has extended temporary protection for Ukrainians until **March 4, 2027**. The overwhelming majority of refugees are adult women (40%) and children (30%). According to Eurostat data as of December 2025, the largest number of Ukrainian refugees in Europe is in Germany (28%) and Poland (23%). Meanwhile, countries continue to systematically reduce benefits and shift from emergency aid policies to integration: cutting payments, restricting access to housing, and conditioning support on employment, education, and integration levels. After 2027, most Ukrainians are expected to transition to standard long-term residency statuses in their host countries or return voluntarily. Some countries are already creating transitional mechanisms for integrated migrants and stricter conditions for those who fail to integrate. Outside the EU, the trend is similar: support for those already in the country continues, but new entries are restricted. Overall, temporary protection policies are shifting toward greater control and long-term solutions for Ukrainians abroad.

According to an **Info Sapiens survey** commissioned by CES, the intentions of Ukrainian refugees regarding return have stopped declining. Thus, **43% are likely to plan a return to Ukraine**, the same as in the previous wave of the study (November–December 2024).

We also analyzed the effect of the government's decision to allow men aged 18–22 to freely cross the border. Based on data from neighboring countries' border guards, we estimated that the net outflow of men in this age group from August to November 2025 was nearly **100,000 individuals**. This is about one in seven men of this age and one-third of Ukraine's net migration losses in 2025.

Among the factors that refugees cite as barriers to return, **security concerns dominate**. At the same time, in addition to the end of the war, refugees also actively mention political and economic incentives for return: a higher standard of living, infrastructure restoration, stricter rule of law and anti-corruption efforts, and Ukraine's accession to the EU/NATO.

Among those who do not rule out returning, the largest economic hubs are Kyiv, Kharkiv, and Odesa, as well as the regions farthest from Russia, including Zakarpattia, Lviv, and Ivano-Frankivsk, are actively considered.

We also asked refugees about the difficulties they face. The largest number of responses concerned **homesickness (46%)**. They also mentioned missing friends and social circle, uncertainty about the future, difficulties in learning a new language, and integration into a new society.

Since the EU plans to **abolish temporary protection status in March 2027** and replace it with alternative statuses, we also examined for the first time the readiness of Ukrainian refugees for such a change in

policy. About **20% (approximately 870,000 refugees)** already hold another status allowing them to stay abroad. The remaining **80% (about 3.4 million people abroad, excluding Russia and Belarus)** either intend to obtain such documents or are waiting for more information. Transitioning such a large number of Ukrainians to alternative statuses or facilitating their return to Ukraine will pose a significant challenge both for host countries and Ukraine.

If temporary protection is abolished and they are unable to obtain another permit, refugees are divided and consider various options: seeking opportunities in other countries abroad, staying abroad even without permission, or returning to Ukraine. At the same time, about **20% of those who do not yet have other permits** besides temporary protection do not know what they will do if their current status is canceled. About **one-third (1.2 million refugees)**, if their status is canceled and they fail to obtain another residence permit, will consider returning to Ukraine—permanently or temporarily for future re-emigration.

We also conducted a **cluster analysis** and identified four groups of refugees:

The first group (22% of all refugees) is the "New Life Trajectory"—this group consists mainly of young, unmarried people under 35 who left Ukraine not because of direct hostilities but for pragmatic reasons: seeking better prospects, work, and education. This group demonstrates the highest level of integration abroad: they are most proficient in foreign languages, more often have stable jobs in their field, live in separate housing, and are more likely to study in local educational institutions. Due to their high economic activity, they rarely need social assistance and more often assess their financial situation as better than before the war.

The second group (22% of all refugees) is the "Strong Ties"—this cluster unites the most Ukrainian-speaking and family-oriented refugees who, despite relatively successful adaptation abroad, maintain the strongest connection with their homeland. Representatives of this group are more often characterized by high entrepreneurship: every fourth had a business in Ukraine, and abroad they open their own businesses twice as often as other Ukrainians. Their distinguishing feature is their financial connection with Ukraine—more than half of them regularly send money to relatives in Ukraine, and every fifth continues to receive a Ukrainian salary or business income. Over 50% plan to return home.

The third group (17% of all refugees) is the "Economically Vulnerable"—this group consists mainly of middle-aged people who often find themselves in difficult life circumstances: there is a high proportion of divorced individuals and single parents. They have the lowest level of financial well-being, depend on social benefits, and mostly live in dormitories or shared housing. Despite their precarious financial situation and working outside their profession, this cluster is mostly not inclined to return to Ukraine, focusing on better social support and infrastructure abroad.

The fourth group (39% of all refugees) is the "Classic War Refugees"—the largest group, whose departure was more often forced and caused by direct hostilities. This cluster is predominantly older, with a significant proportion from eastern Ukraine, who left their homes only in recent years. They have the lowest level of adaptation abroad: most do not know the language, their social circle is limited to other Ukrainians, and their employment rate is minimal. They more often experience psychological

detachment from home and demonstrate the highest readiness to return to Ukraine. Their main conditions are safety in their home region, de-occupation, and housing restoration.

We propose recommendations that could reduce barriers and encourage Ukrainians abroad to return to Ukraine. These include:

- **Collaboration with EU countries** on the return of Ukrainians after the abolition of temporary protection.
- **Assistance to people from affected regions** during reconstruction, development of public-private partnerships.
- **Creation of return and reintegration programs** for Ukrainian youth.
- **Simplification of procedures** for recognizing experience and documents obtained abroad, particularly regarding education in Ukrainian institutions and social security.
- **Granting Ukrainian refugees freedom of movement and choice of residence within the EU** on par with EU citizens.

1. INTRODUCTION

In this analytical report, we update our answers to the following questions: how many Ukrainians have left the country since the start of the full-scale invasion by the Russian Federation, who these people are, the specifics of their lives and integration in their host countries, how many will return to Ukraine, and what the economic and demographic losses will be if not all of them return.

In our study, we use data from a sociological survey conducted in December 2025 – January 2026 by the research agency Info Sapiens on behalf of the Centre for Economic Strategy. We compare these results with four previous waves of surveys conducted using a similar methodology in November-December 2022, April-May 2023, December 2023-January 2024, and November-December 2024. In addition, we use information from open sources and information obtained through public information requests.

Every year since 2022, we have updated our estimate of the number of Ukrainians who have left the country. According to our estimates, as of January 2026, approximately 5.6 million Ukrainian citizens were forced to stay abroad (including Russia and Belarus, where approximately 1.3 million Ukrainians reside).

Next, we examine the policies of various countries regarding assistance to Ukrainians who have left the country and the main changes over the past year, as well as what can be expected when the temporary protection period in EU countries expires in 2027. After that, we look at the socio-economic profile of Ukrainian refugees, where they live and in what conditions. Then we consider the prospects and intentions of Ukrainians to return from abroad based on data from the Info Sapiens survey (who exactly plans to return, when, and what factors may influence the decision to return).

We also present the results of our cluster analysis, which we used to identify four groups of Ukrainian refugees, and describe their characteristics.

A separate section of the report presents the results of a regression analysis of factors that may influence Ukrainians' desire to return home.

The report also presents the results of our calculations on how many Ukrainians will return to Ukraine after the war. We also assess the age structure of Ukrainians who will return and those who will remain abroad, and consider their distribution by level of education and employment status. In addition, we analyse how the departure and non-return of Ukrainian refugees may affect Ukraine's economy.

Finally, we provide a summary of the research findings and recommendations on policy instruments that Ukraine can use to encourage refugees to return.

2. METHODOLOGY

The main source of data in this study is a survey of Ukrainian refugees¹ conducted by the research agency Info Sapiens on behalf of the Centre for Economic Strategy (CES). Together with Info Sapiens, we conducted five waves of surveys of Ukrainian refugees: in November–December 2022, April–May 2023, December 2023–January 2024, November–December 2024, and December 2025–January 2026. The main source of data in this report is the fifth wave of the survey (December 2025–January 2026). We use data from previous waves to compare results. A detailed analysis of the results of previous waves of the survey, as well as their methodology, can be found in the analytical note of the Centre for Economic Strategy, ‘Refugees from Ukraine: who are they, how many are there, and how can they be returned? Final report.’² More of our publications on this topic can be found on our website under the tag ‘refugees.’³

In the fifth wave of the survey, 1,000 Ukrainian refugees⁴ who were living abroad at the time of the survey were interviewed. The survey was not conducted among Ukrainians residing in Russia or Belarus. Respondents were recruited partly through SMS messaging (62% of respondents) with a link to an online questionnaire, and partly through online recruitment (38%).

In 2025, the research methodology was updated. In 2022–2024, all respondents were recruited exclusively via SMS messages with a link to an online questionnaire. In 2025, we added respondent recruitment via the online panel of the Info Sapiens research agency to the SMS messaging.

The combination of two recruitment channels allowed us to better balance the sample and reduce possible biases associated with different levels of Ukrainian mobile phone usage among refugees from different social groups.

As in previous waves, the numbers to which the survey was sent were selected at random from among Kyivstar and Vodafone subscribers who were abroad at the time of the survey (excluding Russia and Belarus). To ensure the representativeness of the survey, geographical quotas for the distribution of Ukrainians abroad were used, based on data from the European Statistical Service⁵, as well as official data on the number of Ukrainians who have moved to the United Kingdom⁶, Canada⁷ and the United States of America.⁸

¹ Hereinafter the term ‘refugees’ in the paper is defined as people who lived in internationally recognised Ukraine and left it due to the start of the war with Russia (mainly after 24 February 2022).

² [Refugees from Ukraine: Who are they, how many are they and how to return them home? - CES](#)

³ [Refugees - CES](#)

⁴ Hereinafter, the report provides the number of cases in the weighted array. A total of 1,173 questionnaires were completed and included in the final research pool. The reduction in the number of questionnaires due to weighting is a technical procedure that does not affect the results and conclusions of the study.

⁵ https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/migr_asytpsm/default/table?lang=en

⁶ <https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/689effe11fedc616bb133a41/ukraine-visa-schemes-summary-jun-2025-tables.ods>

⁷ [Canada-Ukraine authorization for emergency travel: Key figures - Canada.ca](#)

⁸ [Uniting for Ukraine](#)

Online recruitment was conducted via the online panel of the Info Sapiens research agency by sending potential respondents emails with a link to the survey questionnaire.

In addition to the survey data, we also used data from open sources and data obtained as a result of requests for public information. We describe these in detail in the sections where we use them.

3. HOW MANY UKRAINIANS ARE ABROAD?

Given the heterogeneity of data and large migration shifts, there is no trivial answer to this question. In this section, we analyse a range of data sources to estimate the number of Ukrainians who are abroad and who left the country from the start of the full-scale invasion. This analysis is a continuation and extension of the estimates from the previous four waves of this study.

3.1. TEMPORARY PROTECTION OR ITS EQUIVALENT

According to UN estimates, as of December 2025, there were nearly 5.9 million Ukrainian refugees registered worldwide. These figures include the UN's estimate of Ukrainian refugees in the Russian Federation and Belarus. At the same time, according to the latest UN data, there are about 6,000 Ukrainian refugees in Russia and about 40,000 in Belarus⁹.

By April 2025, the UN estimate of Ukrainian refugees in the Russian Federation was about 1.3 million people. Since the Russian Federation does not provide transparency about the number of Ukrainians arriving in its territory from Ukraine, the UN estimates were based on Russian data on officially signed contracts for housing rental by Ukrainian citizens in Russia. This data did not include those who do not rent housing or do so unofficially, as well as Ukrainians who have obtained Russian citizenship. Accordingly, estimates based on such data can only be approximate. In June 2023, Russia stopped publishing this data, and in May 2025, UN estimates ceased to be based on it. This led to a sharp re-evaluation of the number of refugees from 1.3 million in April ¹⁰to several thsd in May 2025¹¹. We continue to rely on the latest estimate of 1.3 million Ukrainian refugees in the Russian Federation, but it should be noted that we cannot be sure of the accuracy of this data or independently verify it.

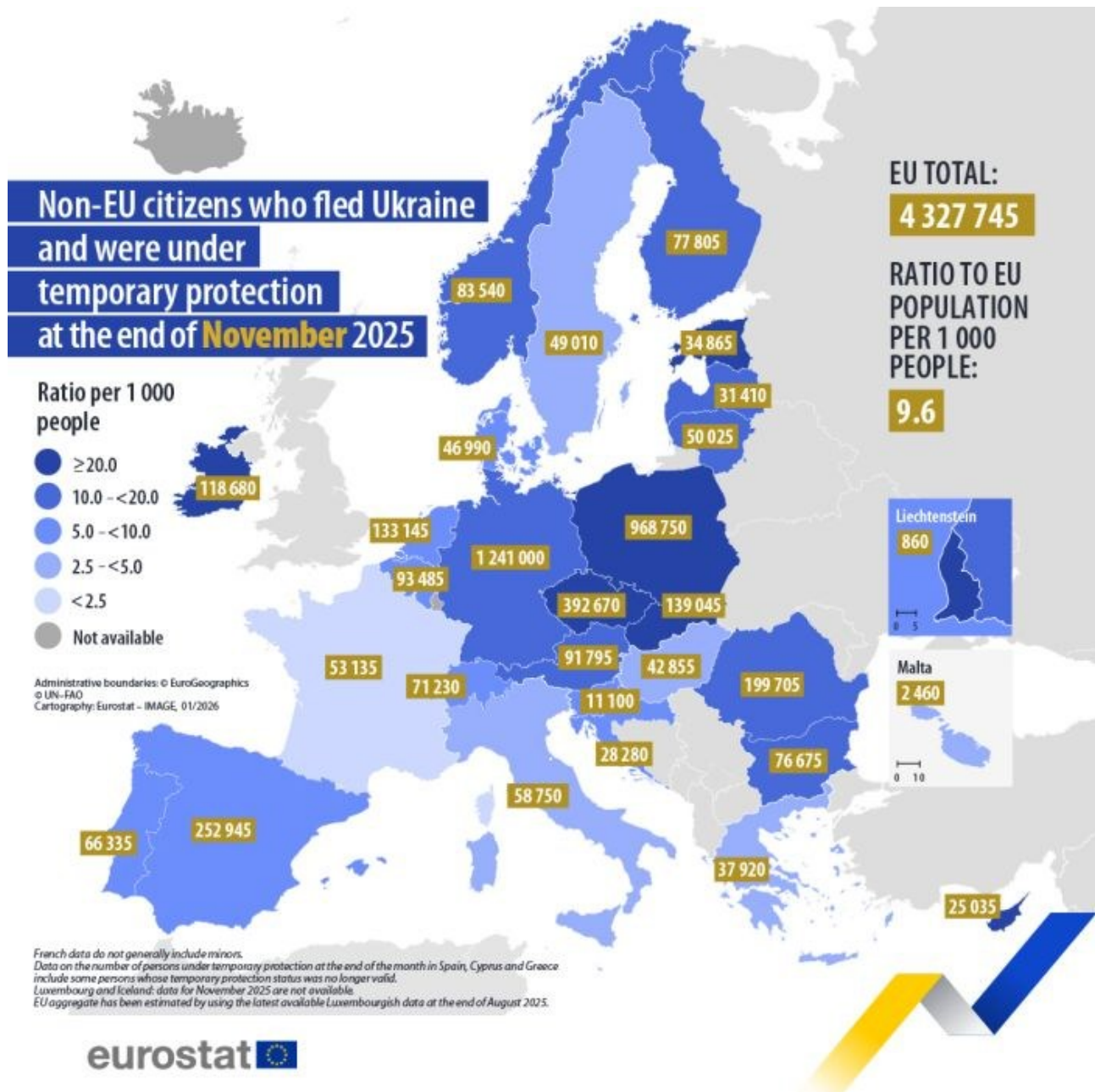
Data for Western countries is also subject to inaccuracies due to differences in procedures for granting and revoking temporary protection. For example, in France, children do not need to obtain temporary protection, so they are not included in the statistics of those who have received it. Also, the policy of revoking temporary protection varies from country to country. For some, this status is automatically cancelled after a certain period following their return to Ukraine. For others, even after returning to Ukraine, a person may retain active temporary protection status in their former country of residence. Some countries sometimes cancel inactive temporary protection statuses at once, which creates sharp declines in Eurostat data (see Figure 1).

⁹ [Situation Ukraine Refugee Situation](#)

¹⁰ [Document - Ukraine Situation Flash Update #80](#)

¹¹ [Document - Ukraine Situation Flash Update #81](#)

Figure 1 . Geographical distribution of Ukrainian refugees in EU countries

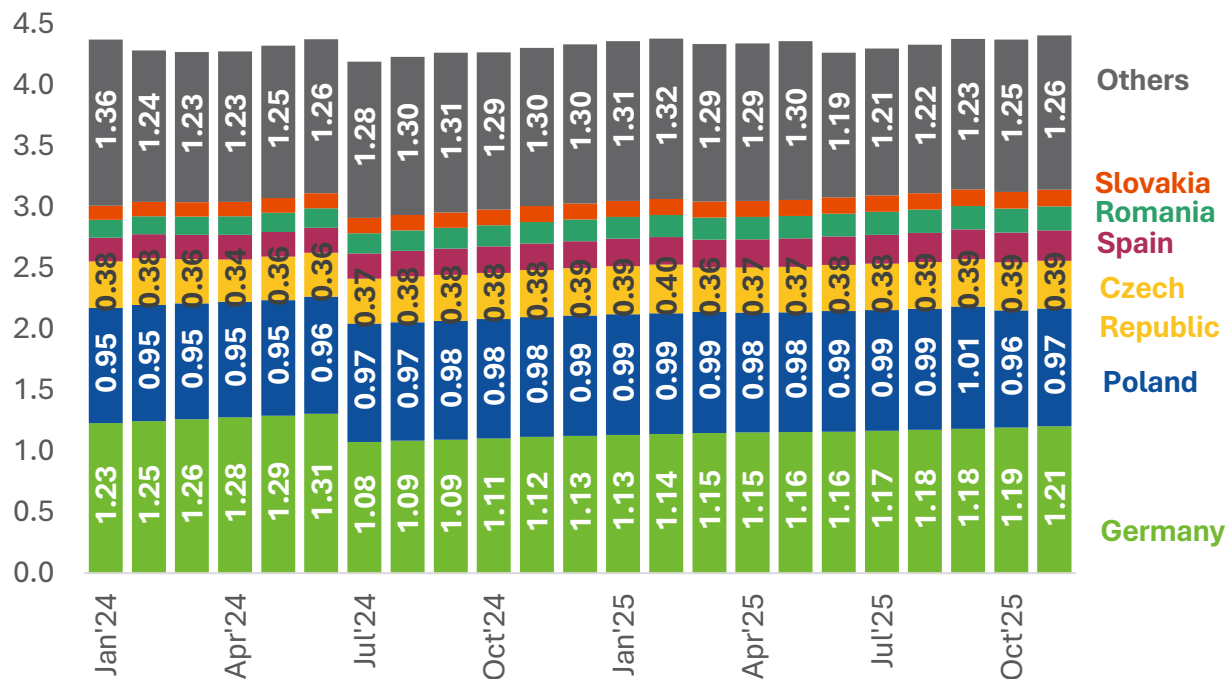


Source: European Statistical Service.

As of October 2025, nearly 4.3 million people have temporary protection status in EU countries, which is only 0.4% (or 46,000 people) more than in January 2025. According to data for November 2025, the largest number of Ukrainians is in Germany – 1.2 million people, Poland – 965,000 people, and the Czech Republic – 391,000 people (see Figure 1 and Figure 2).

At the same time, the Czech Republic ranks first in terms of the relative number of refugees – 35.39 persons per 1,000 inhabitants. Poland (26.45 persons per 1,000 inhabitants) and Slovakia (25.51 persons per 1,000 inhabitants) are in second and third place, respectively, with a slight gap.

Figure 2 . Change in the geographical distribution of Ukrainian refugees in EU countries, million people



Source: European Statistical Service [migr_asytpsm].¹²

Shifts are also visible in the gender representation of Ukrainian refugees in the EU, with the proportion of men continuing to increase. Their number among refugees increased by 163,000 between January 2025 and October 2025 (the proportion increased from 39% to 41%), while the number of women, in contrast, decreased by 124,000 (the proportion changed from 61% to 59%, respectively).¹³

The biggest shifts were recorded in Latvia, where the proportion of men increased by 5 percentage points (from 40% to 45%). In Italy and Denmark, there was an increase of 3 percentage points among men (from 29% to 32% and 40% to 43%, respectively). In most other countries, these changes remain at 1-2 percentage points. The only exception is Greece, the only EU country where the share of men has decreased slightly from 30% to 29%.¹⁴

Outside the EU, the countries with the largest number of Ukrainians accepted since the start of the full-scale invasion are Canada, the United States and the United Kingdom: as of May 2025, there are approximately 274,000 people in Canada¹⁵, 263,800 in the United Kingdom (as of June 2025)¹⁶ and the United States about 260,000 (as of November 2025)¹⁷.

¹² Beneficiaries of temporary protection at the end of the month by citizenship, age and sex - monthly data. Eurostat.

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁵ CUIAS Survey Results: How Ukrainians Are Adapting in Canada and What Their Future Plans Look Like. CUIAS

¹⁶ Ukraine Refugee Situation. UNHCR.

¹⁷ Nearly 200,000 Ukrainians in US thrown into legal limbo by Trump immigration crackdown. Reuters.

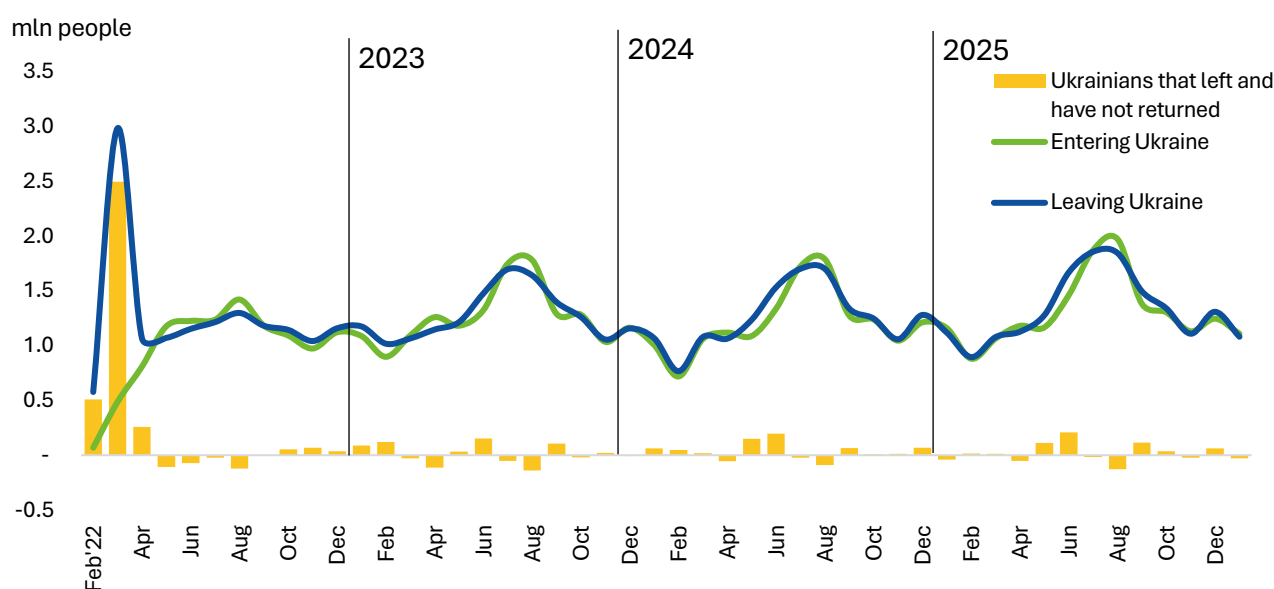
3.2. BORDER CROSSINGS

In this study, we use data on departing and arriving crossings of the Ukrainian border as the primary method for estimating the number of Ukrainian refugees. Net departures (departures from Ukraine minus arrivals in Ukraine) are an indirect source for estimating the number of Ukrainians who have remained abroad. We rely on UNHCR data (which is based on data from Ukraine's neighbouring countries: Poland, Slovakia, Hungary, Romania, Moldova) for 2022 and data from the State Border Guard Service of Ukraine from January 2023 to December 2025.

According to our estimates based on UNHCR and SBGS data, from February 2022 to December 2025, there were 60.4 million departures from Ukraine and 56.3 million arrivals in Ukraine. The net outflow was 3.1 million Ukrainian citizens in 2022 (UN data citing neighbouring border guards) and 161,000 citizens in 2023 (State Border Guard Service of Ukraine data).

As in previous notes, we use only UN data for 2022 due to discrepancies between the data published on the UN website and the data from the State Border Service of Ukraine (SBU). We do not use SBU data for 2022 because in the first weeks of the full-scale invasion, there were likely difficulties in recording border crossings. Instead, for February–December 2022, we use UN data that refers to data from the border services of Ukraine's neighbouring countries. Starting in January 2023, we use State Border Service data.

Figure 3. Ukrainian border crossing dynamics (except for Russian Federation and Belarus) during February 2022 – December 2025, million persons



Sources: UNHCR, border guard services of neighbouring countries (Except for Russia and Belarus), State Border Guard Service of Ukraine, CES calculations.

According to the State Border Guard Service of Ukraine, in 2025, 303,000 more Ukrainian citizens left the country than entered it. This is 34% less than in 2024 (when 459,000 more Ukrainian citizens left than returned).

Table 1. Net migration of Ukrainian citizens from Ukraine (million persons)

	2022	2023	2024	2025
Jan		-0.09	-0.06	0.04
Feb	-0.51	-0.12	-0.05	-0.01
Mar	-2.50	0.03	-0.02	-0.01
Apr	-0.26	0.11	0.06	0.05
May	0.11	-0.03	-0.15	-0.11
Jun	0.07	-0.15	-0.20	-0.21
Jul	0.02	0.05	0.02	0.02
Aug	0.12	0.14	0.09	0.13
Sep	0.00	-0.11	-0.06	-0.11
Oct	-0.05	0.02	-0.01	-0.04
Nov	-0.07	-0.02	-0.01	0.02
Dec	-0.04	0.01	-0.07	-0.06
Year total	-3.09	-0.16	-0.46	-0.30

Sources: UNHCR, border guard services of neighbouring countries (except for Russia and Belarus), State Border Guard Service of Ukraine, CES calculations.

Approximately 4 million Ukrainian citizens remain abroad, having left after the start of the full-scale invasion via the Western border (Poland, Slovakia, Hungary, Romania, Moldova). At the same time, Ukrainians who left the country via Russia or Belarus should be added to this figure.

In a survey conducted by Info Sapiens among Ukrainians abroad, Ukrainians were asked how they left the country. Those who were forced to cross the border with Russia or Belarus accounted for 6.5%. It also turns out that about 277,000 Ukrainians also left the country via Russia or Belarus.

Accordingly, a total of about 4.3 million Ukrainian refugees remain abroad, not counting Ukrainian citizens who are in Russia and Belarus. If we take into account Ukrainians in Russia and Belarus, according to UN data, there are about 1.3 million such persons (see Section 3 above). With them included, the total number of Ukrainian refugees is about 5.6 million.

3.2.1. MEN AGED 18-22 DEPARTING FROM THE COUNTRY

On 28 August 2025, a resolution of the Cabinet of Ministers of Ukraine came into force, lifting restrictions on border crossings for men aged 18-22, allowing them to travel abroad freely. This sparked public debate and widespread interest in the effect and scale of travel by this category of citizens.¹⁸ Since the State Border Service of Ukraine did not provide the relevant data in response to requests for public

¹⁸ Resolution of the Cabinet of Ministers of Ukraine No. 1031 of 26 August 2025 'On Amendments to the Rules for Crossing the State Border by Citizens of Ukraine'. [Link](#).

information, we turned to the border guard services of neighbouring countries to assess the departure of men aged 18-22.

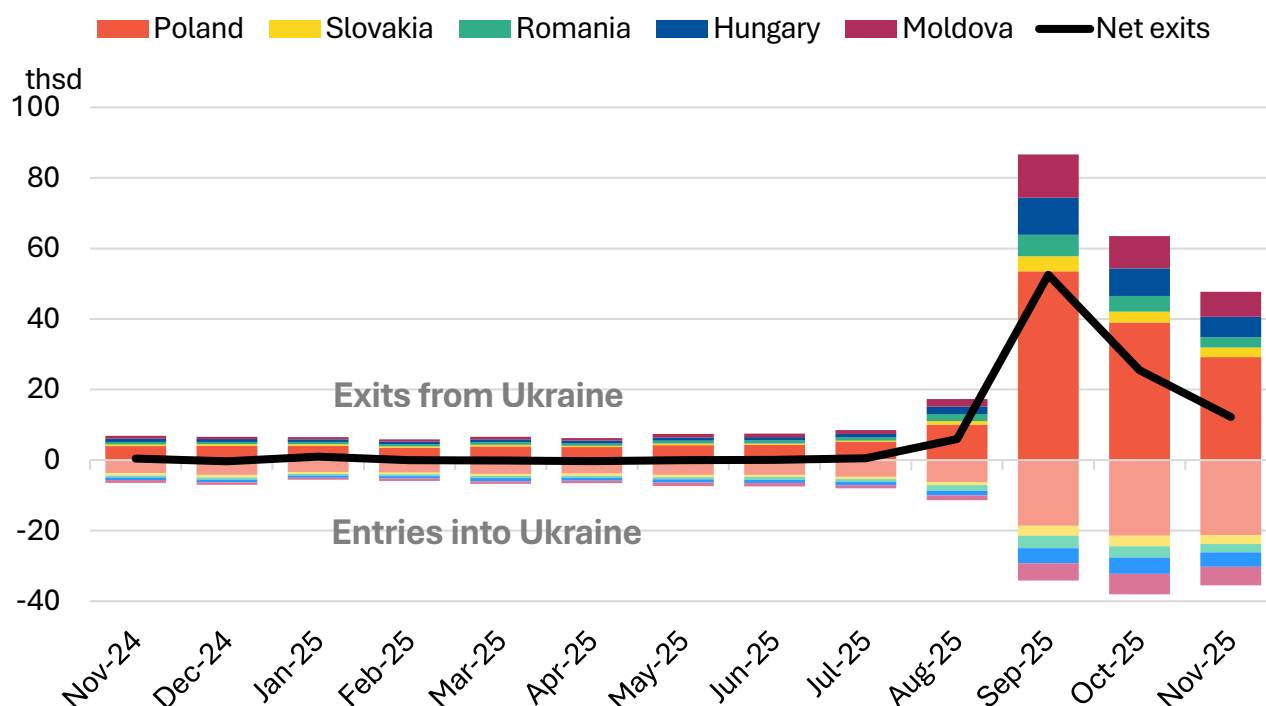
In response to our requests, three out of five countries provided us with data – Poland, Slovakia and Romania, which together account for about 75% of all border crossings, according to the State Border Guard Service of Ukraine. We estimated the number of crossings of the Hungarian and Moldovan borders by men aged 18-22 using extrapolation. We assumed that the proportion of crossings of these borders by men aged 18-22 does not differ from the overall proportion of crossings of these borders by all Ukrainian citizens. Since 18-22-year-old men were not restricted in the borders they could cross, we have no reason to believe that they preferred one border over another compared to the total number of crossings.

According to our estimates, before the relevant policy was introduced, the ‘net’ departures (those who left Ukraine minus those who entered Ukraine) of men aged 18-22 fluctuated around zero. On average, in January-July 2025, 130 more men aged 18-22 left Ukraine each month than returned. The permission to travel abroad created a significant impetus for departure.

According to our estimates, in August, 6,000 more men aged 18-22 left than returned. In September, this figure was about 52,500, in October, 25,500, and in November, 12,300 men of the corresponding age. In total, for August-November 2025, the net loss was about 96,000 men. Considering that, according to the State Border Service of Ukraine, in 2025 alone, 303,000 more Ukrainian citizens left than entered the country, men aged 18-22 account for almost a third of all net losses for the year. If we compare this with the total number of men aged 18-22 in Ukraine, according to the demographic forecast of the M. V. Ptukha Institute of Demography and Social Studies, there were about 700,000 men aged 18-22 in the territory controlled by Ukraine in 2025.¹⁹ Accordingly, almost one in seven of this number left Ukraine in August-November 2025.

¹⁹ Ukraine demographic forecast 2023 https://idss.org.ua/forecasts/nation_pop_proj

Figure 4. Crossing of the Ukrainian border by Ukrainian men aged 18-22



Source: Polish, Slovak, Romanian border guard services, State Border Guard Service of Ukraine, estimates by the Centre for Economic Strategy.

Estimates for Hungary and Moldova are extrapolated based on State Border Guard Service data on border crossings by country.

4. LEGAL STATUS OF UKRAINIAN REFUGEES

4.1. EU COUNTRIES

Ukrainians residing in EU countries retain the right to reside, work and access social support under the temporary protection mechanism, which has been extended once again until 4 March 2027²⁰. Over the past year, the basic legal status of persons under temporary protection has continued to change towards the reduction of benefits. Against the backdrop of discussions on the development of a legislative framework for a gradual exit from the temporary protection regime, aimed at either voluntary integration or return at the EU level, national governments continue to review the scope and conditions for the provision of social benefits.

In Germany, Ukrainian refugees receive assistance under the Bürgergeld (Civic money) programme, which has remained unchanged since last year. However, not all Ukrainian refugees have equal access to benefits under German law. Those who arrived after 1 April 2025 no longer receive social support under the Bürgergeld standard (€563 per adult per month), but under the Asylum Seekers Benefits Act

²⁰ COUNCIL RECOMMENDATION on a coordinated approach to the transition out of temporary protection for displaced persons from Ukraine <https://data.consilium.europa.eu/doc/document/ST-12015-2025-INIT/en/pdf>

(Asylbewerberleistungsgesetz) — which is slightly lower, at approximately €441²¹. This is quite expected, as the change the legal status of Ukrainians in Germany was mentioned among the possible options for reducing support.

The Parliament of Latvia has adopted amendments to the law on support for civilians from Ukraine, which reduce the number of assistance measures. In particular, the one-time payment at the beginning of employment (equivalent to the minimum monthly wage) and an array of other benefits is being abolished, and state support is redirecting its aim mostly at vulnerable groups.²²

In Poland, the temporary protection regime for Ukrainian citizens remains in force. However, on 4 March 2026, the special law on aid for Ukrainian citizens, under which PESEL UKR status was granted, will expire. This will mean that Ukrainians will be subject to the general rules on residence, employment, and access to social services that apply to other foreigners. Preparations for this transition have already begun with the phasing out of benefits.

From 1 June 2025, child-rearing benefits (800 zlotys) and support under the ‘Good Start’ programme (300 zlotys)²³ will only be paid if the child fulfils their obligations regarding pre-school preparation or education within the Polish education system. From November 1, Poland also stopped co-financing accommodation in collective accommodation centres for Ukrainians who have been in the country for a year or more. In the future, such support will only be maintained for certain vulnerable groups (children, the elderly, people with disabilities), for whom compensation of PLN 15 per day is provided²⁴. In addition, from 1 January 2026, in order to obtain PESEL UKR status, Poland will introduce a requirement to present oneself in person before the authorised body, similar to the procedures applied to citizens of countries outside the EU.

After the special status is abolished, most social benefits and privileges will be available mainly to persons who are officially employed in Poland and pay contributions to the social insurance system (ZUS).

In general, the relevant draft law sets the course for the gradual abolition of special conditions that applied exclusively to Ukrainians and the integration of their legal status into the general migration system of Poland. At the same time, the government is proposing an alternative legal mechanism for those who plan to stay in Poland for a longer period. This is a special temporary residence card (CUKR card)²⁵ valid for up to three years, which can be applied for by persons with an active UKR status during a specified period and subject to a security check. This instrument is primarily aimed at already integrated migrants, as it grants the right to work without additional permits and provides greater stability of legal status in the context of the rollback of the temporary protection regime.

²¹ [Rechtskreiswechsel für ukrainische Geflüchtete](#)

²² [Latvian state aid for Ukrainians to shrink next year](#)

²³ [New rules for identity verification and benefits payments for Ukrainian citizens in Poland](#)

²⁴ [Кінець спецзакону в Польщі: як українцям отримати карту CUKR у 2026 році](#)

²⁵ [Картки побуту для громадян України з PESEL UKR](#)

In the Czech Republic, social protection for Ukrainian refugees is regulated by Act No. 65/2022 Coll., known as Lex Ukrajina. Due to periodic amendments, a Roman numeral is added to its title to indicate the serial number of the latest package of amendments.

Since temporary protection in the Czech Republic is valid until 31 March 2026, holders of tolerance visas need to extend it by completing online registration by 15 March.

Holders of this status receive primarily humanitarian aid, which amounts to 4,400 Czech korunas per month for adults under the rules of Lex Ukrajina V (2023) (although previously, a one-time financial assistance of 2,500 Czech korunas and 5,000 Czech korunas per month was paid at the Regional Assistance Centres for Ukraine).

Additionally, compensation for rent and utilities is also possible, as well as other benefits, including ones for children (for low-income families, for special needs, etc.), but this was also cut in the package of amendments from 2023. Housing provided to refugees as free accommodation remained indefinite only for vulnerable categories of persons, while the rest of the cases are capped by a maximum of 90 days. From 2024, the rules for extending temporary protection status became stricter, with a mandatory appearance in person to obtain a visa sticker becoming a prerequisite²⁶.

The updated Lex Ukrajina VII support programme has increased payments by 10% since the beginning of 2025 (due to rising prices), digitised services for refugees through a unified online portal, and strengthened benefits for working parents and pregnant women. At the same time, the state is introducing stricter living conditions that require the availability of real housing, in particular on lease basis. When the support for Ukrainian refugees was introduced, the mandatory condition of legal residence for all migrants, i.e., the registration, was somewhat relaxed, as it was allowed to register at the addresses of the Ministry of Internal Affairs. However, now the permanent administrative registration will indicate insufficient integration as well as financial independence, threatening the loss of protection. A new feature is the mechanism for transitioning to a 5-year residence permit (ZDP) for Ukrainians with temporary protection who are financially independent and have been living in the country for more than two years, which marks the gradual integration of refugees into Czech society. An important requirement for obtaining a ZDP is that the children of Ukrainian refugees attend Czech schools.

In Slovakia, temporary protection holders are entitled to medical care, access to education, employment, social benefits, and financial assistance (€80 per month for those who are unemployed). The refugees who arrived in the country after 1 March 2025 are also entitled to free accommodation for 60 days instead of 120 days.²⁷

Poland²⁸ and Slovakia²⁹ have also updated their migration strategies recently. Among other things, they provide for the development and simplified procedure for issuing new statuses for Ukrainians who will replace temporary protection.

²⁶ [Humanitární dávka](#)

²⁷ [Štátne príspevky za ubytovanie osôb s dočasným útočiskom](#)

²⁸ [Strategia migracyjna Polski na lata 2025-2030](#)

²⁹ [Národná stratégia Slovenskej republiky k riadeniu azylu a migrácie](#)

Both countries emphasise speeding up the processing of residence applications for bona fide migrants, strengthening the screening of unfounded applications and preventing abuse of visa regimes, as well as giving priority to migrants who are in demand by the economy or have high potential for integration (in particular through language skills and participation in public life). The Ukrainian refugees remain in focus, as the plans are underway to speed up the processing of applications for certain statuses and to develop mechanisms for a gradual transition from temporary protection to long-term residence permits.

Thus, EU Member States continue to gradually reduce assistance to Ukrainian refugees, develop transitional mechanisms for them to obtain long-term, but still non-standard, residence permits, and encourage integration into the society, culture, and law of the host countries.

4.2. POST-2027 FUTURE: WHAT DO THE EU COUNTRIES PREPARE FOR UKRAINIAN REFUGEES?

Currently, the future of a large proportion of Ukrainian refugees in the EU is only certain until 4 March 2027, as long as temporary protection remains in force. After this date, countries will most likely facilitate the transition to long-term statuses (national or pan-European, standard for all migrants or specific for Ukrainians) as well as voluntary return, in accordance with the recommendations of the Council of Europe. The former focus on three points: 1) legalisation of Ukrainian refugees in EU countries through other statuses, 2) organised and supported return to Ukraine, 3) continued stay for vulnerable groups.

The transition to other legal statuses in the EU is a priority for countries hosting Ukrainian refugees. This means that the governments of these countries should facilitate the granting of residence permits under national law (e.g. based on employment, self-employment, study, family circumstances) or, if national status is not available, permits based on European directives for highly skilled workers, students, or researchers.

4.2.1. GERMANY

Germany currently has a programme in place to accelerate the transition of Ukrainians to national long-term residence permits, which provides for the possibility of obtaining a long-term residence permit on appropriate grounds while still under temporary protection. However, only about 14,000 Ukrainian refugees have so far switched from temporary protection to work or study visas. At the same time, the proportion of those in employment is growing from 65,000 in 2022 to over 340,000 in the summer of 2025³⁰.

The main mechanisms for Ukrainian refugees to remain legally in Germany after temporary protection are as follows:

- **Education.** Ukrainians can stay in Germany by enrolling in a university, vocational school or advanced training programme. To do so, they must have confirmation of enrolment, basic knowledge of the language of instruction, medical insurance, and financial resources for living

³⁰ [Temporary protection is coming to an end: how can Ukrainians change their status in Germany?](#)

expenses. Such a permit is issued for the duration of the course of study and can be the first step towards further employment or permanent residence.

- **Work.** One of the most common ways is to switch to a residence permit based on employment. This requires a job offer from a German employer. For qualified specialists, it is important to have their diploma or professional qualification recognised, and for certain professions (e.g. doctors), they need the appropriate work permit or licence. Researchers in Germany enjoy simplified rules.

Residence permits for employment purposes are usually issued for a period of up to four years with a possibility of extension. Holders of an EU Blue Card or persons who have completed their education in Germany can obtain such a permit within a shorter period of time.

The goal for many is a permanent residence permit (Niederlassungserlaubnis), which does not need to be renewed regularly. It can be obtained after 5 years of legal residence in the country, stable income, basic knowledge of German, availability of housing and no problems with the law³¹. This is effectively a recognition that a person has successfully integrated and can live and work independently in the country.

4.2.2. POLAND

Ukrainian citizens staying in Poland based on the temporary protection and have UKR status can now apply for standard migration statuses. For example, a temporary residence and work permit, which allows them to legally work or study in the country for up to three years. For those who plan to stay in the country for longer, a long-term residence permit is available, which is usually issued after several years of continuous legal residence or if you have family ties with Poland or Polish origin, international protection, etc., and provided you are financially independent and know the language. Separate permits are available for highly qualified specialists and for Ukrainians who want to start their own business.

4.2.3. CZECH REPUBLIC

In the Czech Republic, the residence permit system is based on Act No. 326/1999³² on the residence of foreigners, which establishes temporary and permanent permits.

Ukrainians can obtain a temporary residence permit for work, study, scientific activity, or family reunification. Usually, it is issued for 1–2 years, provided they have accommodation, income, and medical insurance and are staying for more than 90 days. After five years of legal residence or marriage to a Czech citizen, or for the purpose of employment, it is possible to apply for a long-term residence permit, which does not require regular renewal. There is also a separate Green Card — a special work visa tied to a specific vacancy from the official list of shortage occupations. It is divided into types: A, B, and C. The type depends on the employee's level of qualification.

³¹ [Residence Act in the version promulgated on 25 February 2008 \(Federal Law Gazette I p. 162\), most recently amended by Article 4b of the Act of 17 February 2020 \(Federal Law Gazette I p. 166\)](#)

³² [Act No. 326/1999 Coll., on the Residence of Foreign Nationals in the Territory of the Czech Republic \(an unofficial version as of 13th February 2009\)](#)

4.2.4. RETURNING TO UKRAINE

Along with the transition to national residence permits, preparations should be made for facilitating the return to Ukraine of those refugees who did not want or were unable to obtain such a status. Countries of temporary residence should organise opportunities for refugees to make so-called ‘familiarisation visits’. These to be self-financed short trips to Ukraine to assess the situation (the state of their property, living conditions). Clear parameters and conditions for such visits should be established, and countries should introduce special programmes to organise the return of Ukrainian refugees.

The Recommendations of the Council of Europe envisage the return as a two-stage process.

Before departure, refugees receive administrative, advisory and financial assistance (enhanced but regressive), support with documents, organisation of ‘familiarisation visits’ to their home country and, if necessary, additional payments for vulnerable groups. The aim of this stage is to help people make a considered, informed and final choice on whether to return or to stay. If a person chooses the latter, the competent authorities are obliged to advise them on the legal ways of obtaining a long-term residence and work permit as well as provide help them obtain it, or, if not, to help organise their departure.

The regulatory framework for migration at EU level combines control, human rights protection and long-term integration. The Migration and Asylum Pact³³ establishes common approaches to the examination of applications, the assessment of migrants' vulnerability and the response to migratory pressure, while strengthening border management and the effectiveness of return procedures. The Return Directive³⁴ enshrines basic guarantees for foreigners – the prohibition of collective expulsions, compliance with the principle of non-refoulement and legality as well as the protection of children. This system is complemented by the EU Strategy on Voluntary Return and Reintegration³⁵, which emphasises the voluntary nature of decisions, the legality of return and the creation of conditions for sustainable living and the realisation of people's potential in their country of origin.

All of them are coherent with the ECHR practice which states in its decisions: the priority of human rights, the prohibition of detention (which is recognised as a last resort), voluntary departure, and the best interests of children. In turn, the practice of the EU Court of Justice emphasises that the Return Directive takes precedence over conflicting provisions of national law.

In practice, these principles are implemented through voluntary return and reintegration support programmes, which provide specific administrative, financial, logistical and advisory mechanisms to assist migrants returning to their country of origin or a third country.

Some countries have introduced ‘bridge’, i.e. transit statuses allowing people to stay in the country for a relatively long time (3-5 years) and do not depend on the availability of temporary protection. These include countries with the largest Ukrainian populations abroad – Poland, Germany and the Czech Republic.

³³ [Pact on Migration and Asylum](#)

³⁴ [Directive 2008/115/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council of 16 December 2008 on common standards and procedures in Member States for returning illegally staying third-country nationals](#)

³⁵ [The EU strategy on voluntary return and reintegration](#)

4.3. OTHER COUNTRIES

In 2025, other Western countries that had accepted large numbers of Ukrainian refugees, such as the United Kingdom, Norway, the United States and Canada, gradually wound down the emergency humanitarian programmes for Ukrainians that had been introduced after Russia's full-scale invasion. Those who already have the appropriate status continue to receive support, but opportunities for those wishing to obtain it are becoming increasingly limited.

US immigration policy towards Ukrainians in 2025 was marked by an attempt to roll back the emergency humanitarian mechanism that was introduced after Russia's full-scale invasion.

In this context, the fundamental Uniting for Ukraine (U4U) programme, which allowed Ukrainians to enter the United States under sponsorship, was effectively suspended for new applications in early 2025 by Trump's executive order reorganising the refugee resettlement programme in the United States. However, on 10 February 2025, IRAP (International Refugee Assistance Project – an independent non-profit organisation) filed a lawsuit requesting that the legality of this act be established, a case later named *Pacito v. Trump*. Subsequently, on 15 May, the Federal Court ordered the US government to resume consideration of refugee applications under humanitarian programmes, including U4U for Ukrainians, but only for those who were to arrive by 20 January 2025 and those who had a 'strong interest based on a reasonable expectation of policy permanence' (and such interest was held by all those who were to arrive by 3 February 2025). The administrative pause was finally lifted by a memorandum from the Deputy Director of the US Citizenship and Immigration Services. On 9 June 2025, the US Citizenship and Immigration Services resumed accepting and reviewing applications for re-parole extensions, work visas, and changes in immigration status.³⁶

At the same time, according to legislative changes from the summer of 2025 (H.R. 1), all participants in the U4U programme must pay a new immigration fee of \$1,000 for the granting or extension of humanitarian parole. The procedure for obtaining humanitarian parole will be carried out only on an individual basis ('only a case-by-case basis') if there are grounds of an urgent humanitarian nature or due to significant public benefit to American society, which means potentially more refusals.

Switzerland and Norway have a similar approach to Ukrainian refugees. It consists of introducing stricter restrictions on obtaining temporary protection.

Although the migration policy of these countries is aimed at extending temporary protection for Ukrainians already in residing the country until 4 March 2027, applications for temporary protection now require the specification of the region of origin within Ukraine – applicants from regions considered relatively 'safe' will not be able to obtain such status.^{37 38} The changes do not affect those possessing the status or their family members. In addition, Switzerland has revised the rules for

³⁶ [USCIS Lifts Administrative Pause on Immigration Applications Filed by Uniting for Ukraine \(U4U\) Parolees and Others Who Entered Pursuant to Humanitarian Parole](#)

³⁷ [Allgemeinverfügung zur Gewährung des vorübergehenden Schutzes im Zusammenhang mit der Situation in der Ukraine](#)

³⁸ <https://www.udi.no/uk/important-messages/more-areas-excluded-from-the-right-to-collective-protection>

temporary travel to Ukraine for status holders: they are now allowed to stay in the country for up to 15 days per six months instead of the previous 15 days per quarter.

In Canada, 2025 included the continuation of temporary measures regarding Ukrainians. However, there is also a trend in the country towards restricting the entry of immigrants through the introduction of legislative initiatives that could render the asylum acquisition process more difficult in the future (Bill C-12, Strengthening Canada's Immigration System and Borders Act, is being discussed as legislation bringing significant changes to the immigration system and asylum). One of the key innovations of the bill is the 'one-year rule.' If a person applies for asylum more than one year after entering Canada, their case will not be referred to the Immigration and Refugee Board of Canada. Instead, the application will go to an immigration officer for a pre-removal risk assessment, which usually means rejection³⁹. The Senate will vote on the bill in February 2026. It is noteworthy that in 2024, Canada deported 18,000 people – the highest number since Stephen Harper's government (2006–2015).

Thus, in 2025, many countries continue to support Ukrainians who are already in their territory or allow them to extend their stay with access to work, education and social services. At the same time, policies towards new applicants are becoming stricter or more differentiated, particularly due to the assessment of origin, stricter admission criteria and general trends towards restricting and controlling immigration flows.

In the United Kingdom, special mechanisms for Ukrainians were also phased out in 2024–2025. In particular, only one of the three existing programmes remained – Homes for Ukraine, while the Ukraine Family Scheme was closed on 19 February 2024 and the Ukraine Extension Scheme on 4 February 2025. At the same time, on 4 February 2025, the government introduced a new scheme, Ukraine Permission Extension (UPE), which allows holders of three-year Ukrainian visas to extend their stay for another 18 months. Thus, the overall focus of British policy is shifting from creating new humanitarian programmes to extending status only for those who are already in the country.

In 2025, many countries continue to support Ukrainians who are already there or allow them to extend their stay with access to work, education and social services. Policies towards new applicants are becoming stricter or more differentiated. The assessment of origin is being refined and admission criteria are becoming more stringent.

³⁹ [Canada bill targeting refugees feared to signal new era of US-style border policy](#)

5. WHO EXACTLY LEFT AND WHERE DID THEY GO? PROFILE OF UKRAINIAN REFUGEES

5.1. GENDER AND AGE STRUCTURE

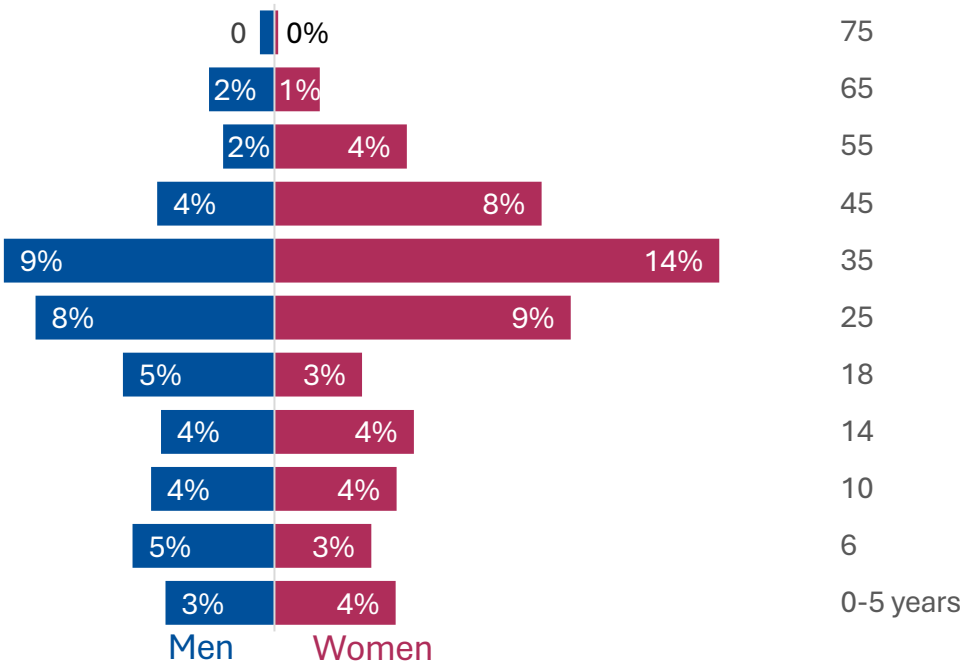
The gender and age structure of refugees has remained virtually unchanged since December 2024.

As before, the majority of Ukrainian refugees abroad are adult women. As of December 2025, they accounted for 40%, which is 4 percentage points lower than in December 2024, although this change is not statistically significant. At the same time, their share was 10 percentage points lower than at the beginning of 2024, when they accounted for 50% of the sample.

The share of adult men among refugees increased slightly, from 27% to 29% (Figure 5). Children under the age of 18 account for 31% of refugees.

Figure 5. Gender and age distribution of refugees

Children are almost a third of refugees

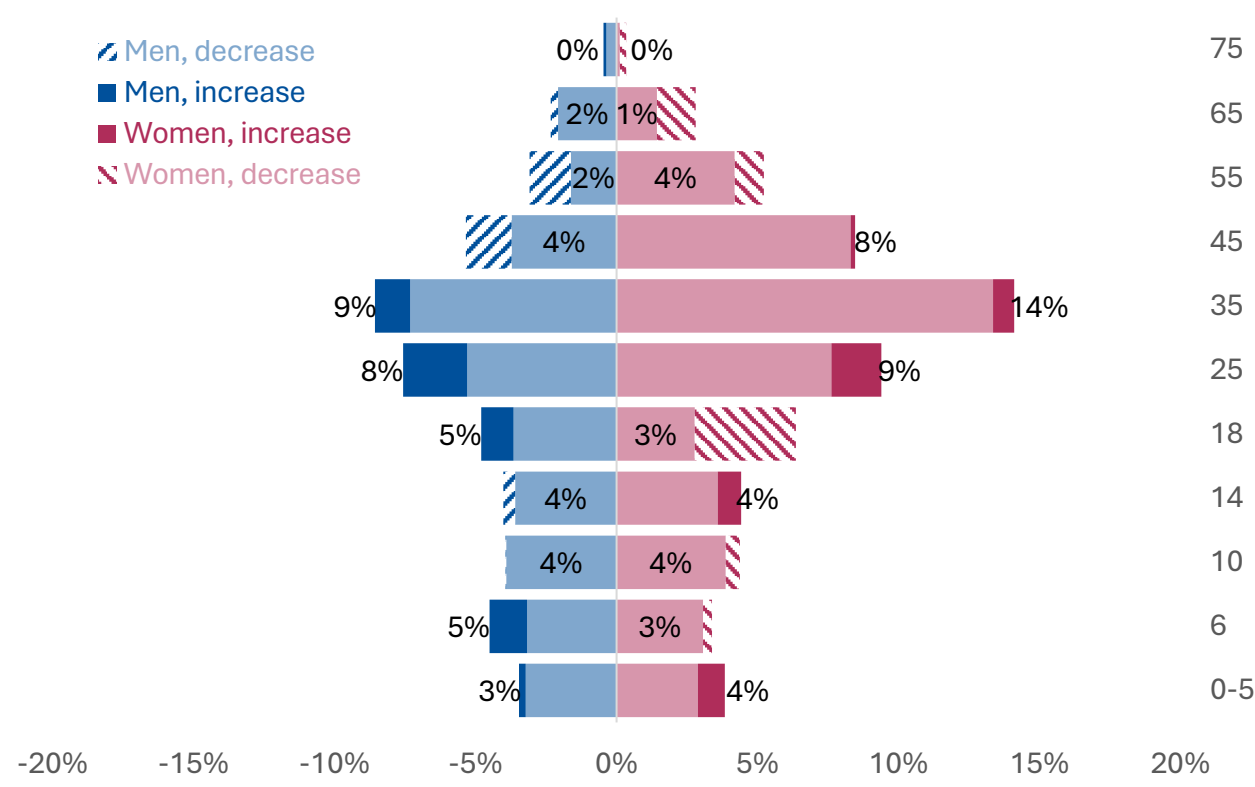


Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

The proportions of boys and girls among minors are almost equal – about 15%.

Changes over the past year also show a decrease in the proportion of refugees over 45 years of age. Such changes should certainly be interpreted with caution, but this coincides with the general trend of older Ukrainians being more inclined to return. Most likely, this also means that Ukrainians of this age are already beginning to return from abroad more actively.

Figure 6. Changes in the gender and age structure of refugees in December 2025–January 2026 compared to November–December 2024.



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2024 – January 2026.

37% of refugee families left with children under the age of 18 (Table1). In 2025, entire families with children were more active in leaving. They accounted for 26% of all those who left in 2025, compared to 17% in previous years.

Among households without children, people of working age who live alone or in pairs predominate. Most often, these are people over 35 who are not yet retired — they account for 21%. Another 17% are families with adult children (over 18).

Young people under 35 without children, living alone or in couples, make up 16% of refugees. In 2025, they began to leave more actively and accounted for 28% of all those who left that year.

Pensioners without children or other relatives make up 5% of refugee households. In total, pensioners make up about 9% of refugees, meaning that another 4% live in multi-generational households.

Table1 . Distribution of household types among Ukrainian refugees abroad

Household type	Prevalence among refugees
Over 35 years old without children	21%
Single-parent family with children under 18	19%
Complete family with children under 18 years of age	18%
Families with adult children	17%
Up to 35 years old without children	16%
Pensioners without children	5%
Other	5%

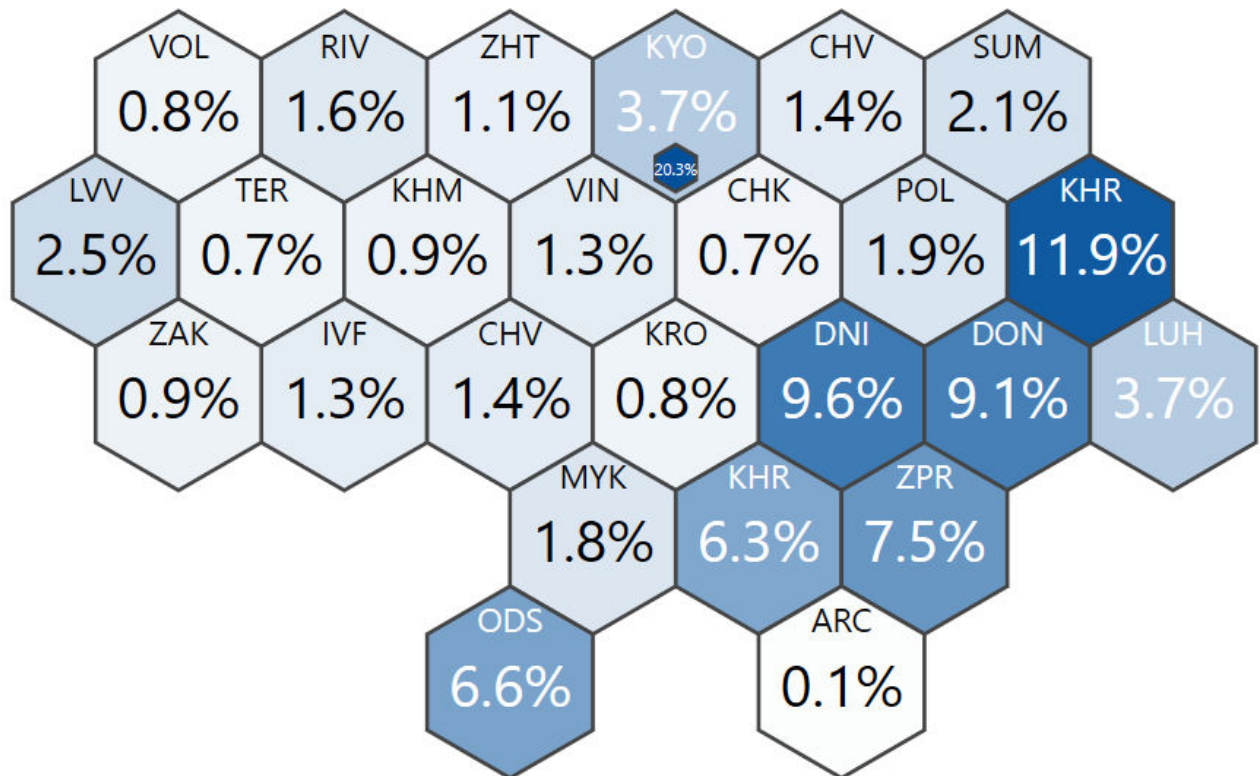
Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2024 – January 2026.

5.2. WHERE UKRAINIAN REFUGEES CAME FROM AND WHERE THEY MOVED TO

Before moving abroad, most refugees lived in Kyiv and the Kyiv region (24%), as well as in the eastern and southern regions, primarily in Kharkiv (12%), Dnipropetrovsk (10%), Donetsk (9%), Zaporizhzhia (7.5%), Odesa (7%) and Kherson (6%).

64% of refugees in Ukraine lived in large cities and regional centres: 20% in Kyiv, 11% in Kharkiv, 7% in Dnipro, and 6% in Odesa.

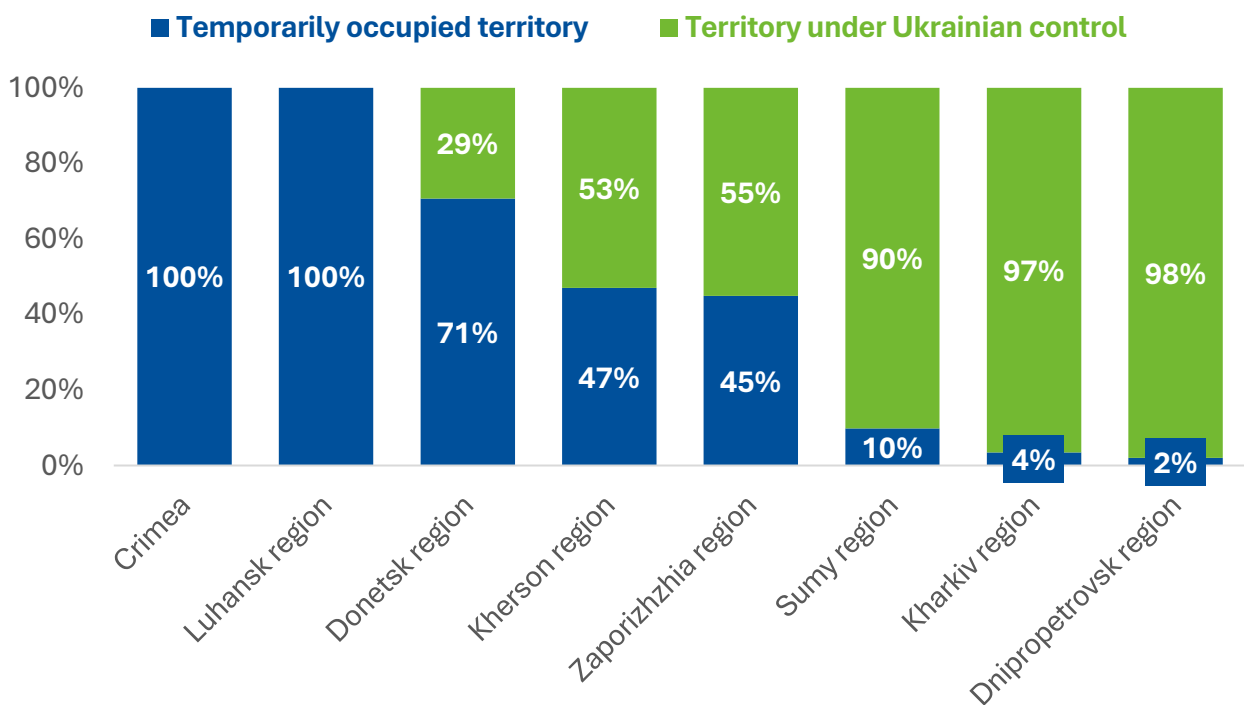
Figure7 . Distribution of refugees by regions in which they lived in Ukraine



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

17.5% of respondents left the temporarily occupied territory for abroad. The homes of 71% of all refugees from Donetsk region, 47% and 45% from Kherson and Zaporizhzhia regions, respectively, are under occupation.

Figure 8. Proportion of refugees who left occupied and Ukrainian-controlled territory



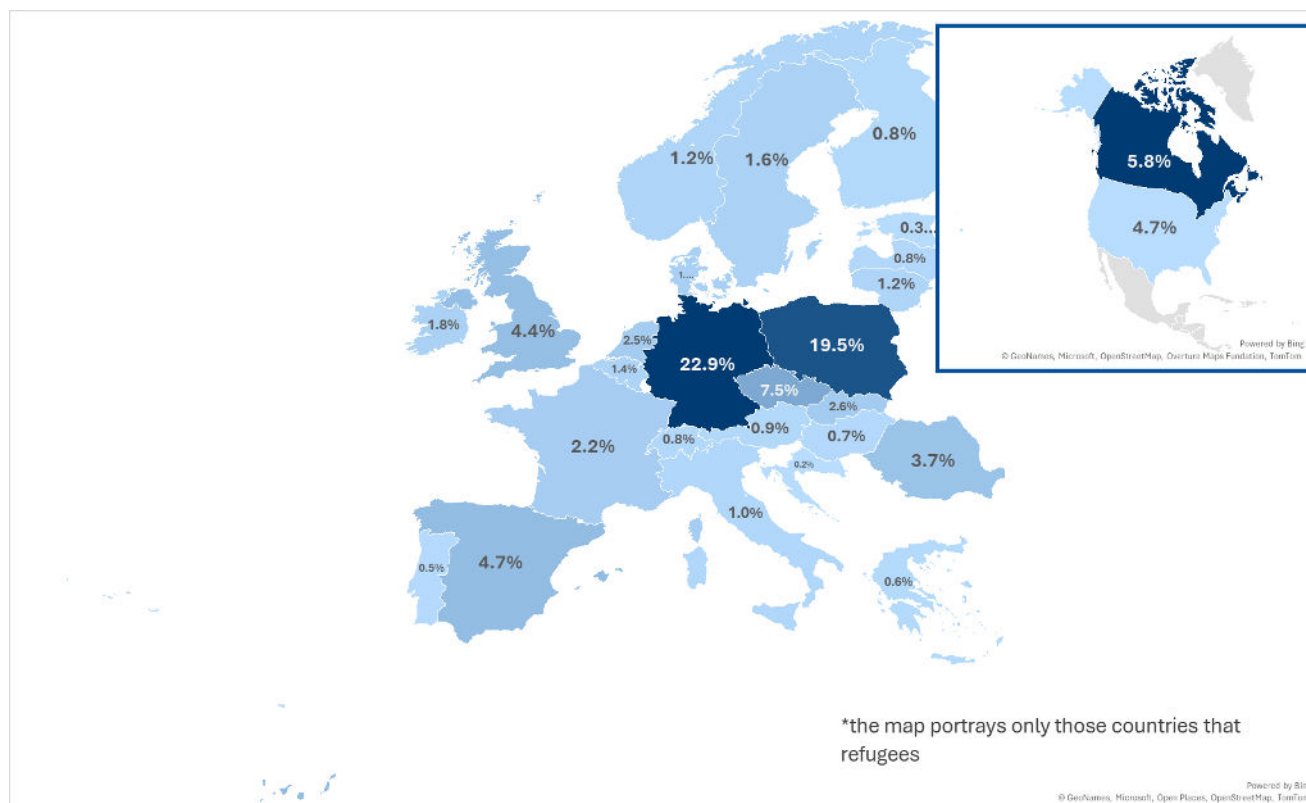
Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

The largest number of Ukrainian refugees currently live in Germany (23%) and Poland (19.5%) (Figure 9).

Germany is slightly more popular among young people under 35. It is home to 28% of refugees under 35 and 20% of refugees aged 35 and over.

Poland is more attractive to refugees aged 35-49: 24% of this age group live there. By comparison, only 15% of refugees under 35 and 18% of refugees over 49 live in this country.

Figure 9 . Distribution of refugees in Europe and North America



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

86% of the refugees surveyed lived in cities before leaving Ukraine, 8% in villages and 5% in urban-type settlements. Abroad, the proportion of Ukrainian refugees in cities is slightly higher – 89%, with 10% living in villages.

5.3. EDUCATION

As in previous waves of the study, the proportion of refugees surveyed who have higher education is extremely high. 71% have a bachelor's degree or higher, 36% have a master's degree or a scientific degree. This indicator is highest in the United Kingdom (81%) and the United States (78%).

Among refugees over the age of 24, 75% have higher education. Young people under the age of 25 most often continue their education while abroad. 57% of them are currently studying: 35% in educational institutions in their country of residence, 23% online in Ukrainian educational institutions. 14% combine education and work.

5.4. EMPLOYMENT BEFORE MOVING FROM UKRAINE

Among those surveyed, 71% were employed in Ukraine (full-time/part-time and self-employed). Another 11% were not working for various reasons, almost 10% were pupils or students, and 8% were pensioners or disabled. 1.3% were both working and studying. The employment rate of refugees before the war remains roughly the same as in previous waves of the study – approximately 70%.

According to the State Statistics Service of Ukraine, the employment rate of the population over 15 years of age in Ukraine in 2021 was 49.3%. Thus, refugees were a population group with a significantly higher employment rate than the national average.

About 15% of respondents had experience living and/or working abroad before Russia's full-scale invasion. In 2021, almost 5% of current refugees worked abroad, with the majority living in Germany, Poland, Romania and the United Kingdom (57%).

5.5. ECONOMIC SITUATION BEFORE MOVING FROM UKRAINE

Ukrainian refugees generally had a high level of economic well-being before moving from Ukraine. Only 14% were forced to save on food or clothing and footwear, while 43% could afford to buy expensive items. This applies to both those who left at the beginning of the war and those who left later.

The level of economic well-being of refugees is significantly higher than the average for Ukraine. According to data from the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology,⁴⁰ in 2022-23, the proportion of people in Ukraine who did not have enough money for food, clothing or footwear was around 40%, while the proportion of those who could afford expensive items was just over 20%. Therefore, people with a better economic situation are more likely to leave Ukraine.

⁴⁰ <https://kiis.com.ua/?lang=ukr&cat=reports&id=1256&page=1>

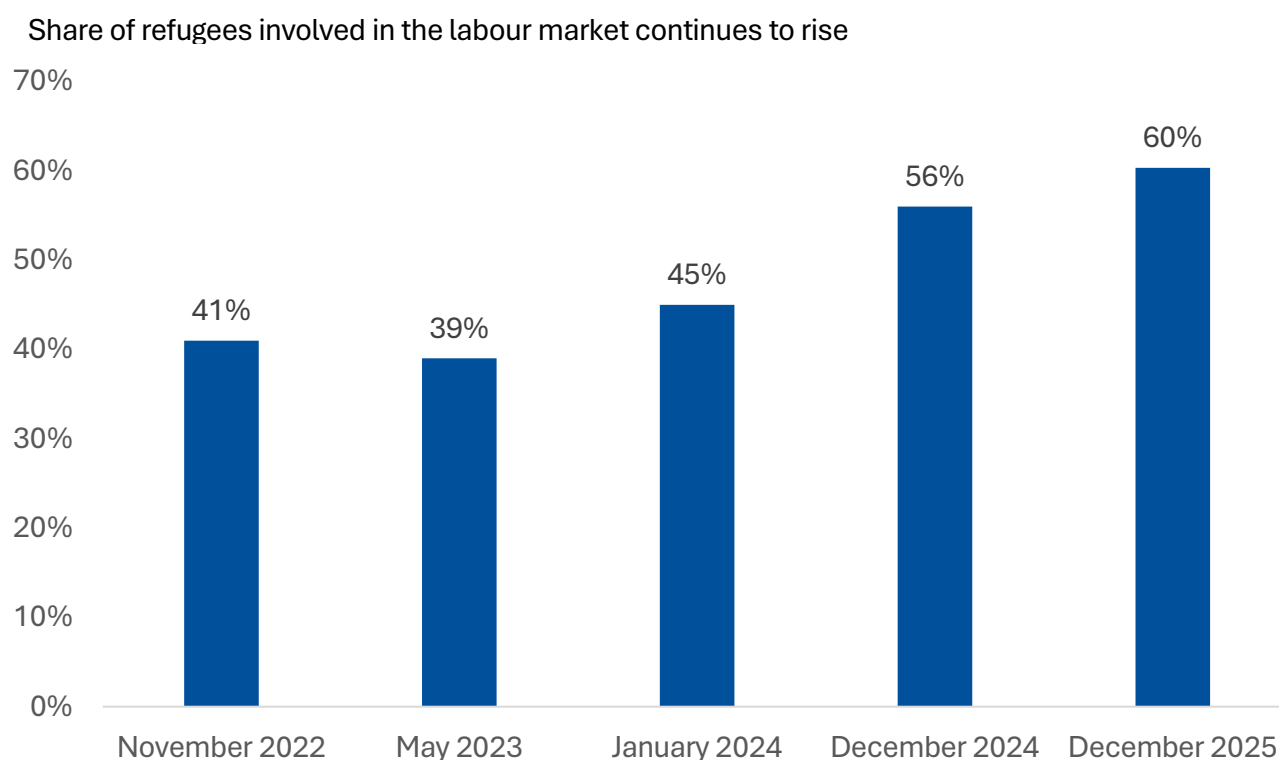
6. HOW DO UKRAINIAN REFUGEES LIVE?

6.1. ECONOMIC SITUATION AND INTEGRATION

Among the refugees surveyed, 60% are employed, which is 11 percentage points lower than the employment rate before they left Ukraine.

20% of refugees over the age of 18 are studying (14% are students who are not working), 10% are unemployed (looking for work), 7% are not working and not looking for work, and 7% are retired and not working.

Figure 10 . Proportion of employed persons and entrepreneurs among Ukrainian refugees by survey wave



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES.

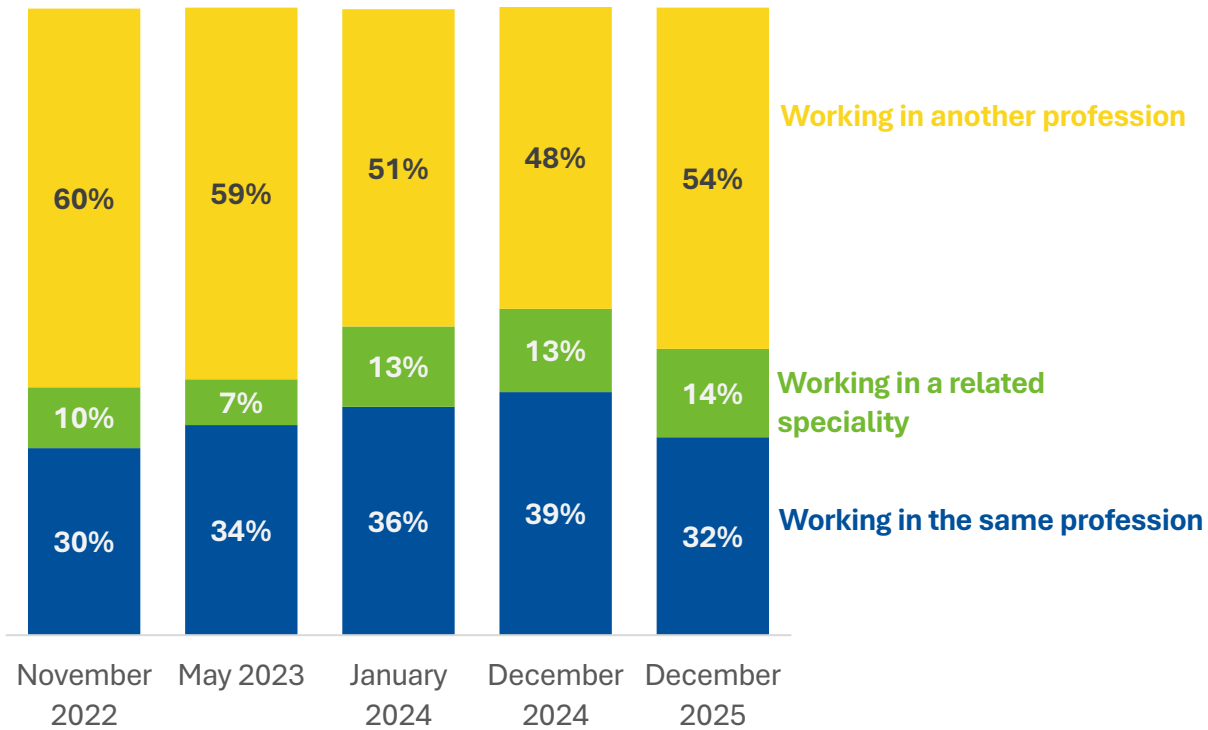
The professional skills of Ukrainian refugees abroad remain underutilised.

Among those who worked in Ukraine and work abroad, 54% work in a profession different from the one they had in Ukraine. Only a third work in the same profession, and 14% work in a related profession (Figure 11). Compared to the results of our survey a year ago, the proportion of those working in the same profession has decreased slightly, which is mainly explained by a change in the methodology of recruiting respondents. In practical terms, it can be said that the changes over the year have been insignificant.

Refugees with a master's degree or a scientific degree have a higher chance of working in their profession (42% of them currently work in their profession). Among those with a lower level of education, only 24% are employed in their profession.

Knowledge of the language of the host country also has a strong influence on the type of work refugees can get: 48% of those with a B2 level or higher work in the same profession as in Ukraine.

Figure 11 . Responses of employed refugees to the question "Are you working in the same profession as before the war?"



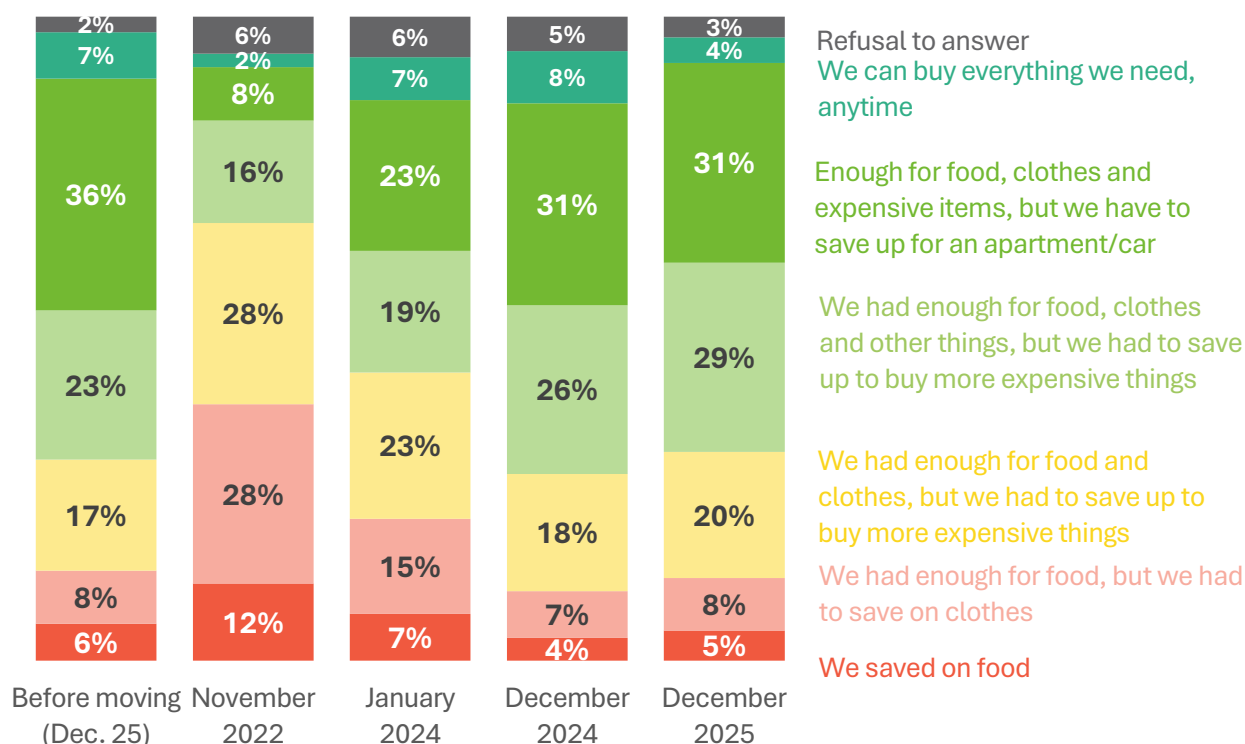
Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

Almost 36.5% of employed respondents rate their current job as easier than the one they had in Ukraine. Another 36% rate them as equally difficult, and only 17% consider their new job to be more difficult.

Among those who are not working, 30% have been unable to find any job. Other frequently cited reasons include a lack of job options in their field (33%), jobs that match their experience and qualifications (29%), and jobs with sufficient pay (27%). 19% are not working due to health reasons, including psychological health, and 10% due to the need to care for children and other relatives.

Figure12 . Self-assessment of economic situation by survey wave

The economic situation stabilised at levels close to migration



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES.

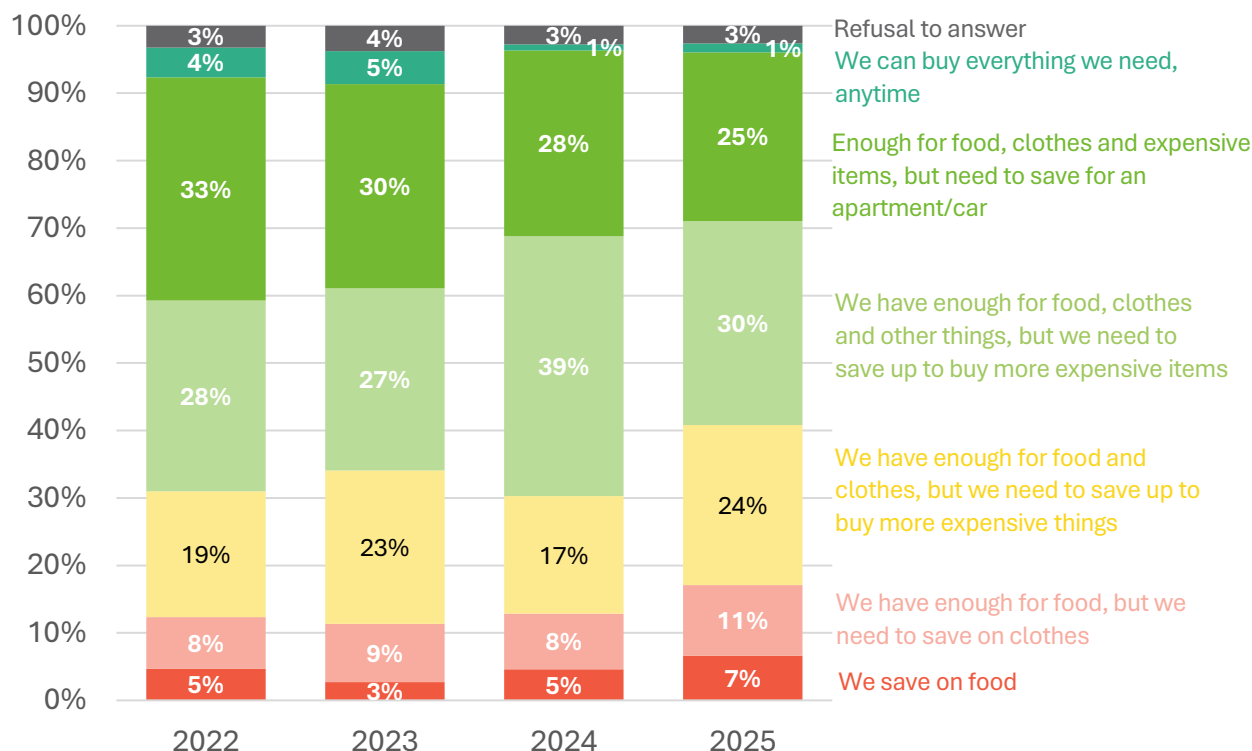
The economic situation of Ukrainian refugees has also stabilised (Figure12). There have been no significant changes compared to 2024. The category of people who can buy everything they need at any time has decreased slightly (from 8% in 2024 to 4% in 2025). **However, even with this change, current refugees are significantly wealthier than those we surveyed in November 2022, when 12% were saving on food and 28% had to save on clothing and footwear.**

Only 13% of refugees in December 2025 saved on food or clothing and footwear. This was most often mentioned by respondents aged 50 and over: 23% of them have to save on these items.

The current standard of living of refugees is slightly lower than their standard of living in Ukraine. Before moving, 43% could buy expensive items or anything they wanted, compared to 35% now. On the other hand, the proportion of those with an average income (enough for clothes and food, but having to save on more expensive items) has increased abroad: 29% compared to 23% when they lived in Ukraine. The decline in living standards is most often observed among refugees over the age of 50.

6.1.1. ECONOMIC SITUATION BY YEAR OF DEPARTURE

Figure13 . Self-assessment of economic situation by year of departure



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

The length of stay abroad has a positive impact on the financial situation of refugees. Ukrainian refugees who left in 2022-23 currently have the best economic situation.

Those who left in 2025 are the least well-off: 7% save on food, 11% save on clothing, and 24% have enough money to buy food and clothing but have to save on more expensive items (Figure13).

6.1.2. BUDGET STRUCTURE

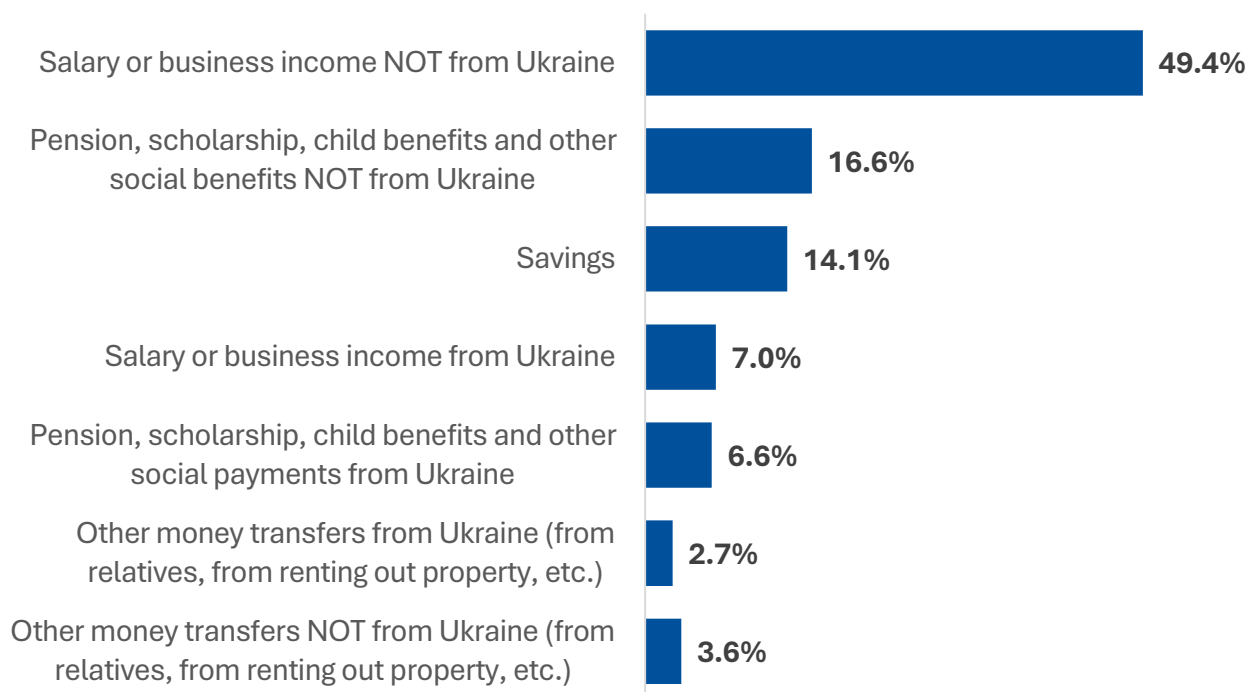
For the first time in this survey, we also asked refugees about the structure of their budget.

Different groups of refugees rely on different sources of income. For example, 59% of Ukrainian refugees have salaries or business income abroad as part of their budget. 32% rely, to varying degrees, on savings. 27% rely on local social benefits and 16% rely on social/pension benefits from Ukraine in their budgets. About 8% of Ukrainian refugees also receive money transfers from Ukraine (from relatives, rental income, etc.). Another 7% rely on transfers from other countries. Also, 12% receive salaries or business income from Ukraine while abroad. The sum of the percentages above exceeds 100 because a significant proportion of refugees rely on more than one source of income – 43% of respondents indicated two or more sources of family budget income.

One way to examine the structure of Ukrainian refugees' family budgets is to look at a "typical" budget. The shares of each item in Figure14 can be interpreted as the average expected share of the corresponding item – since we do not have information on refugees' income in monetary terms, these columns are not weighted by the amount of income from the corresponding source.

The "average" refugee relies on wages or entrepreneurial income abroad for almost half (49%) of their income. The second most important source is social benefits abroad and savings. A typical Ukrainian refugee household relies on these sources of income for 17% and 14% of their income, respectively. As expected, income and remittances from Ukraine play a much smaller role. Although there are refugees who rely on income from work in Ukraine, this is not typical.

Figure14 . Budget structure (sources of expenditure) of a typical Ukrainian refugee family budget



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026, CES calculations.

Representative shares are calculated as the arithmetic mean for each source from the entire sample. Each respondent has equal weight.

We also analysed the role of each item for those who receive it. This gives us a better idea of how important each of these sources of income is. These results are presented at Figure15 . The width of each bar in this figure reflects the relative popularity of this item in refugee households' incomes, and the height reflects how much recipients of this income rely on the corresponding source.

Refugees already employed abroad hardly rely on other sources of income. On average, only 16% of their income comes from sources other than wages (most often from savings). Those who still have income from wages or entrepreneurship in Ukraine usually have a significantly higher share of other income sources – wages from Ukraine account for an average of 59% of their income. They also often receive wages abroad, which account for an average of 18% of their income.

For recipients of social benefits abroad, these payments are often critically important. If payments are cancelled, such refugees will lose an average of 61% of their budget. Most often, pensioners (on average, 29% of their monthly budget), single-parent families with children (20% of their budget) and young people under 35 living alone (19%) rely on social benefits from their country of residence.

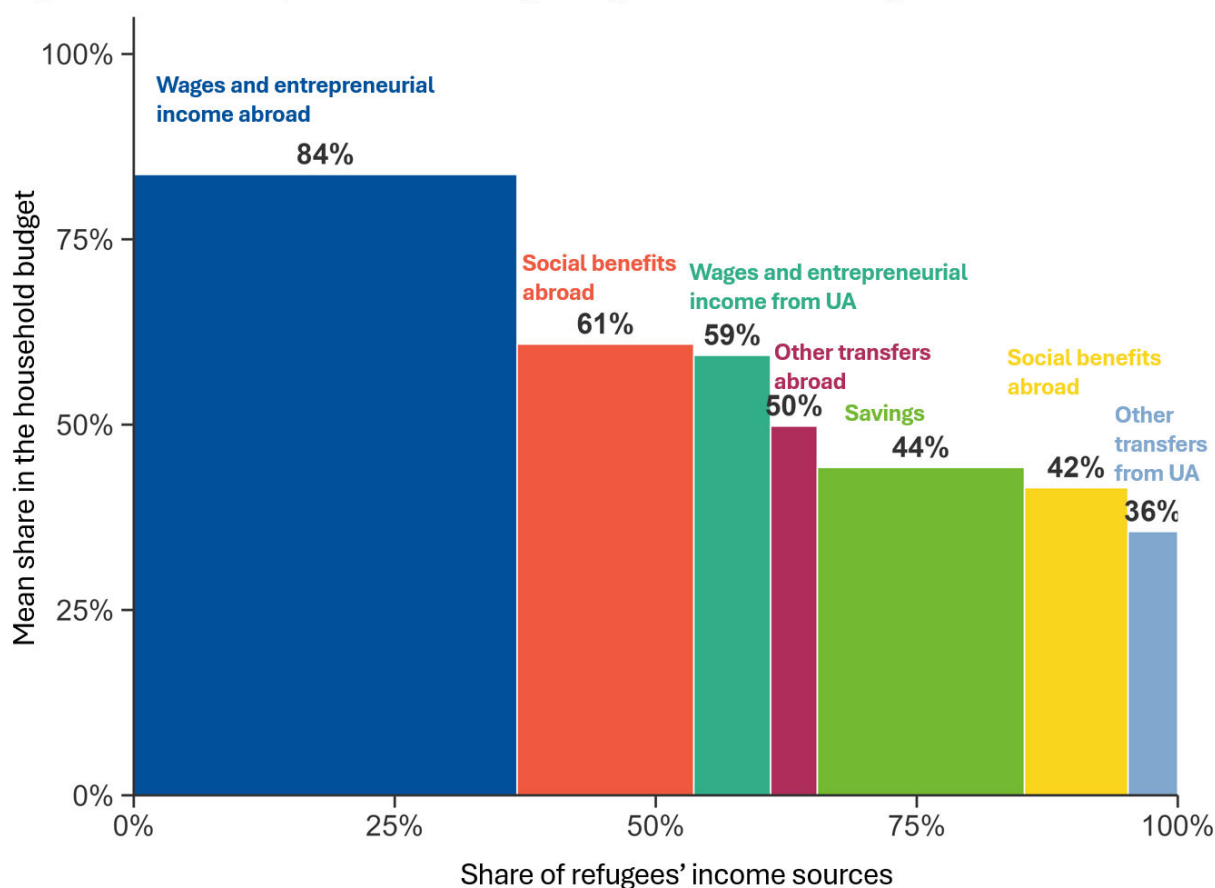
Pensioners abroad also depend on pensions from Ukraine. On average, it accounts for 39% of their monthly income abroad, which is a larger share than social benefits from the host country, i.e. 29% of

income. For other categories of the population, social benefits from Ukraine account for only a small share of the budget. For example, for families with children, they account for only 3-5% of income.

A significant proportion of Ukrainians abroad rely on savings in their lives, which is not a sustainable or long-term financial solution. At the same time, for those who rely on savings, they constitute a significant part of their monthly budget – 44%.

Figure15 . Proportion of income sources in the budget of those receiving each category of income

Wages abroad make up 84% of the average budget for those receiving them



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

The width of the columns reflects the prevalence of each category of income sources among the sample. The total width of all categories is reduced to 100%, taking into account the possibility of selecting several options.

The financial situation of Ukrainian refugees abroad often allows them to financially support their relatives in Ukraine. 38% of refugees send financial assistance to Ukraine, which is about half of those who have relatives in Ukraine. Among refugees who have children left in Ukraine, this figure is significantly higher, at 62%.

By comparison, only 8% of refugees receive remittances from Ukraine. Most often, these are single-parent families with children (14% receive money from Ukraine, probably from a partner who remained in Ukraine) or young people under 35 who live alone (10% receive money from Ukraine).

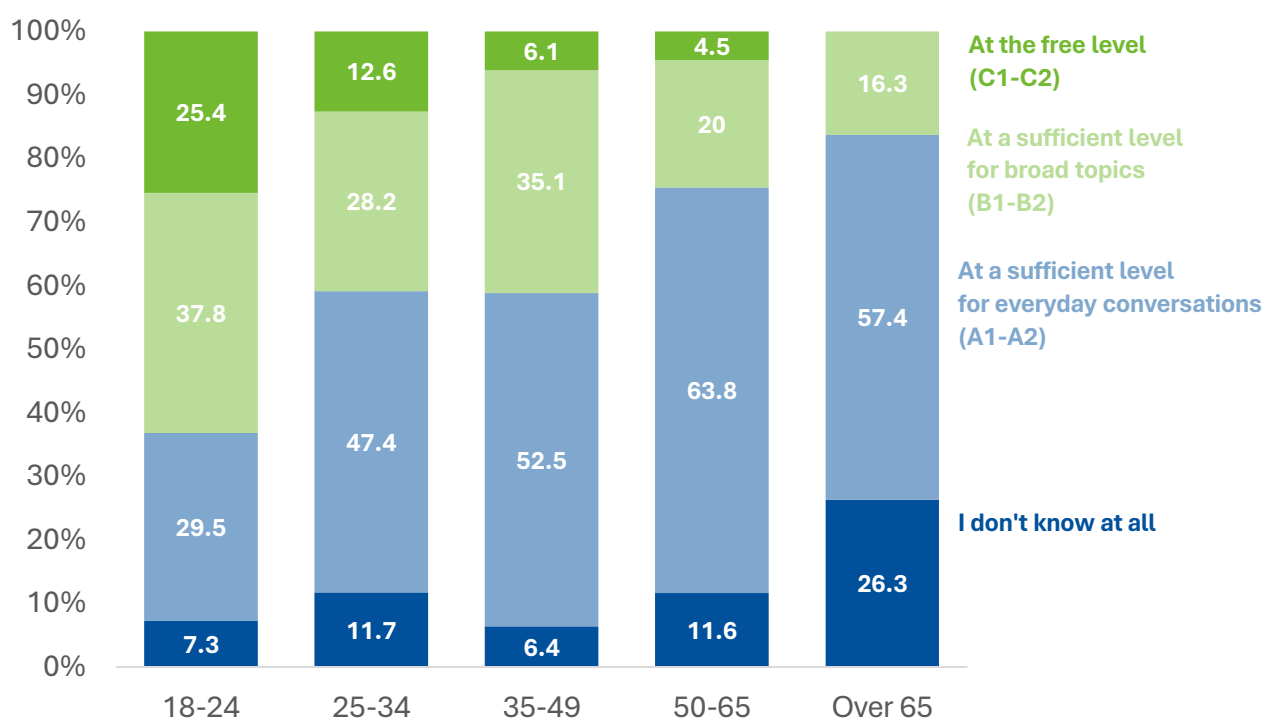
6.2. SOCIAL INTEGRATION

6.2.1. LANGUAGE PROFICIENCY

Almost 10% of Ukrainian refugees do not understand the local language at all, and about half (51%) know it at a minimal level, i.e. A1-A2. Language proficiency is more common among young people aged 18 to 24, 62% of whom are fluent or can communicate on a wide range of topics (Figure 16). More than half of refugees in other age groups have a minimal knowledge of the language or no knowledge at all.

The level of knowledge of the country's language also depends on the time of relocation. Among those who left in 2022, 47% already have a B1 level or higher (can communicate on a wide range of topics), 46% know the language at a minimum level or enough to converse on simple topics (A1-A2), and only 7% do not know it at all. Among those who arrived in 2025, 35% do not know the language of the country at all, and only 12% can communicate on a wide range of topics or are fluent in it.

Figure 16. Knowledge of the language of the host country by age



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

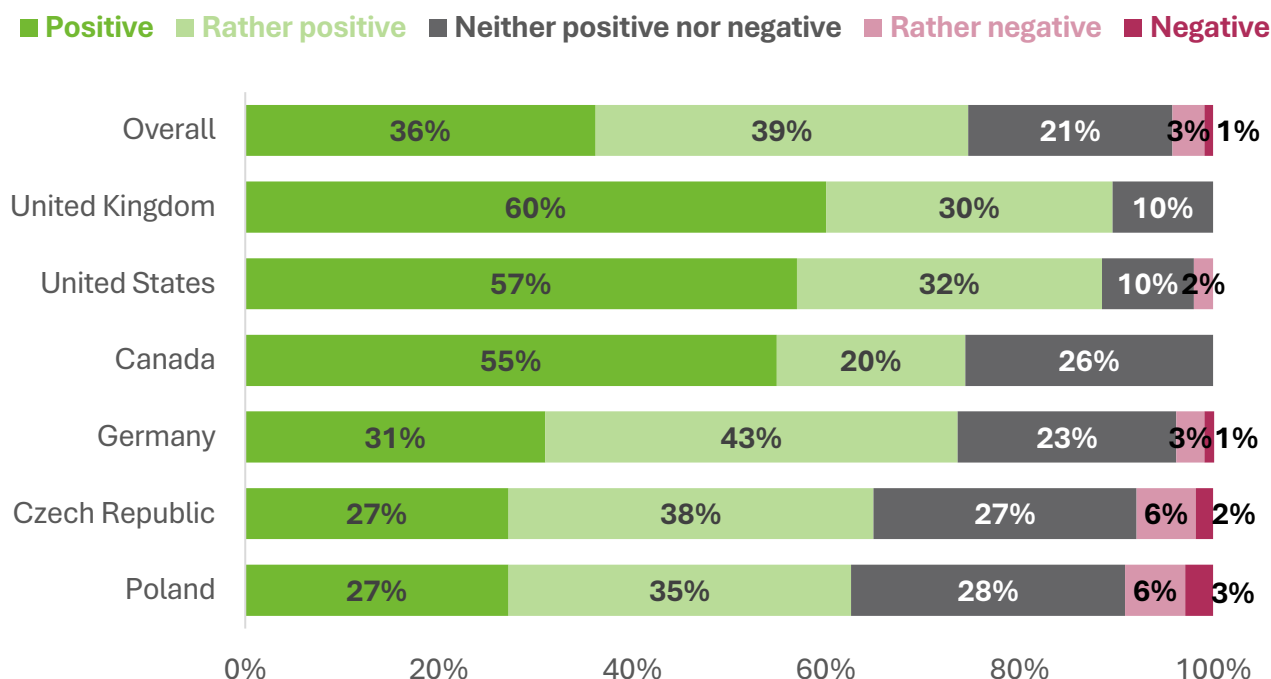
6.2.2. SOCIAL TIES

In general, refugees assess the attitude of local residents towards them positively. 75% assess the attitude towards them as positive or rather positive, and only 4% as negative or rather negative (Figure 17). As was the case a year ago, refugees in Europe were more likely to experience negativity or ambivalence from local residents than refugees in the United States, Canada and the United Kingdom.

Young people are slightly less confident about the positive attitude of local residents towards them. 69% of refugees aged 18-24 rate the attitude towards them as positive or somewhat positive, compared to 90% among those over 65.

Ukrainian refugees' intentions to return to Ukraine are largely unrelated to their assessment of local residents' attitudes. Those who definitely do not plan to return are slightly more likely to rate attitudes towards them as positive or somewhat positive (82%). No other differences in ratings were found among other groups.

Figure17 . Refugees' assessment of local residents' attitudes towards them



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

Almost 83% of Ukrainians abroad have social connections in their new country. At the same time, 78% have friends among the local population (most often met after moving). Another 73% have friends among other Ukrainians and 31% among other migrants. Only 10% have no friends in their new country.

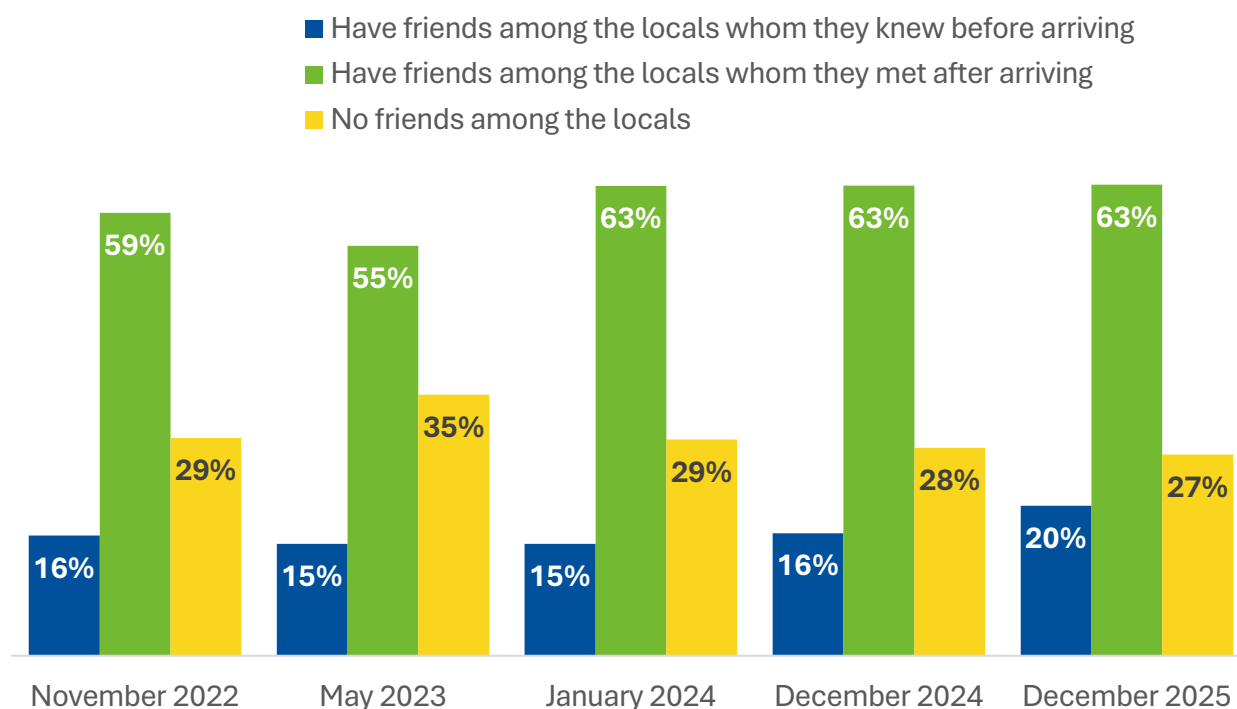
20% of refugees had acquaintances among local residents prior to relocation. 63% of refugees found friends among locals only after moving (Figure18).

Older refugees are slightly more likely to be friends with Ukrainians abroad. 88% of those over 65 have friends among Ukrainians. Young people under 35 are more likely than other age groups to be friends with other migrants (non-Ukrainians): 41% have such friends, compared to 26% among other refugees.

The time spent abroad also has an impact on the social circle of refugees. Only 7% of those who moved in 2022 do not have friends in their country of residence and are more likely to already have friends among the locals (79% compared to 73% on average). In contrast, 27% of those who moved in 2025 do not yet have friends or good acquaintances abroad.

Figure18 . Response to the question "Do you have friends/good acquaintances among local refugees (non-Ukrainians)?"

Almost a third of Ukrainians abroad consistently do not socialise with locals



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

6.2.3. DIFFICULTIES ENCOUNTERED ABROAD

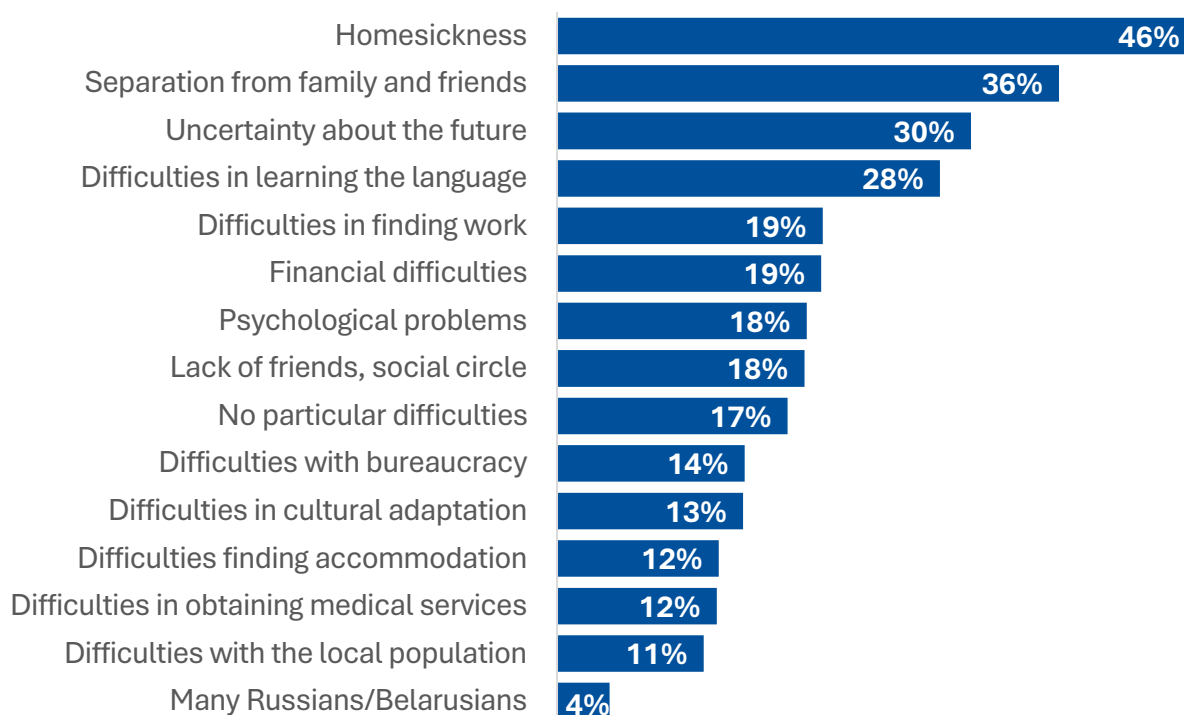
Changing country of residence and staying abroad for a long time is accompanied by a number of difficulties. Only 17% of Ukrainian refugees abroad say they do not have any particular difficulties in their country of residence. At the same time, the main difficulties that can "push" them out of their new country are emotional factors – homesickness and separation from loved ones, which are faced by 46% and 36% of Ukrainian refugees, respectively.

Among the most frequently mentioned difficulties faced by Ukrainian refugees is uncertainty about the future, including legal problems. 30% of the problems mentioned are difficulties in learning a new language (28%), finding a job and financial difficulties (19% each).

Men are twice as likely to report no particular difficulties compared to women (24% vs. 12%). Women are much more likely to feel sad and worried about their homeland and home (53% versus 36% among men), find it harder to cope with separation from family and friends (40% versus 31%), worry about the uncertainty of the future (33% versus 25%), and report difficulties in learning the language (30% vs. 24%), finding work (22% vs. 15%) and housing (14% vs. 8%), financial difficulties (21% vs. 16%) and difficulties in accessing medical services (14% vs. 9%). Men are slightly more likely to have difficulties adapting to the culture of their new country (16% compared to 12% of women) and interacting with the local population (13% compared to 9%).

Young people under the age of 25 are less likely to have difficulties learning the language of their host country (15% compared to 27% on average among all refugees) but are twice as likely to report psychological problems (36% compared to 18%) and difficulties interacting with the local population (20% compared to 11%). Refugees under the age of 35 are more likely than older refugees to have difficulties adapting to the culture of their new country (21% compared to 9%). Refugees over the age of 50 are more likely than others to feel sadness and anxiety about their homeland (60% compared to 43% among younger refugees).

Figure 19 . Answers to the question "What difficulties are you personally facing in your host country? Select up to 5 of the biggest difficulties."



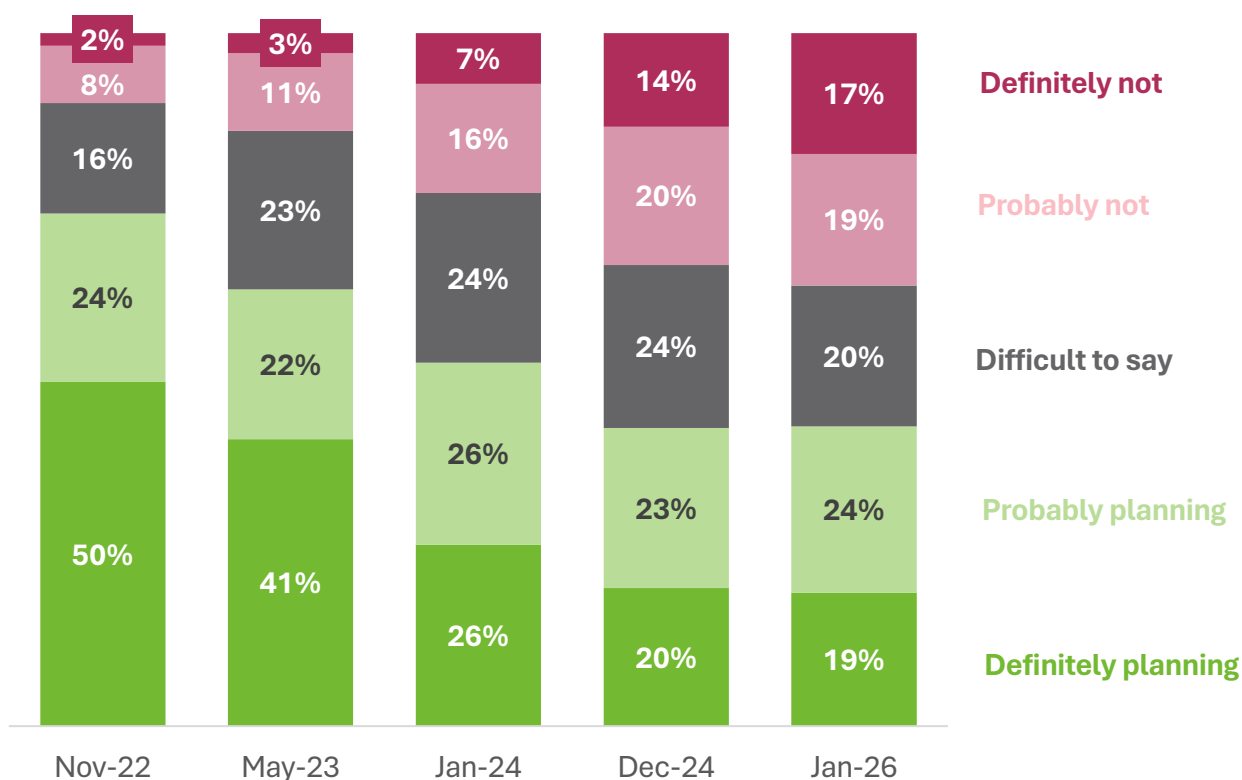
Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.
Each respondent could select more than one answer, so the percentage of responses exceeds 100%.

7. DO UKRAINIANS PLAN TO RETURN?

7.1. UKRAINIANS' PLANS TO RETURN TO UKRAINE

As of early 2026, about 43% of refugees intend to return to Ukraine, and 36% do not plan/are unlikely to plan to return. If during the previous waves of this study there was a trend of decreasing the share of refugees planning to return, in this wave of the survey, the share of refugees intending to return remained at 43%. The share of refugees inclined not to return has also not undergone significant changes.

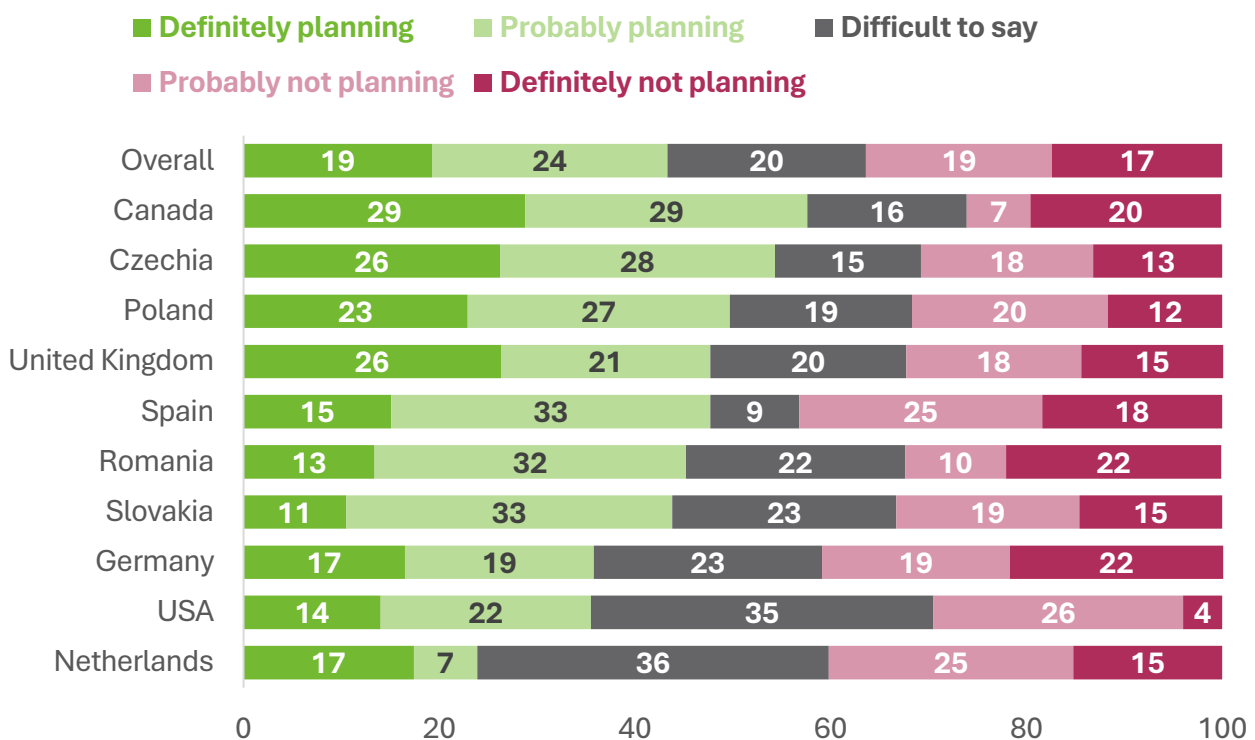
Figure 20. Intentions to return to Ukraine by waves of research



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES.

Among those willing to return to Ukraine, almost 80% are ready to come back only after the war has completely ended. As a specific point in time, the possible signing of a document that would allow the resumption of civilian flights over Ukraine has been chosen.

Figure 21. Intentions to return to Ukraine by country of residence, %

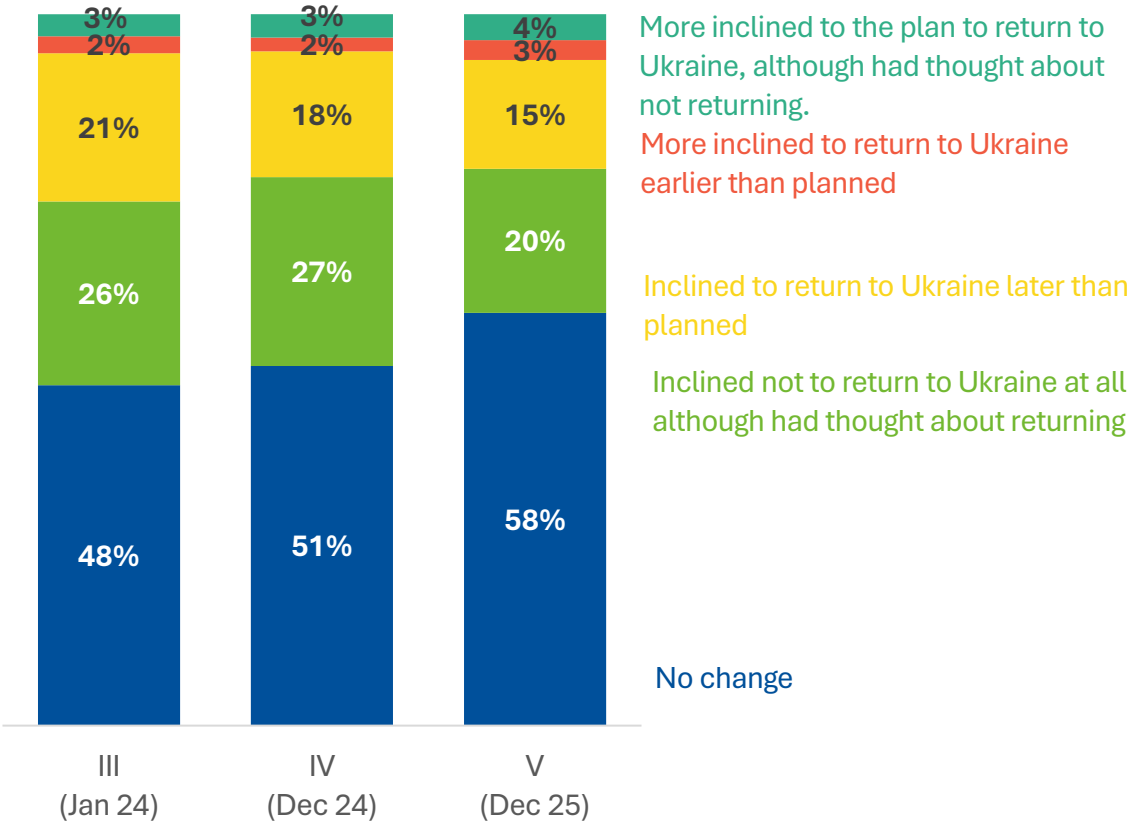


Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025-January 2026

In the Czech Republic and Canada, more than half of the refugees intend to return to Ukraine. In the Netherlands (~24%), the USA (35%), and Germany (36%), refugees express the least willingness to return (Figure 21).

Among the respondents, 58% have not changed their opinion about returning over the past year. More than 20% have started to lean more towards the idea of not returning to Ukraine at all, and 15% towards returning later than they had previously expected. Only 6% are now more inclined to return than a year ago.

Figure 22. Response to the question "Have your intentions regarding returning to Ukraine changed compared to your intentions a year ago?" over the years of the study Answer to the question "Have your intentions regarding returning to Ukraine changed compared to your intentions a year ago?" by year waves of the study, %



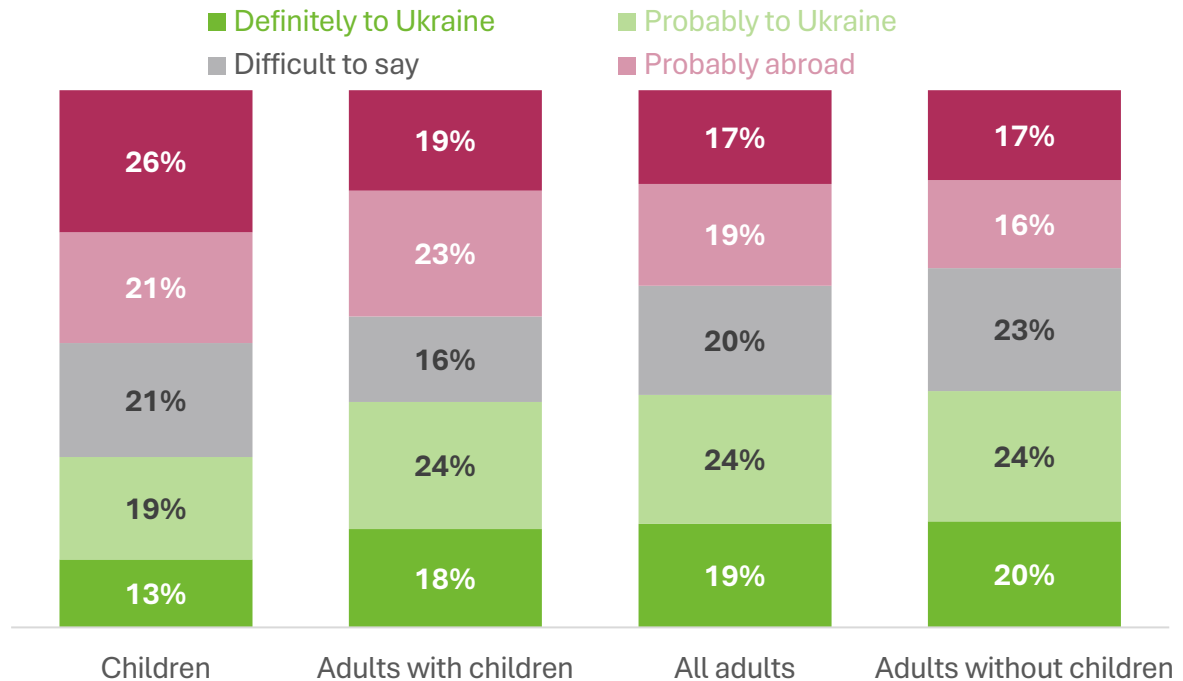
Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025-January 2026

Of those who left Ukraine for abroad in 2022-2024, on average, 20% changed their minds in favour of not returning to Ukraine at all (Figure 22). Those who left Ukraine in 2024 were the most likely to postpone their return – nearly 21%.

7.2. ARE THE CHILDREN OF UKRAINIAN REFUGEES PLANNING TO RETURN TO UKRAINE?

Figure 23. Answer to the question "Does your child want to return to Ukraine or stay abroad?" and to the question "Do you plan to return to Ukraine?"

Parents say that their children are, on average, less willing to return

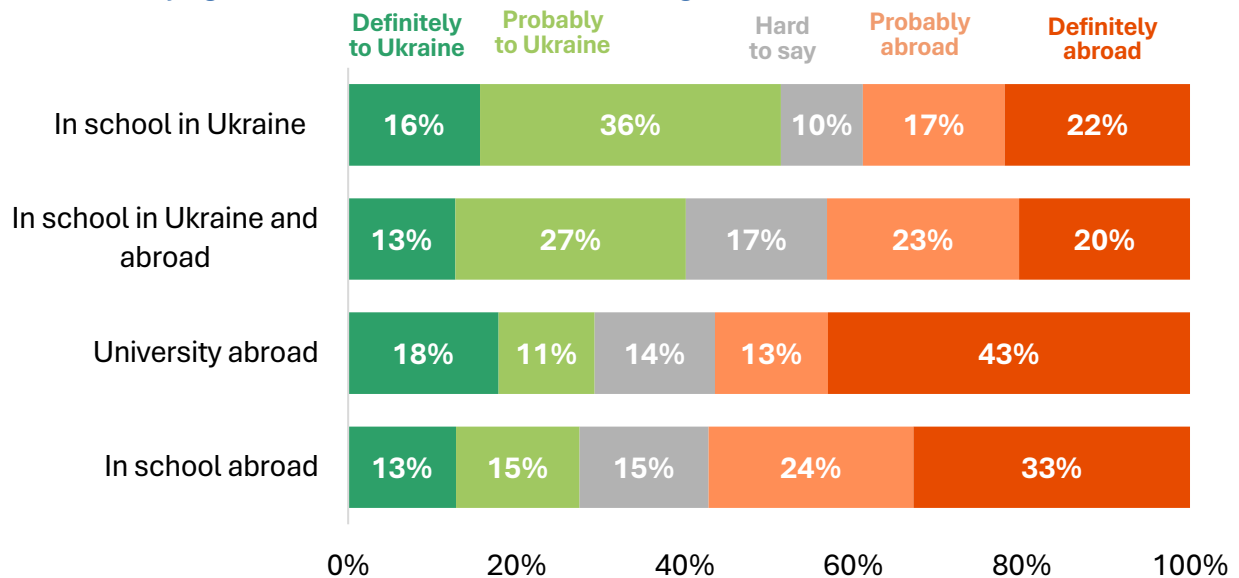


Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025-January 2026.

Refugees who left with children assess their intentions to return to Ukraine more pessimistically than adult refugees in general. 47% of parents believe that their children will not return, while among adults, 36% do not plan to return. Another 21% are undecided, and 32% believe that their children will return to Ukraine (among adults, 43% plan to return) (Figure 23). Refugees who left with children assess their intentions to return to Ukraine more pessimistically than adult refugees in general. 47% of parents believe that their children will not return, while among adults, 36% do not plan to return. Another 21% are undecided, and 32% believe that their children will return to Ukraine (among adults, 43% plan to return) (Figure 23).

Figure 24. Answer to the question "Does your child want to return to Ukraine or stay abroad?" distributed by the child's place of study

Children studying in Ukrainian schools are more willing to return

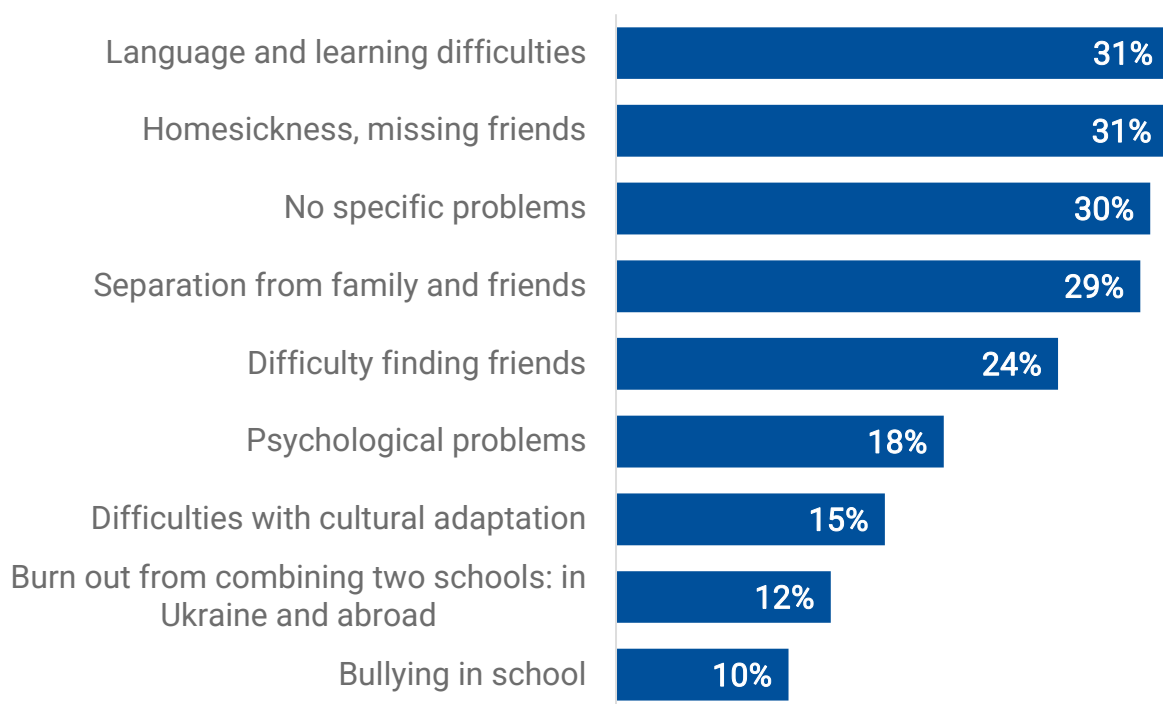


Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025-January 2026

Parents of children who continue their education in Ukrainian educational institutions more often believe that their children will return to Ukraine: more than half of those whose children study only in a Ukrainian school remotely believe that their children will return. Those whose children study in schools both abroad and in Ukraine at the same time have approximately an equal distribution: 40% plan to return to Ukraine, 43% do not plan to return (Figure 24).

The most convinced that their children will stay abroad are the parents of students at foreign universities: 43% of them believe that their children will definitely not return. Those whose children study in secondary schools abroad and are not included in the Ukrainian education system are the least likely to believe that their children will return: more than half of these respondents, that is, 57%, think that their children do not plan to return to Ukraine.

Figure 20. Difficulties faced by children of Ukrainian refugees



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

Among the main problems faced by children of Ukrainian refugees abroad (as assessed by their parents) are difficulties in learning the language of the country and using it in education, as well as homesickness for their homeland, home and friends (chosen by 31% of parents), and separation from family and friends (29%). Almost a quarter (24%) have difficulty finding friends and forming a social circle in their new country. 18% of parents report psychological problems in their children. Only 30% of parents said that their children did not experience any significant difficulties in their new country.

7.2. WHERE ARE UKRAINIAN REFUGEES WILLING TO RETURN?

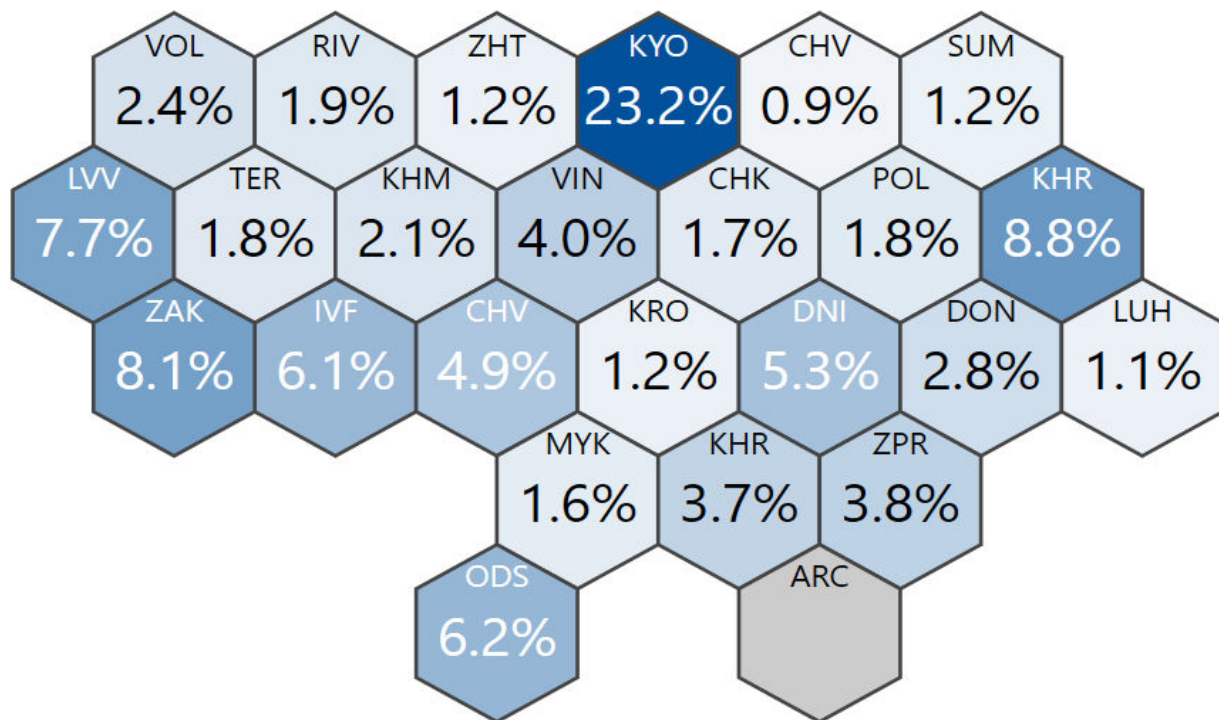
We asked Ukrainians abroad which regions they would consider returning to. Most often, the refugees surveyed chose Kyiv and the Kyiv region – in 23% of cases. This is partly due to the fact that a significant proportion of refugees (about 24%) come from Kyiv and the Kyiv region and want to return home. Also, among those who are no longer ready to return to their homes due to destruction or occupation, it probably makes more sense to choose Kyiv and the Kyiv region as an economic centre to maximise their well-being and opportunities.

The leaders also include relatively safe regions in western Ukraine – Lviv (7.7%), Zakarpattia (8.1%), and Ivano-Frankivsk (6.1%) – regions that are furthest from the fighting.

The leaders also include the Kharkiv region – 8.8% of refugees are ready to return here, Odesa – 6.2% and Dnipropetrovsk – 5.3%. Their attractiveness is partly explained by the large number of people who left these regions because of the war but would like to return home.

33% of refugees are only willing to return to the region they left and are not willing to consider other regions of Ukraine.

Figure23 . Answers to the question "If you decided to return to Ukraine, which regions would you consider returning to?": the proportion of refugees who chose the corresponding region



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

The question was asked to 82.6% of refugees – all except those who said they "definitely do not plan" to return to Ukraine. Kyiv is included in the Kyiv region.

The choice of regions for return is not entirely determined by the perception of their level of security, despite the importance of this factor for return in general. For example, refugees consider the safest regions to be Zakarpattia (30% of respondents), Chernivtsi (18%), Ivano-Frankivsk (18%) and Lviv (15%) regions. Only 3% consider Kyiv and the Kyiv region, where the largest number of refugees would like to return, to be safe.

The difference between the willingness to return to a region and the perception of its safety can be explained by the fact that most refugees are willing to return after the war has completely ended, when it will be safe in all regions. Currently, 42% of refugees believe that there are no safe regions in Ukraine at present.

If they return to Ukraine, about half of the refugees surveyed (47%) would only consider a large city or regional centre, while 22% would be willing to consider both a large city and a small town, such as a district centre. Only 14% would be willing to consider a village or small town.

7.3. WHY ARE UKRAINIAN REFUGEES NOT RETURNING?

In December 2025 – January 2026, as part of the current wave of research, we also asked Ukrainian refugees what exactly is preventing them from returning to Ukraine. The results indicate that the decision to stay abroad is multifactorial, but security risks remain key.

The main barrier is the war and fear for themselves and their loved ones, as stated by almost 60% of respondents (Table 2). The second most important factor is power outages and other problems with communal infrastructure (41%). The third is mobilisation (29%).

For men and young people under 35, mobilisation ranks second in importance after war and security risks (45%).

Table 2 . What prevents Ukrainian refugees from returning to their homeland: age distribution

Barrier	18-24	25-34	35-49	50-65	65+	Overall
War	58%	60%	60%	53%	47%	58%
Blackouts	39%	45%	41%	37%	35%	41%
Mobilisation of men	46%	44%	27%	8%	2%	29%
Better infrastructure abroad	35%	33%	24%	21%	26%	27%
Adapted to life abroad	36%	31%	27%	16%	11%	27%
Pessimistic about Ukraine's future	28%	35%	26%	15%	7%	26%
Home in a combat zone	22%	18%	25%	26%	29%	23%
Better prospects for children	28%	24%	25%	14%	2%	22%
I won't find a good job in Ukraine	35%	25%	21%	15%	4%	22%
Better social support	18%	23%	21%	20%	24%	21%
Better job than in Ukraine	25%	26%	19%	13%	2%	20%
Occupation of my region	25%	10%	17%	18%	18%	16%
Family abroad	19%	16%	13%	16%	28%	16%
I am afraid of condemnation	11%	14%	14%	9%	3%	12%

I have no information about the possibility of a return	11%	11%	9%	10%	6%	10%
House destroyed	10%	9%	8%	9%	8%	9%
I/my children do not speak Ukrainian well	5%	2%	5%	6%	4%	4%
Other	3%	1%	2%	2%	0%	2%

Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

At the same time, some of the reasons are related not only to risks in Ukraine, but also to adaptation abroad. 27% of refugees say they have already gotten used to life abroad. Among young people aged 18–24, this figure reaches 36% – they integrate more quickly, study, work and build new lives. Another 27% note a better quality of life, healthcare and more comfortable cities in their host country. The highest rating is in Germany – 32% (Table3).

Table3 . What prevents Ukrainian refugees from returning to their homeland: geographical distribution

Barrier	Germany	Poland	Czech Republic	Canada	Italy	Spain	United States	Others
War	55%	58%	55%	65%	62%	58%	67%	61%
Blackouts	38%	37%	24%	45%	41%	46%	31%	50%
Mobilisation	30%	28%	17%	20%	28%	18%	37%	36%
Better quality of life, etc.	32%	26%	19%	29%	20%	27%	22%	30%
Adapted to life abroad	26%	25%	29%	26%	25%	21%	18%	31%
I don't see a future for myself/my children in Ukraine	27%	25%	22%	23%	28%	29%	24%	25%
Home in a combat zone	23%	27%	18%	13%	38%	21%	14%	29%
Better prospects for me and my children	21%	25%	18%	13%	20%	15%	27%	26%
I won't find a good job in Ukraine	28%	18%	25%	10%	12%	14%	12%	27%
Better social support	32%	12%	10%	13%	21%	14%	2%	27%
Better job than in Ukraine	18%	24%	22%	16%	18%	17%	12%	21%

Occupation of my region	14%	16%	18%	19%	8%	9%	22%	18%
My family/relatives are here	15%	16%	12%	16%	26%	5%	22%	15%
I am afraid of being judged	10%	10%	7%	7%	10%	14%	22%	17%
I have no information about the possibility of a return	9%	7%	0%	10%	10%	9%	18%	14%
My home has been destroyed	12%	8%	9%	3%	10%	3%	6%	10%
I/my children do not speak Ukrainian well	6%	2%	6%	0%	8%	2%	4%	7%
Other	3%	2%	2%	3%	0%	2%	2%	1%

Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

A quarter of respondents have lost faith in the future – both for themselves and their children in Ukraine, and for the country as a whole. This indicator is highest among young people aged 25–34 (35%) and refugees in Spain (29%), Italy (28%) and Germany (27%). This clearly demonstrates the formation of long-term emigration sentiments.

The economic factor also remains significant: 20% say they have a better job abroad than they had in Ukraine, and 22% fear that they will not be able to find a good job after returning. Among young people aged 18–24, this fear reaches 35% – they are not sure that the Ukrainian labour market will be able to offer them competitive conditions.

In addition, 23% of respondents consider the fact that their home or region is in or near a combat zone to be significant. Among refugees in Italy and Romania, this figure reaches 34–38%. At the same time, refugees in Romania rate their quality of life lower than Ukrainians surveyed in other countries.

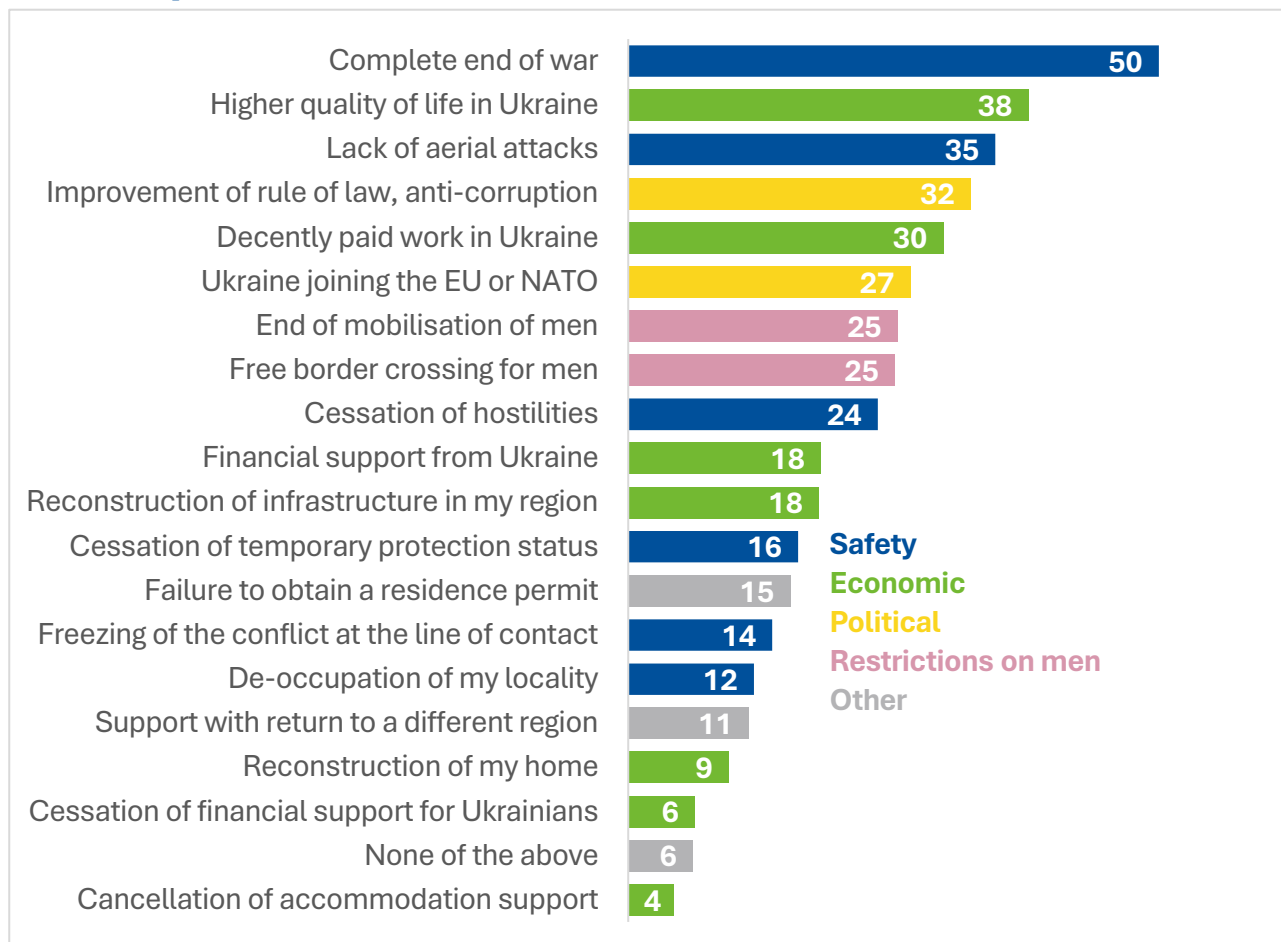
The geographical breakdown of the data shows a clear segmentation: refugees in the United States are distinguished by their focus on their children's prospects, supported by 27.5% of respondents. Meanwhile, security factors dominate in Poland and the Czech Republic.

Refugees in Italy have the least opportunity and desire to return. The homes of 38% of them are in the combat zone, and 26% have relatives or family members already living in the host country, which is one of the highest rates among all the countries surveyed. This creates the conditions for social integration in the new country.

Therefore, despite the fact that Ukrainian refugees' decision to remain abroad is primarily due to security risks – war, fear for themselves and their loved ones, and the threat of mobilisation – factors of long-term integration, which vary depending on the country of residence, are becoming increasingly important. On average, one in four refugees say they have adapted to life abroad.

7.4. WHAT COULD MOTIVATE REFUGEES TO RETURN

Figure 24. Answer to the question "Which of these factors could encourage you to return to Ukraine?", % of total respondents



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

The survey defines the resumption of civil aviation flights as the criterion for the final end of the war.

The main factors that could encourage refugees to return are security-related, i.e. the final end of the war and the absence of air strikes. At the same time, economic and political factors are important for a significant proportion: 38% mention a higher standard of living in Ukraine, 32% mention improvements in the rule of law, and 30% mention the possibility of finding a well-paid job in Ukraine. For 25%, important factors are the end of mobilisation and free border crossing for men.

The possibility of finding a well-paid job as an incentive to return was more often mentioned by young people aged 18-24 (38%). They also more often noted that financial support upon returning to another region or other financial assistance could motivate them (37%).

The abolition of temporary protection or the termination of financial assistance in the host country as incentives to return to Ukraine were more often mentioned by refugees over 65 years of age (46% and 21%).

8. FACTORS POTENTIALLY LINKED TO THE WILLINGNESS OF REFUGEES TO RETURN

8.1. ANALYSIS OF REFUGEE SURVEY DATA

In this section, we analyse which factors are associated with Ukrainians' desire to return to Ukraine based on survey data. As in previous survey waves, we use an ordered logit regression model. The dependent variable in the regression is the stated intention to return. Independent variables include gender, age, presence of children, education, region of origin, host country, employment status, income, and others. The results of this analysis help us better understand which factors are associated with higher or lower intentions to return to Ukraine.

At the same time, it is important to note that the results of this analysis should not be interpreted as causal relationships. For example, if the regression results indicate that refugees in Poland are 65% more likely to want to return than those in Germany, this does not necessarily mean that moving from Germany to Poland would increase someone's desire to return to Ukraine. There may be other unaccounted factors influencing both location and return intentions (omitted variable bias), or return plans may dictate the choice of host country (reverse causality).

Nevertheless, the regression results provide a better understanding of which refugees are more or less likely to return and which factors are likely associated with these intentions.

Figure 25 shows the regression results in the form of odds ratios (depicted as dots and numbers) and confidence intervals (90% confidence intervals are shown as lines, with asterisks indicating levels of statistical significance: * – significant at the 10% level, ** – significant at the 5% level, *** – significant at the 1% level).

Odds ratios can be interpreted as follows. If the value is greater than 1, it shows how many times more likely respondents in that category are to plan a return to Ukraine compared to respondents in the “baseline” category. For example, in Figure 25, the odds ratio for the variable “Poland” is 1.65, meaning respondents currently in Poland are 1.65 times (or 65% more) likely to plan a return than those in Germany (the baseline category for host country).

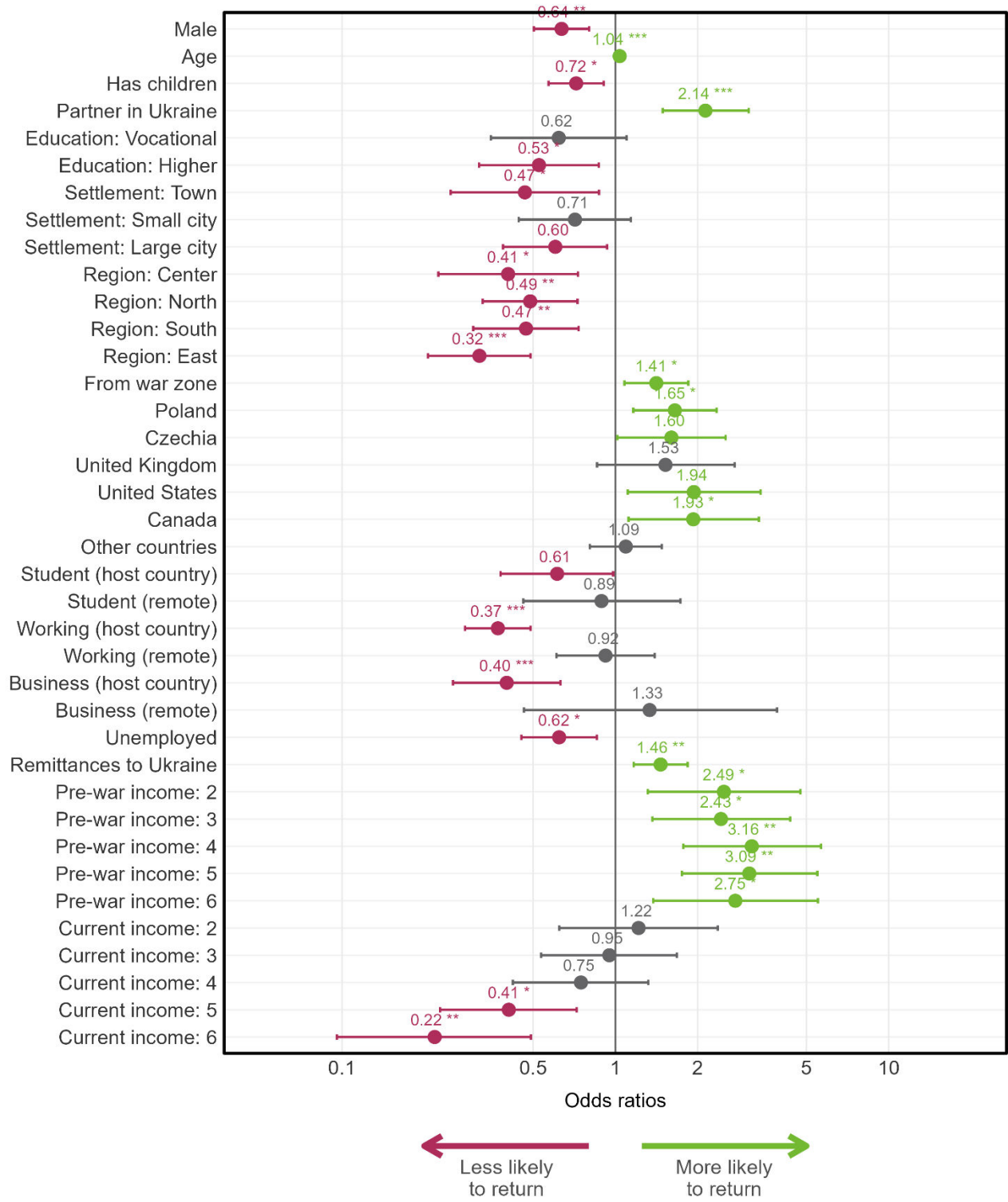
If the value is less than 1, it means respondents in that category are less likely to return to Ukraine than those in the baseline category. To calculate how many times (or by what percentage) they are less likely to return, subtract 1 from the odds ratio. For example, the odds ratio for the variable “Male” is 0.64, meaning men are $(0.64 - 1 = -0.36)$ 36% less likely to plan a return to Ukraine than women.

If the odds ratio equals (or is not statistically significantly different from) 1, it means people in that category are as likely to return to Ukraine as those in the baseline category.

For continuous variables, such as age, the odds ratio indicates how much more likely the intention to return becomes if the variable increases by 1. For example, the odds ratio for “Age” is 1.04, meaning the likelihood that a person plans to return increases by 4% with each additional year of age.

Baseline categories for specific variables: Educational variables are related to refugees with only basic secondary education. For type of settlement, the comparison is with refugees who lived in rural areas before moving abroad. The baseline region is Western Ukraine. The baseline host country is Germany. Variables for pre-war and current income are based on a self-assessment scale of economic status, where the baseline category is the lowest – “Not enough money even for food.”

Figure 25. Regression analysis results



Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, December 2025 – January 2026

Income categories are defined as follows: Income: 2 – We had enough for food, but had to save or borrow for clothing and footwear; Income: 3 – We had enough for food, clothing, and footwear, but had to save or borrow to buy items such as a good suit, mobile phone, or vacuum cleaner; Income: 4 – We had enough for food, clothing, footwear, and other purchases, but had to save or borrow to buy more expensive items (e.g., household appliances); Income: 5 – We had enough for food, clothing, footwear, and expensive items, but had to save or borrow to buy a car or apartment; Income: 6 – We could buy anything we needed at any time. The baseline category for income level is "We had to cut back on food." The type of settlement reflects the locality from which respondents left.

Unlike the results of the regression analysis in the previous wave of the study, in this wave we observe that having children is negatively and statistically significantly associated with plans to return—refugees with children are, on average, 28% less likely to plan a return compared to those without children. This may be related both to deeper integration and to the unwillingness to subject their sons to travel restrictions. Over four years of full-scale invasion, the children of those who left at the beginning of the invasion have grown significantly older. Similarly, boys aged 14–17 have been more actively leaving: the number of boys of this age receiving temporary protection in EU countries significantly exceeds the number of girls.

Having close relatives in Ukraine is positively and statistically significantly associated with the desire to return to Ukraine. For example, refugees who have a partner in Ukraine are, on average, more than twice (114% more) as likely to return. Financial ties to people in Ukraine are also important. Those who send financial remittances to someone in Ukraine are almost one and a half times more likely to return to Ukraine compared to those who do not. This may indicate the presence of people and an environment in Ukraine to which refugees see a reason to return.

For maintaining ties with Ukraine, remote study/work/business in Ukraine is also important. Refugees who work in the host country are, on average, 60% less likely to return compared to those who continue to work remotely in the Ukrainian market. The same applies to entrepreneurs. It is also notable that unemployed refugees abroad are 38% less likely to return to Ukraine.

In the analysis of the previous wave, region of origin was also statistically insignificant in explaining the desire to return. At the same time, in this wave, we see that people from Western Ukraine (the baseline category) are, on average, more than twice as likely to return compared to those from other regions.

As in previous waves, there remains a connection between the type of settlement from which refugees left in Ukraine and their desire to return. Those most willing to return are people from Ukrainian villages. People from cities are 30–40% less willing to return compared to refugees from villages.

Compared to refugees in Germany (the baseline category), refugees in other countries are generally one and a half to two times more likely to return. The lower desire to return among Ukrainians in Germany may be partially explained by the more comprehensive social-integration package provided by this country. Despite the gradual reduction of these benefits and support, such measures were important for the integration of Ukrainians in the new host country during the first years.

Higher pre-war income is associated with a significantly greater desire to return when we account for other variables. However, this effect is nonlinear: critical poverty (the baseline category, which had to cut back on food) is more important. Thus, people who did not even have enough money for food before the full-scale invasion are 2–3 times less likely to return to Ukraine than all other higher categories of economic self-assessment.

Unlike the previous wave, where current refugee income was not a statistically significant variable, this time the effect is present, particularly for the wealthiest categories—those who can easily afford to buy expensive items. The wealthiest individuals, according to self-assessment, are 3–5 times less likely to return.

9. READINESS FOR THE ABOLITION OF TEMPORARY PROTECTION

From 4 March 2027, a managed transition to alternative residence statuses is planned, which will allow people to stay in the country on the basis of, for example, education or work, or until they voluntarily return to Ukraine.⁴¹ As member states retain a high degree of discretion in shaping the relevant transition policies, they are likely to differ in the extent to which they facilitate the return or continued settlement of Ukrainians abroad.

In this study, we also asked Ukrainian refugees several questions about their readiness for possible changes in the policies of their host countries towards them.

In response to a question about their readiness for the abolition of temporary protection status⁴², 21% of Ukrainian refugees reported that they already have documents other than temporary protection that allow them to stay in the country. 26% plan to obtain alternative documents in the near future (Figure 26). At the same time, 25% responded that they know little about the relevant changes and will wait for more information. At the time of the survey, about half of the refugees surveyed (45%) did not have and did not plan to obtain other permits to stay in the host country in the near future, which may indicate a lack of awareness of the upcoming changes.

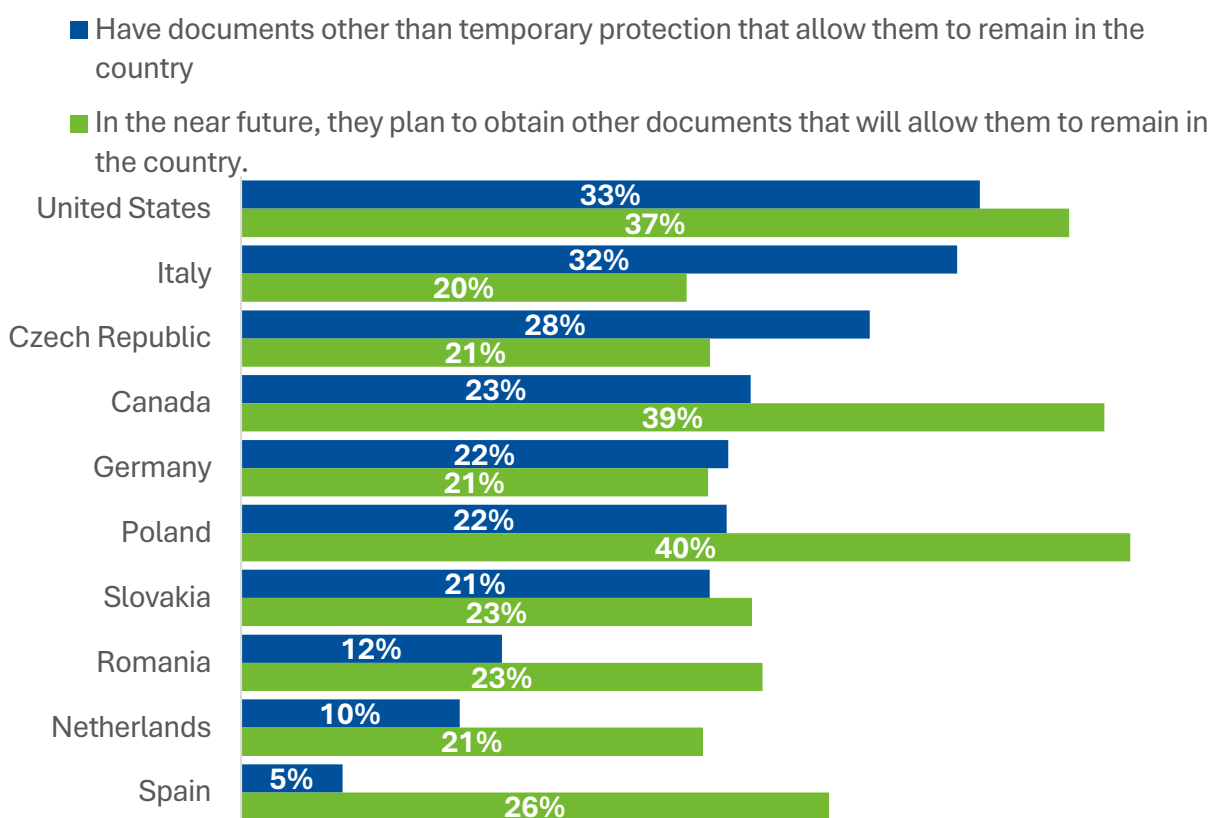
In Germany, Poland and the Czech Republic – countries where about 60% of Ukrainian refugees who have left for the EU are located – an average of 24% of them already have documents, in addition to temporary protection, allowing them to stay there. Another 27% plan to obtain such documents in the near future.

Men are more likely to say that they already have other documents in addition to temporary protection (26% compared to 18% of women). Among refugees under the age of 35, 27% have other documents.

⁴¹ [Protection of displaced Ukrainians: Council adopts recommendation on transition out of temporary protection - Consilium](#)

⁴² "In October 2025, the European Union adopted recommendations on the gradual abolition of temporary protection for Ukrainian refugees. Other countries may also gradually abolish special status for Ukrainians who left because of the war. Which of the following best describes your situation now?"

Figure 26 . Geographical distribution of intentions to legalise residence abroad



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

Among those who do not yet have documents alternative to temporary protection, in the event of the cancellation of temporary protection and the inability to obtain an alternative, 34% will consider the possibility of obtaining a residence permit in another country abroad, and 29% will consider returning to Ukraine on a permanent basis (Figure 28). 14% will temporarily return to Ukraine but will look for opportunities to leave again.

20% of refugees who currently do not have alternative documents are prepared to remain abroad without permits if they are unable to obtain them after the temporary protection is cancelled.

Men are more likely than women to plan to seek ways to remain abroad if they do not obtain alternative documents to temporary protection: 46% will seek opportunities to obtain permits in another country, and 30% are prepared to remain abroad even without documents. Women are more likely to be willing to return to Ukraine if they are unable to obtain documents: 33% are considering returning on a permanent basis, and 15% are considering returning temporarily.

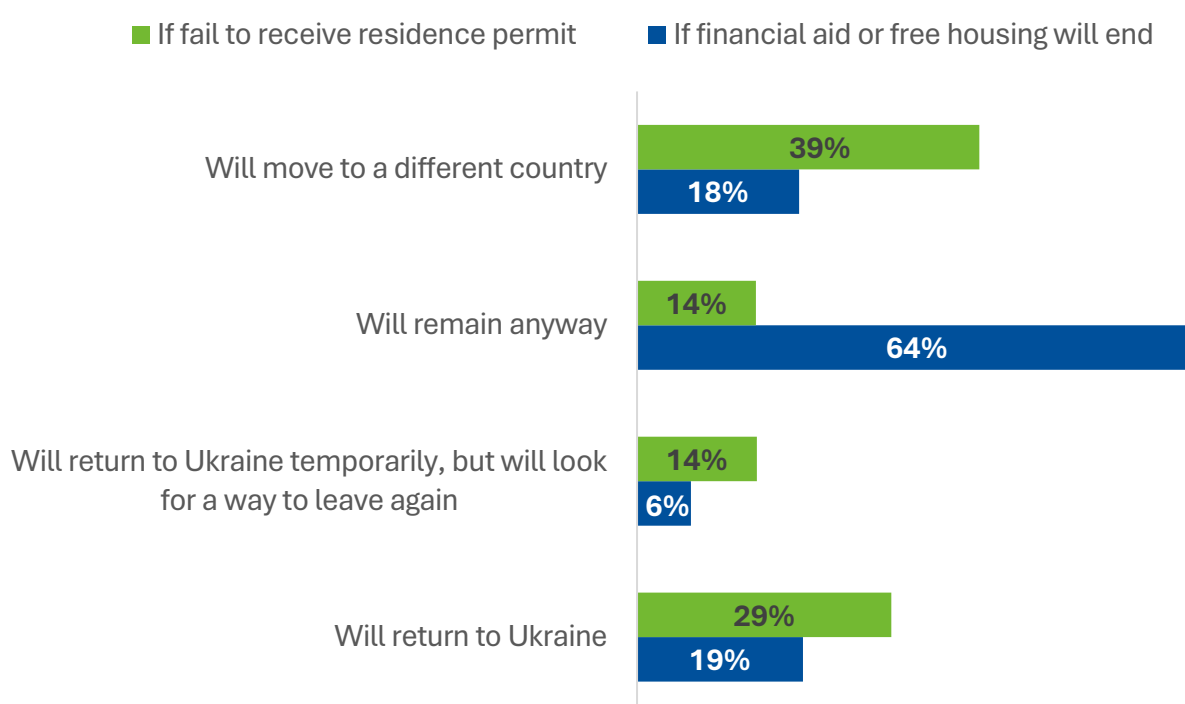
Young people under 35 who currently only have temporary protection are more likely than older refugees to be willing to move to another country in order to obtain a residence permit (47%) and are more likely to consider staying abroad without documents (25%).

The cancellation of temporary status will primarily lead to the return of refugees over 50 years of age. 40% of refugees aged 50-65 and 66% of refugees over 65 are ready to return to permanent residence in Ukraine if they are unable to obtain other documents after the end of temporary protection.

The cancellation of social benefits and housing assistance will have less impact on refugees' intentions than the inability to obtain new documents after the cancellation of temporary protection. If this assistance is cancelled, most Ukrainian refugees who receive it plan to remain in their country of residence. They can either live without such assistance (33%) or are willing to adapt to new conditions: look for better-paid work (32%) or adapt in other ways (20%). Only 19% of recipients of such assistance plan to return to Ukraine on a permanent basis in this case, and 6% are considering the option of returning temporarily and then leaving again later.

The cancellation of social benefits and housing assistance will primarily affect refugees over the age of 65. 62% of them are ready to return to Ukraine for permanent residence if such assistance disappears.

Figure 28. Migration intentions of Ukrainians in the event of a change in the conditions of their stay abroad



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

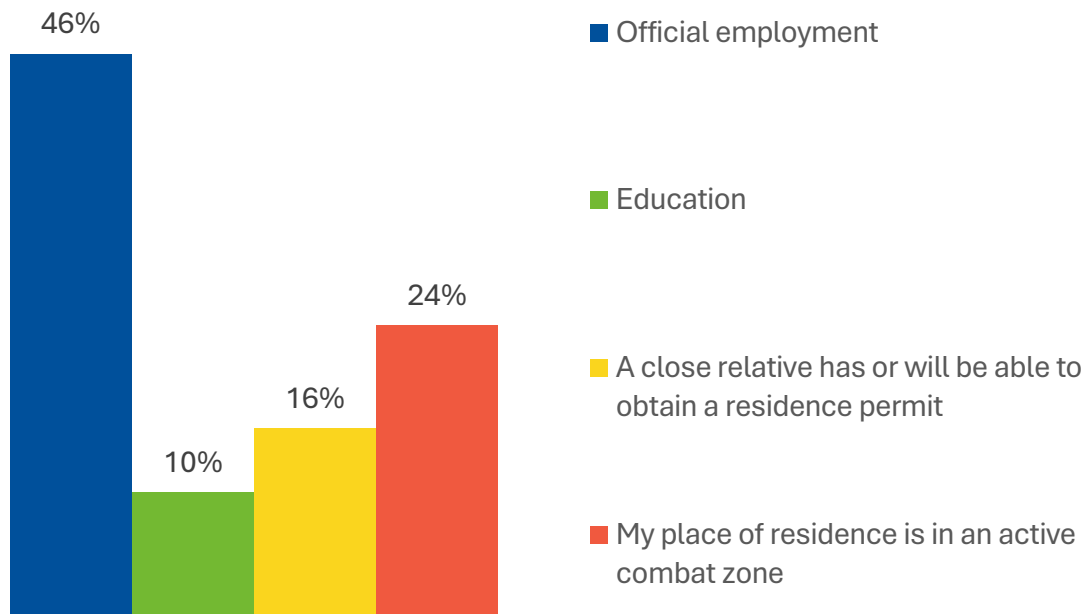
Blue bars: % of those receiving financial assistance or housing assistance. Green bars: % of those who currently have no alternative residence permits other than temporary protection.

Each respondent could select more than one answer, so the percentage of responses for each cluster may exceed 100%.

If temporary protection is cancelled, 46% of Ukrainian refugees who do not yet have other documents expect to obtain a residence permit on the basis of employment, internship or business activities in the host country (Figure 27). Another 15% have a relative who has obtained or may obtain a residence permit, and 10% expect to obtain permits through their studies abroad. At the same time, 37% are eligible for a permit on humanitarian grounds: due to hostilities or shelling near their place of residence (24%), occupation of their place of residence (11%), destruction or serious damage to their home (14%). Another 9% noted that they or their relatives have special needs (disability, special medical or educational needs) and expect to receive a permit on this basis.

Figure 27. Legal grounds for obtaining documents other than temporary protection that allow staying in the country of residence

Most refugees plan to obtain a residence permit through official employment



Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025 – January 2026.

Each respondent could select more than one answer, so the percentage of responses exceeds 100%.

10. REFUGEE GROUPS

Ukrainians who have left the country due to the full-scale invasion do not constitute a homogeneous group. They have different motivations, different life and socio-economic circumstances, different plans for returning, etc. To better understand the heterogeneity of Ukrainian refugees, as in previous waves of research, we conducted a cluster analysis.

Similar methodologies are widely used in marketing research to understand different subgroups of the target audience. It is also important for public policy to understand how different categories of citizens differ and to adapt policies to the different needs of the relevant groups. At the same time, it is important to note that this analysis is not definitive but rather helps to statistically identify refugee ‘archetypes’ while considering an array of characteristics. These groups are not binary cells, but only tendency categories.

As in previous notes, we use the k-modes method to identify four clusters, which we have labelled with names that describe the trends and tendencies of the people who fall into a particular cluster. Nevertheless, these categories and names should not be taken as definitive. Rather, they describe central tendencies that are more pronounced in a particular category of refugees than in others.

This time, based on the results of this year's cluster analysis, we have identified the following four groups of refugees:

- «New life trajectory» – (22.2% of all refugees, hereinafter – cluster 1);
- «With strong ties» – (21.6% of all refugees, hereinafter – cluster 2);
- «Economically vulnerable» – (17.4% of all refugees, hereinafter – cluster 3);
- «Classic wartime refugees» – (38.8% of all refugees, hereinafter – cluster 4).

In the three previous CES notes, we conducted cluster analysis based on the first wave of the refugee survey (November-December 2022), the third wave (December 2023-January 2024), and the fourth wave (November-December 2024). Since our survey is not of a panel type (for each wave of the survey, we randomly select new respondents rather than surveying people from the previous wave), we cannot track how the plans and characteristics of refugees in the groups identified in previous waves have changed. Therefore, each time we perform a new cluster analysis and exclude (partially) other groups. The set of questions used for clustering also changes from wave to wave. For a more formalised selection of relevant and informative variables on which the cluster analysis was based, we used the Boruta algorithm, which is based on random forests. For more detailed and technical information on the methodology of selecting variables for clustering, see Appendix 1. Description of the methodology for selecting variables for clustering.

The list of variables used for cluster analysis can be found in Appendix 2. Variables in cluster analysis.

The detailed description of each cluster is provided below.

10.1. CLUSTER 1: «NEW LIFE TRAJECTORY» (22% OF ALL REFUGEES)

This group differs significantly in terms of its demographic profile: it consists mainly of young people under 35 (53% compared to 35% on average) and is more likely to be unmarried (42% compared to 30% on average). They are much less likely to come from occupied territories (17% compared to 33% among all refugees) or areas of active combat (12% compared to 17%). They are also more likely than others to have chosen the Russian-language questionnaire.

The motivation for their departure is distinctly pragmatic. Representatives of this cluster were more likely to leave in search of better prospects (51% versus 26% overall), work or education. Economic factors such as job loss in Ukraine and pessimistic sentiments — fear of mobilisation (40%) and disbelief in Ukraine's future (45%) — also played a significant role. They also more often explained their decision to leave by a sense of danger, despite the relatively lower proportion of people who left their homes close to the front line.

Table 4. Principal reasons for relocation, by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
No active combat, but with shelling	27.1	37.7	12.8	28.0	28.7
Living conditions and prospects abroad are better than in Ukraine	25.5	50.6	12.8	42.8	10.6

Due to distrust of the Ukrainian authorities / disbelief in the country's future	24.7	44.6	21.0	25.4	15.0
Fear of mobilization	21.6	40.0	13.8	21.5	15.6
Active combat nearby	20.8	20.2	9.6	22.0	26.9
The settlement was far from the front line, but they still felt the danger.	18.4	29.6	5.1	19.6	19.0
Active combat within the location of residence	17.4	11.6	10.8	14.3	25.8
Location of residence occupied or was occupied	15.1	7.7	24.2	10.1	16.3
I/my family members have lost our jobs or a significant portion of our income	15.0	28.3	8.9	20.3	8.5
For reasons of work	12.0	18.7	11.4	16.4	6.6
For family reunification	7.9	6.1	12.2	8.0	6.4
Destroyed housing	6.8	3.2	4.4	10.9	8.3
Inability of children to obtain an education	6.6	11.9	4.9	7.9	3.9
For education	5.9	9.7	5.2	7.2	3.5

Source: Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, CES calculations.

Note: The colour highlights the fractions that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green indicates higher values, red indicates lower values.

Each respondent could select more than one answer, so the percentage of responses for each cluster exceeds 100%.

Abroad, this group is currently the best integrated into the host country's society. They know the language of their host country best – almost a third (29%) rate their language skills at C1-C2 level (on average, only 9% of respondents in the sample rated themselves this way). Representatives of this cluster generally have a more positive assessment of the attitude of locals towards them and actively form new social ties, both with local residents and with other migrants. They are also more independent in their daily lives – most often living in separate accommodation (83% compared to 62% among all refugees).

Both before moving and in their new country, these migrants are more likely than others to have stable jobs. Half of them work full-time in their country of residence (compared to 34% of refugees overall). At the same time, their work is more often in the same field as before moving from Ukraine (41% of those

working in this cluster, compared to 30% overall in the sample), and more often requires the same level of qualification (41% versus 33% overall in the sample).

This group has the highest proportion of students at local universities (15% compared to 7% among all refugees). Youth and high economic activity also result in the highest self-assessment of economic situation: this cluster is less likely than others to need humanitarian or social assistance, relies on income from wages and savings, and best assesses its level of financial well-being. This is the only cluster that, at the time of the survey, rated its level of financial well-being higher than at the time of departure from Ukraine.

This group is the least likely to return to Ukraine. Only 12% plan to return to Ukraine. When explaining their decision, they more often than other clusters cite better quality of life abroad and economic stability as barriers, as well as fear for their own safety and unwillingness to face infrastructure problems or mobilization. Among the potential incentives for returning, they emphasize fundamental changes in Ukraine: the end of the war (with the resumption of civil aviation flights), economic growth, and justice reform. They are also actively establishing themselves in their new country legally, preparing for the abolition of temporary protection status – 58% of them already have alternative permits, which is the highest indicator of readiness. Accordingly, the abolition of temporary protection in 2027 concerns them the least.

Table 5. Readiness for the removal of temporary protection, by clusters, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
Already possess other documents, apart from temporary protection, that allow them to stay in the country	21.1	57.5	11.0	11.9	9.9
Obtainment of other documents planned in the near future that will allow them to stay	26.1	25.2	30.4	37.7	19.0
Staying with temporary protection	44.6	24.4	50.9	43.1	53.3
Have little or insufficient information, waiting for additional	25.3	18.0	22.0	28.0	30.0

Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

«In October 2025, the European Union adopted recommendations on the gradual abolition of temporary protection for Ukrainian refugees. Other countries may also gradually abolish special status for Ukrainians who left because of the war. Which of the following best describes your situation right now?»

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red – downwards.

The table contains response options in which there are statistically significant differences between clusters.

Each respondent could choose more than one answer, so the share of answers for each cluster exceeds 100%.

10.2. CLUSTER 2: «WITH STRONG TIES» (22% OF ALL REFUGEES)

This cluster is characterized by a strong connection to Ukraine and a predominant desire to return, despite relatively successful integration in the host country.

Respondents in this cluster demonstrate the highest level of Ukrainian language use—85% chose the Ukrainian-language version of the survey (compared to 78% overall). They more often relocated as families, typically couples with several children. Refugees in this cluster also tended to leave Ukraine earlier in the invasion—two-thirds departed in 2022. Among their reasons for leaving, they more frequently cite the occupation of their home region (24% vs. 15% among all refugees), which is why a slightly higher proportion of this group travelled to Western countries via Russia or Belarus.

Additionally, this cluster more often relocated to reunite with family abroad (12% vs. 8% overall).

Refugees in this cluster are less likely to cite combat operations, shelling, or fear of mobilization as factors in their departure compared to other Ukrainians abroad.

Overall, this cluster is more mobile and entrepreneurial. Before relocating abroad, nearly one in four refugees in this group (23%) owned a business or were self-employed in Ukraine (compared to 15% on average among refugees). Similarly, migrants in this cluster are more likely to pursue entrepreneurial activities in their new country—14% own a business (vs. 8% overall). Their integration is also facilitated by the fact that refugees in this cluster more often had prior experience living abroad before 2022 (26% vs. 15% overall). They also find it somewhat easier to make friends with locals—82% have acquaintances among the local population in their host country (compared to 73% of all refugees).

Table 6. Employment by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
Full-time employed	33.9	50.2	32.4	31.5	26.4
Part-time employed	13.1	14.6	12.5	19.3	9.8
Looking for work in a new country	17.4	12.6	17.0	23.3	17.6
Studying in a special course for Ukrainians	10.9	7.5	7.1	22.9	9.5
Do business in a new country	7.7	10.2	14.4	4.8	3.8
Studying in a special course in a new country, which is also available for the nationals	7.1	14.6	3.6	8.3	4.3
Unemployed and not seeking employment	6.7	3.3	5.8	4.6	10.0
Employed remotely in Ukraine	6.6	5.7	9.7	3.5	6.7
Retirees	6.6	2.4	7.1	2.6	10.6
Economically inactive	2.8	2.1	2.3	1.4	4.2

Other	0.7	0.3	1.8	0.4	0.3
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Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red - downwards

The table contains response options in which there are statistically significant differences between clusters.

Each respondent could choose more than one answer, so the share of answers for each cluster exceeds 100%.

Despite reporting fewer integration challenges overall, refugees in this group maintain active ties with Ukraine — both personal and financial.

51% of respondents in this cluster plan to return to Ukraine, while another 24% are undecided. This cluster is more economically connected to Ukraine than others: 19% of refugees here receive wages or business income from Ukraine, and 10% continue to work remotely for the same employer as before relocating abroad.

More than half (55% of the cluster) send financial support to relatives in Ukraine (compared to 46% among all refugees). This is partly due to their stronger economic standing: 34% can afford food, clothing, footwear, and luxury items, while another 7% can buy anything they want.

Table 8. Readiness for the cancellation of temporary protection, by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
Provide financial support to relatives who remained in Ukraine	45.6	52.0	54.6	39.6	39.6

Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red - downwards

When asked about barriers to potentially returning to Ukraine, this group is less concerned with security factors. Instead, they more often cite adaptation to their new life and family abroad as restraining factors. Among potential incentives for return, the importance of Ukraine's Euro-Atlantic path stands out.

Legally, this group also remains more dependent on temporary protection status: only 11% hold alternative residence permits. Most of them currently plan to stay under temporary protection, and if it is cancelled, this group is somewhat more likely to return to Ukraine (29% vs. 23% among all refugees)

10.3. CLUSTER 3: «ECONOMICALLY VULNERABLE» (17% OF ALL REFUGEES)

This group is the most socially and economically vulnerable. Demographically, the cluster more often consists of middle-aged individuals: 52% are aged 35–49 (compared to 44% among all refugees). There are more divorced individuals in this group—15% vs. 10% overall. It also has a higher proportion of both those who left alone (24% vs. 17%) and those who left with children (45% vs. 37%), but without a partner or other close relatives (e.g., parents).

When explaining their decision to leave Ukraine, refugees in this cluster more frequently cite better living conditions abroad (43% vs. 26% overall), loss of employment or income in Ukraine (20% vs. 15%), and destruction of housing (11% vs. 7%). At the same time, this group is somewhat less likely to have left due to the occupation of their home (10% vs. 15% on average).

Economically, this group assesses their situation as significantly worse than the first two clusters. Only 21% can afford expensive purchases (compared to 35% overall), and 15% in this cluster are forced to cut back on food, clothing, or footwear. Regarding income sources abroad, they more often rely on social benefits from the host country—while 27% of all refugees receive such payments, 48% of the "economically vulnerable" do.

In their daily lives, they more often live with other refugees like themselves. Only 32% have separate housing (vs. 62% overall), and 61% live in dormitories or share accommodations with others. This cluster is more likely to be job-seeking (23% vs. 17% among all adult refugees) or employed only part-time (19% vs. 13%). Among those who are employed, a higher proportion work in fields completely different from their pre-war occupations—61% in this cluster vs. 51% overall.

When describing their difficulties, this group more frequently mentions uncertainty about their future in the host country, challenges in finding employment, financial hardship, and bureaucratic hurdles. This range of challenges also means that this cluster includes the highest number of Ukrainians receiving various forms of assistance: social benefits, language courses, humanitarian aid, subsidized housing, employment support, and help with document processing.

Table 7. Aid received by refugees by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
Medical aid	40.8	47.9	38.9	40.5	37.9
Language courses	35.4	38.2	31.1	46.1	31.4
Financial aid	35.3	30.7	23.8	68.2	29.7
Humanitarian aid	26.6	29.4	19.1	37.8	24.1
Partial coverage of housing/housing services	23.5	22.5	18.9	35.2	21.3
Administrative aid with documents	22.8	32.0	19.8	29.2	16.4
Free housing	21.5	10.9	17.1	34.4	24.2
Assistance in employment	20.6	31.3	16.3	29.3	13.0
Education (under 18 years of age)	15.6	21.2	10.9	19.5	13.2
Not receiving aid	15.1	20.7	17.2	4.1	15.7
Psychological assistance	13.6	21.3	13.7	18.3	7.0
Education (adults)	11.6	22.2	7.3	15.4	6.1

Source : Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red - downwards

The table contains response options in which there are statistically significant differences between clusters.

Each respondent could choose more than one answer, so the share of answers for each cluster exceeds 100%.

Despite the challenges in their current situation, this group is oriented toward integration in their new country. This group of refugees also has a negative balance regarding intentions to return to Ukraine: only 28% are considering return, while 49% currently do not plan to go back. In this respect, they resemble Cluster 1 ("New Life Trajectory"), though Cluster 1 is more adapted and integrated—including legally—while the "economically vulnerable" cluster remains in a more precarious position.

Notably, the "economically vulnerable" are significantly more likely to attend integration courses for refugees (23% vs. 11% overall). They are less likely than others to say they miss home, experience separation anxiety, or lack friends. When describing what deters them from returning, they more frequently mention better social support abroad (37%), better urban infrastructure abroad (34%), better job opportunities abroad (27%), and disillusionment with Ukraine's future as a state (33%).

Table 8. Intentions to return to Ukraine by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
Surely plan to	19.3	5.2	22.2	8.3	30.6
Rather plan to	24.0	6.9	28.5	20.1	33.1
Difficult to say	20.3	16.3	24.1	22.4	19.5
Rather not planning to	19.0	29.9	14.1	30.4	10.3
Surely not planning to	17.4	41.7	11.1	18.8	6.5
Balance of intentions	6.9	-59.5	25.4	-20.7	46.9

Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red – downwards. Balance of intentions is the difference between the total of refugees planning to return (surely and rather to) and refugees planning to stay (surely and rather to).

Legally, this group is currently poorly prepared for the potential cancellation of temporary protection status—only 12% hold alternative residence documents. Nevertheless, they more frequently report plans to obtain such documents (38% vs. 26% on average among all refugees). If they lack a permit, they are more willing to seek opportunities to obtain one in another foreign country (37% vs. 27%) or even relocate somewhere without a residence permit (12% vs. 8%). In the event that benefits and payments are cancelled in their host country, they are more likely than other clusters to seek higher-paying employment (30% vs. 18%) or adapt in other ways (for example, by looking for a country where such support is available or where working conditions are better).

10.4. CLUSTER 4: «CLASSIC WARTIME REFUGEES» (39% OF ALL REFUGEES)

This cluster was identified by our methodology as the largest. In terms of their circumstances for leaving and current situation, it also most closely matches the common perception of refugees forced to flee due to war. This group more often left because of combat operations in or near their locality (26% and 27%, respectively), and less often due to economic reasons, job loss, fear of mobilization, or disillusionment with Ukraine. Refugees in this cluster also more frequently left in the last two years (24% departed in 2024 and 2025, compared to 19% on average), which may indicate the forced nature of their decision.

Refugees in this cluster have a slightly higher average age (27% are over 50, compared to 21% overall). There is also a higher concentration of people from Donetsk and Luhansk regions in this group—18% vs. 13% on average.

Their level of adaptation abroad is the lowest. They have the poorest language skills (67% do not know the local language at all or know it only minimally, vs. 38% overall), are less likely to have friends or good acquaintances among locals (41% vs. 27%), and usually socialize with other Ukrainians abroad (72%). Economically, they are also the least active and assess their financial situation as worse than other refugee groups (18% are forced to cut back on food, clothing, and footwear, vs. 13% overall). Before relocating abroad, refugees in this cluster more often did not work because they managed households or were on parental leave (12% vs. 8% overall), or were retirees (13% vs. 9%).

Abroad, a smaller proportion of people in this cluster are employed—26% work full-time, compared to 34% on average. They also less frequently use assistance in the form of social benefits, language courses, employment support, document processing, or psychological assistance. This may be due to lower awareness, greater dependence on more socially active refugees (e.g., family members), or a lesser desire to integrate into the new country.

Among their difficulties, this group of Ukrainians abroad most frequently cites homesickness (59%), separation from loved ones (44%), learning a new language (48%), and lack of friends (29%).

Table 9. Challenges faced by refugees by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
I miss and worry about my home-land/home	46.1	37.7	49.1	25.2	58.7
Separation from family and friends	36.3	40.5	33.4	18.3	43.5
Uncertainty about the future in the new country, difficulties in renewing residence permits	29.9	25.0	31.9	37.6	28.2

Difficulties learning the language	27.7	16.5	13.6	24.9	43.1
Difficulties in finding a job	19.2	12.0	11.9	33.4	21.0
Financial hardship	19.1	10.0	15.6	32.7	20.1
Lack of friends, acquaintances, or an insufficient social circle	17.9	9.2	12.6	10.6	29.0
No particular difficulties	16.7	32.3	23.0	10.6	6.9
Difficulties in interacting with government services, document processing	13.6	14.9	9.0	21.1	11.9
Difficulties in cultural adaptation	13.4	7.9	10.8	15.1	17.3
Difficulties in finding housing	11.7	8.0	7.6	25.2	10.0
Difficulties in accessing necessary medical services	11.5	7.2	13.1	11.7	13.0
Difficulties in interacting with locals	10.6	4.1	3.1	15.5	16.3
Difficult to answer	2.7	5.1	3.1	2.5	1.3

Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red – downwards. The table includes response options with statistically significant differences between clusters.

Each respondent could choose more than one answer, so the share of answers for each cluster exceeds 100%.

This social profile and situation explain why this group has the highest positive balance of intentions to return to Ukraine—63% say they definitely or likely plan to return, compared to an average of 43% among all refugees. In the event of return, this group demonstrates the highest level of "regional patriotism"—40% say they are willing to return only to their own region (vs. 33% among all refugees).

As barriers to return, "classic refugees" more often cite occupation (23%), damaged homes (11%), and much less frequently mention economic or political reasons. Similarly, they more actively identify the cessation of hostilities, de-occupation, and housing restoration as potential incentives for return.

Table 10. Factors favouring the return of the Ukrainian refugees, by cluster, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
Full end of the war (resumption of flights)	50.0	59.8	44.3	42.7	50.8
Higher standard of living in Ukraine	37.7	54.0	35.2	41.6	28.0
Absence of active combat and air-strikes in my locality	34.6	37.5	21.2	34.2	40.5
Improvements in law enforcement and anti-corruption	32.3	50.4	28.8	29.4	25.1
Ability to find decently paid work	29.7	45.2	27.0	32.9	20.8
Ukraine's accession to the EU/NATO	26.6	33.9	32.6	23.2	20.5
End of mobilization	25.4	40.4	21.8	25.8	18.6
Freedom of border crossing for men	25.1	41.5	15.1	23.7	22.0
Cessation of hostilities in my region	23.5	17.9	16.0	22.0	31.6
Financial assistance from Ukraine	18.1	24.5	13.2	18.2	17.3
Restoration of regional infrastructure	18.0	24.2	12.7	14.9	18.7
Expiration of temporary protection status	16.0	11.5	17.6	19.9	15.9
Inability to obtain or renew a residence permit	15.3	20.2	13.2	19.8	11.6
De-occupation of my locality	11.8	6.5	8.8	10.1	17.3
Restoration of my home	9.5	6.4	5.6	8.1	14.0
Prohibition of remote work by employer	0.6	1.6	0.0	0.4	0.5

Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red – downwards. The table includes response options with statistically significant differences between clusters.

Each respondent could choose more than one answer, so the share of answers for each cluster exceeds 100%.

90% of this group do not have alternative documents to temporary protection, and the majority currently plan to remain under temporary protection, primarily due to a lack of awareness of alternative options. At the same time, in the event of the termination of temporary protection and the inability to obtain other residence permits abroad, this cluster is more likely than others to return to Ukraine (31% vs. 23% overall).

Table 11. Actions undertaken in case of temporary protection cancellation, %

	All	1: "New life trajectory"	2: "With strong ties"	3: "Economically vulnerable"	4: "Classic wartime refugees"
I will look for opportunities to obtain a residence permit in another country (not Ukraine)	26.8	20.3	26.8	37.0	26.0
I will remain in the current country of residence, even without a residence permit	10.7	9.3	9.2	14.8	10.4
I will move to another country (not Ukraine), even without a residence permit	8.0	6.1	8.9	12.4	6.6
I will return to Ukraine	22.9	5.2	28.9	20.1	31.0
I will temporarily return to Ukraine but will seek opportunities to leave	10.8	7.1	14.0	11.7	10.7
Other	2.5	2.2	1.8	1.4	3.5
Difficult to answer / Not sure	16.0	8.6	19.7	11.1	20.3

Source: Info Sapiens questionnaire commissioned by CES, CES calculations.

Note: the colour highlights the shares that are statistically significantly different from the rest of the refugees. Green - upwards, red – downwards. The table includes response options with statistically significant differences between clusters. Each respondent could choose more than one answer, so the share of answers for each cluster exceeds 100%.

11. IMPACT OF THE REFUGEES ON THE ECONOMY

In this section, we analyse how many Ukrainians may remain abroad or return to Ukraine after the war, and we also estimate the potential losses to Ukraine's GDP from non-return. **Depending on the scenario, between 2.1 and 3 million Ukrainians may not return to Ukraine. Accordingly, between 1.3 and 2 million people will return to Ukraine.**

Older people with secondary education and no connection to the labour market are slightly more likely to return. This will create additional challenges for Ukraine in reintegrating such returnees after the war.

For each of the (non-)return scenarios, we also assessed the associated GDP losses. **Depending on the scenario and methodology, the losses could range from 2.3% to 9.5% of Ukraine's GDP each year.** Below, we describe our estimates and methodology in more detail.

11.1. HOW MANY UKRAINIANS WILL RETURN, AND HOW MANY WILL REMAIN ABROAD?

In Section 2, we estimated that there are currently about 5.6 million Ukrainians abroad who left due to the full-scale invasion. Using questions from the survey about the number of children, we can calculate that there are about 442 children per 1,000 adult refugees surveyed.

Since the respondents in our survey are only adults, we derive the number of children abroad based on the answers regarding the number, age and gender of the children with whom the respondents left. To ensure a more accurate representation in our calculation of the number of children, in our study they "inherit" the statistical weight of their mother or father who participated in the survey. However, since the survey is representative of the adult population abroad, in order to avoid double counting of children, we divide the statistical weight of a child by two if both parents are abroad. This is based on the assumption that each of the two parents abroad had an equal probability of being included in the sample.

In other words, if a father and mother abroad have one child, then each adult in such a household accounts for "half" of the child in a statistical sense. If only the mother/father left with their child, then the child receives the statistical weight of their mother or father directly. This logic applies to every child indicated by respondents in the survey.

We introduced this adjustment of statistical weight to the number of parents abroad in the previous (fourth) wave of this study.

Accordingly, according to our estimates, 69% of all refugees are adults over 18 years of age, and 31% are children under 18 years of age. By extrapolating this information to the total number of refugees, we can calculate the number of adults and children among refugees (as well as the number of children aged 0-13 and 14-17, using data on the age of children). Excluding the Russian Federation and Belarus (since refugees in these countries were not included in the study), there are currently 4.3 million Ukrainians abroad. Among them, 3 million are adults and 1.3 million are children (of whom about 973,000 are under 14 and 344,000 are aged 14-17).

According to our calculations, after the end of the war, 2.1 million Ukrainians will remain abroad (excluding Russia and Belarus) in an optimistic scenario, 2.7 million in a moderate scenario, and 3.0 million in a pessimistic scenario. Accordingly, 2.2 million will return to Ukraine in an optimistic scenario, 1.6 million in a moderate scenario, and 1.3 million in a pessimistic scenario.

These calculations are based on our assumptions about the likelihood of Ukrainian refugees returning from abroad, depending on their stated intentions to return (Table 12). In the case of children, their decisions to return are "inherited" from their parents in our calculations.

Table 12. Assumptions about the likelihood of Ukrainian refugees returning from abroad depending on different scenarios

	Optimistic	Middle	Pessimistic
"Definitely planning"	100	80	60
"I am likely to plan"	75	60	50
"Not planning to"	25	10	10
"Definitely not planning to"	0	0	0
"Hard to say"	50	30	20

Source: CES assumptions.

Table 13. Number of Ukrainian refugees who will return to Ukraine or remain abroad (excluding Russia and Belarus), depending on the scenario, as of January 2026

	Optimistic	Middle	Pessimistic
Number of refugees who will return to Ukraine as of January 2026	2	1	1
Among them:			
Adults	1.5	1.1	0.9
Children (0-13 years old)	0	0.4	0
Children (14-17 years old)	0	0	0
Number of refugees who will remain abroad as of January 2026	2.1	2.7	3
Among them:			
Adults	1.4	1.9	2
Children (0-13 years old)	0.5	0.6	0

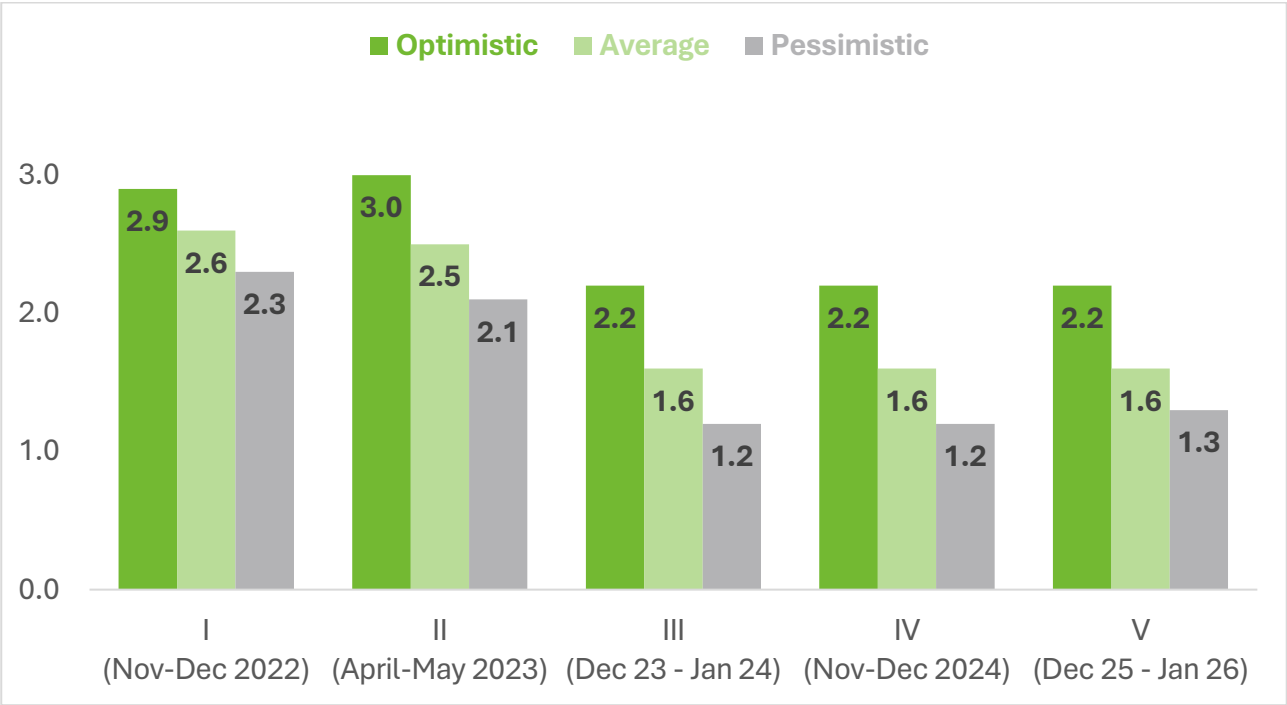
Children (14-17 years old)	0	0	0
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Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Figure 28 and

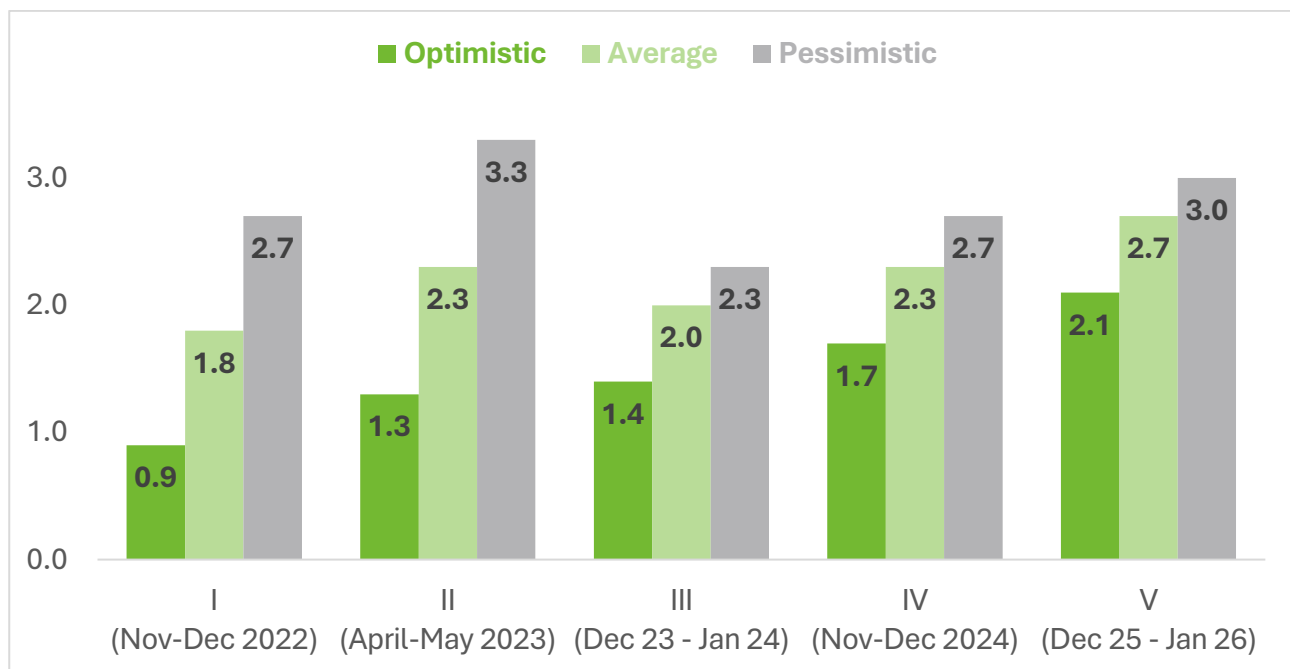
Figure 29 compare our estimates of the number of Ukrainians who will return to Ukraine and remain abroad between survey waves.

Figure 28. Comparison of estimates of the number of Ukrainians who will return to Ukraine between survey waves, by scenario, million people



Source: CES calculations based on the Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES.
In waves I-II, we did not know how many people had left for Europe via Russia/Belarus, and made different assumptions about this number depending on the scenario. Starting with wave III, we were able to accurately estimate the total number of refugees.

Figure 29. Comparison of estimates of the number of Ukrainians who will remain abroad, between survey waves, by scenario, million people



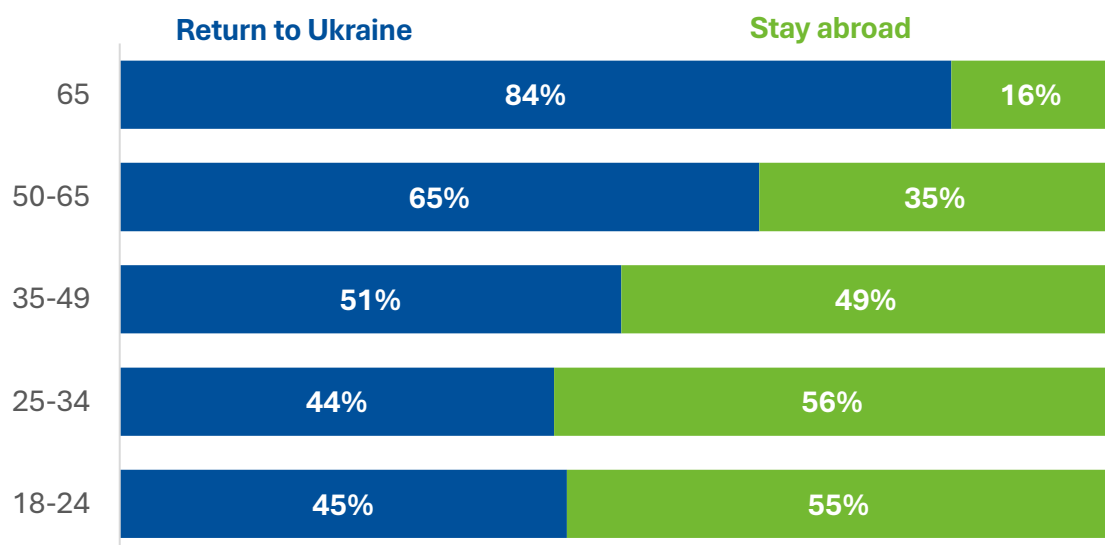
Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES.

In waves I-II, we did not know how many people had left for Europe via the Russian Federation/Belarus, and made various assumptions about this number depending on the scenario. Starting with wave III, we were able to accurately estimate the total number of refugees.

11.2. WHO EXACTLY WILL (NOT) RETURN?

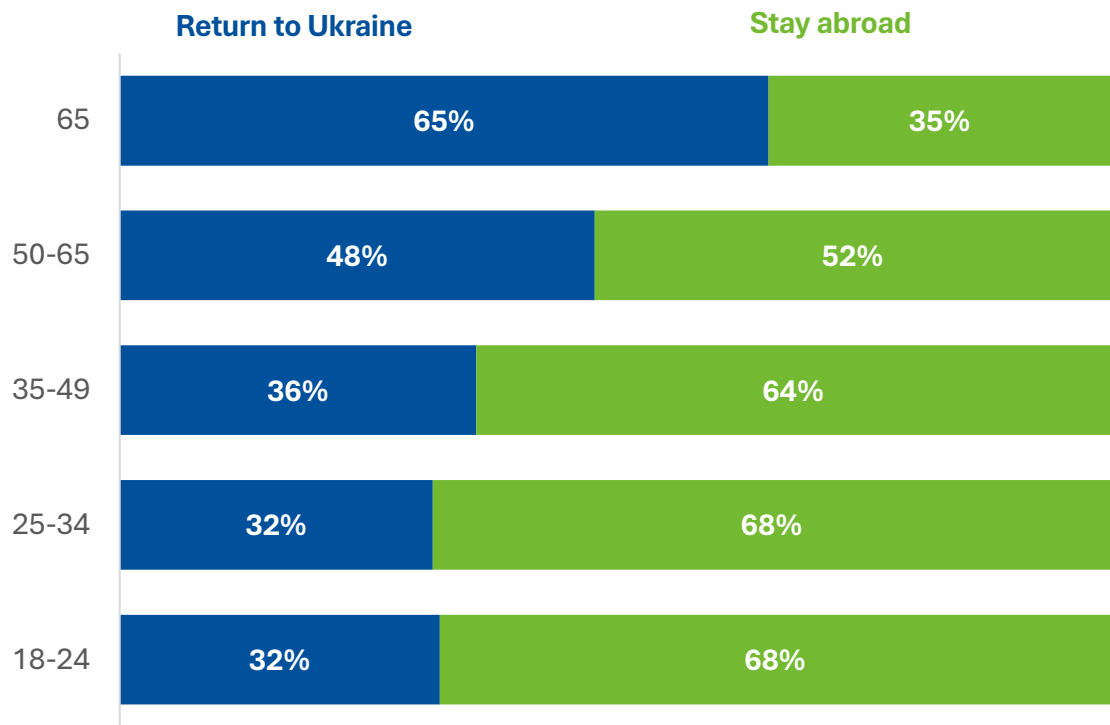
In addition to estimates of the total number of people who will return and remain abroad, it is important to understand who exactly will return and who will remain outside Ukraine. In this section, we will look at the number of people who will return, by age, level of education and employment status.

Figure 30. Distribution of Ukrainians who plan to return to Ukraine or remain abroad according to age group, under an optimistic scenario, %.



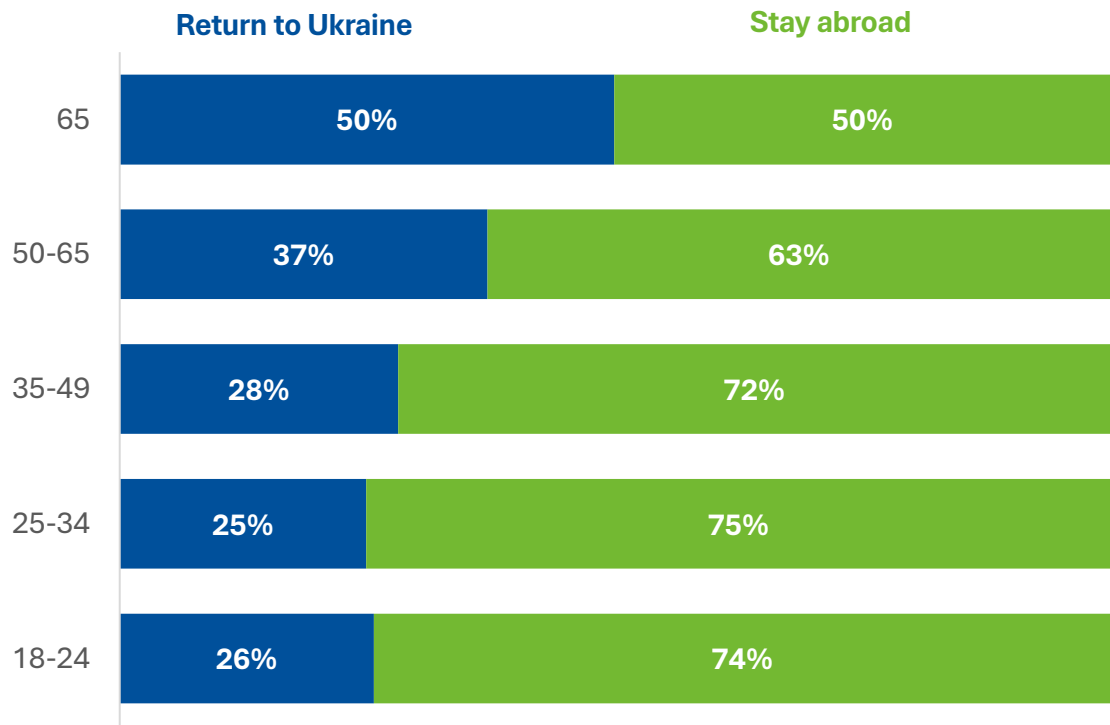
Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Figure31 . Distribution of Ukrainians who plan to return to Ukraine or remain abroad according to age group, under the middle scenario, %.



Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Figure 32. Distribution of Ukrainians who plan to return to Ukraine or remain abroad according to age group, under a pessimistic scenario, %.



Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Considering Figure 30, Figure31 and Figure 32, it can be concluded that in all scenarios, older people will be more inclined to return to Ukraine. In the optimistic scenario, the majority of Ukrainians over the age of 35 will return: 51% of refugees aged 35-49, 65% aged 50-65, and 84% over the age of 65. At the same time, young people are much more reluctant to return – from about 25% in the pessimistic scenario to 45% in the optimistic scenario.

Table14 shows the number of Ukrainians in each age group who are currently abroad, as well as how many of them will return to Ukraine after the war ends and how many will remain abroad. According to various scenarios, approximately 180-240 thsd Ukrainians aged 18-24 will remain abroad, 410,000-550,000 aged 25-34, 640,000-930,000 aged 35-49, 175,000-310,000 aged 50-65, and 22,000-70,000 Ukrainians over 65.

Table14 . Number of adult Ukrainians who will return to Ukraine or remain abroad (excluding Russia and Belarus), depending on age group and scenario, as of January 2026

	Optimistic	Middle	Pessimistic
Staying abroad:			
18-24	326 thsd	326 thsd	326 thsd
25-34	729 thsd	729 thsd	729 thsd
35-49	1.3 million	1.3 million	1.3 million
50-65	491 thsd	491 thsd	491 thsd
65	135 thsd	135 thsd	135 thsd
Returning from abroad:			
18-24	147 thsd	105 thsd	84 thsd
25-34	320 thsd	230 thsd	181 thsd
35-49	657 thsd	467 thsd	365 thsd
50-65	317 thsd	235 thsd	182 thsd
65	113 thsd	88 thsd	67 thsd
Will remain abroad:			
18-24	179 thsd	220 thsd	242 thsd
25-34	409 thsd	499 thsd	547 thsd
35-49	640 thsd	830 thsd	932 thsd
50-65	174 thsd	255 thsd	309 thsd
65	22 thsd	47 thsd	68 thsd

Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025–January 2026.

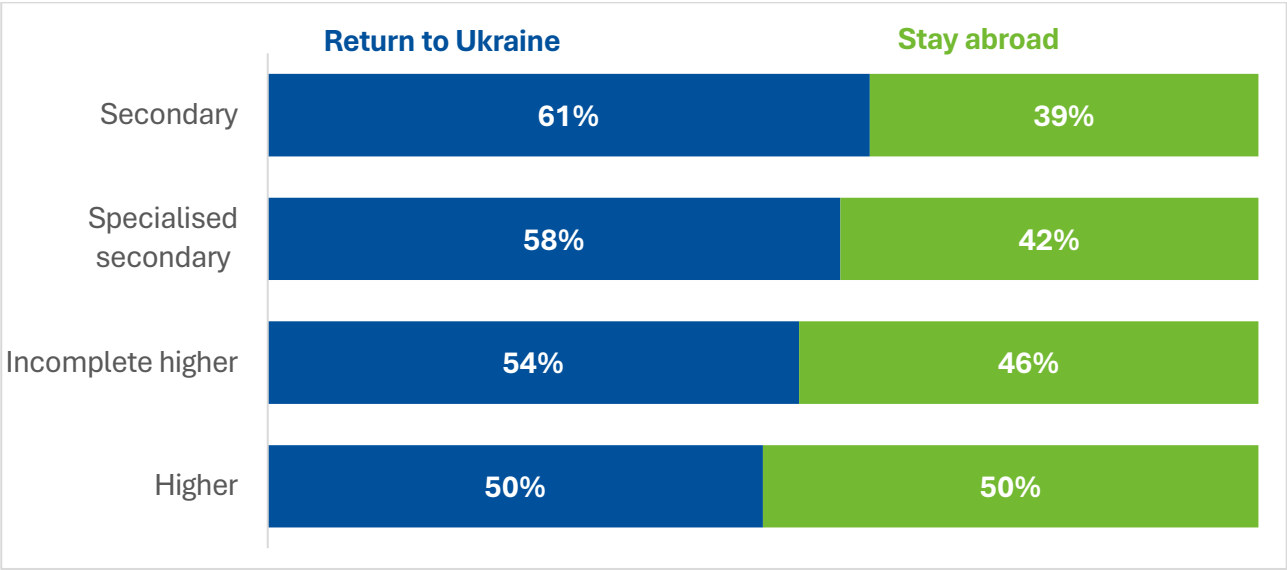
We also estimated the number of Ukrainians with different levels of education who may return or remain abroad after the war ends. These results are presented below (Figure 33,

Figure 34, [Figure 35](#),

Table 15). Since the proportion of people with higher education among Ukrainian refugees is significantly higher than the average for Ukraine, this indicates a prolonged brain drain from Ukraine. Our estimates also indicate that people with higher education are more likely to remain abroad, which points to the potential risk of losing skilled workers not only during the war, but also after it ends.

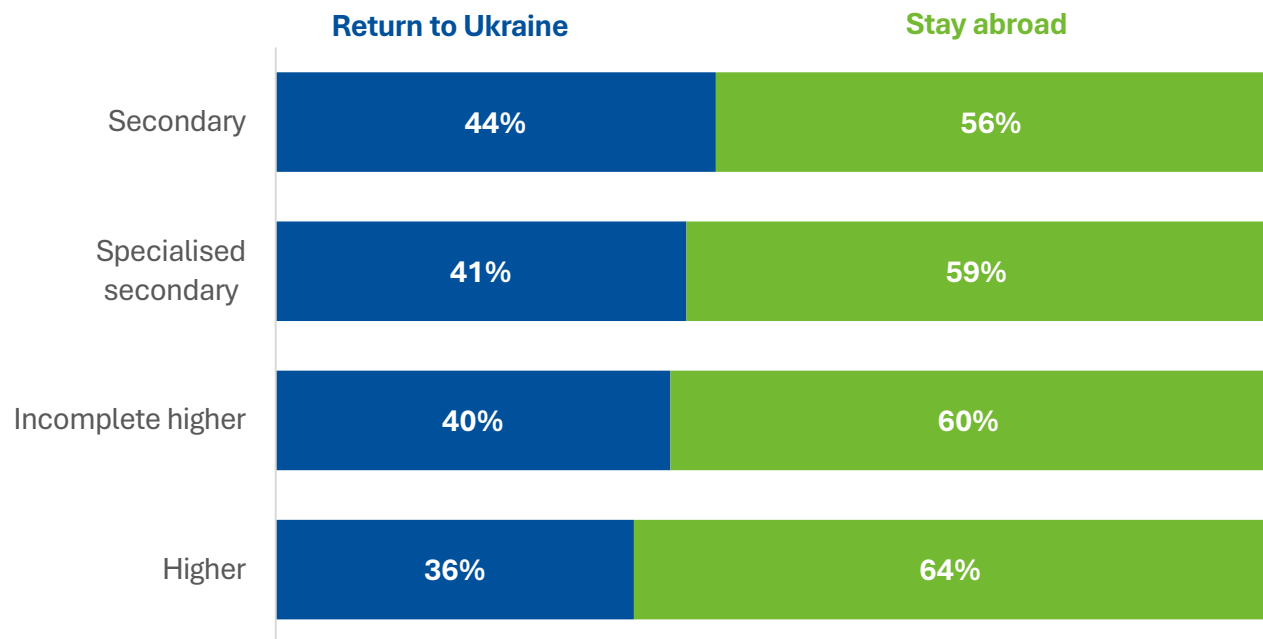
Thus, in a positive scenario, 61% of people with secondary education will return to Ukraine, and only half of those with higher education. The same trend holds for the medium and pessimistic scenarios. In the medium scenario, only 36% (760,000 out of 2.1 million) of refugees with higher education will return, and in the pessimistic scenario, 28% (595,000 refugees).

Figure 33. Distribution of Ukrainians who plan to return to Ukraine or remain abroad by highest level of education attained, according to the optimistic scenario



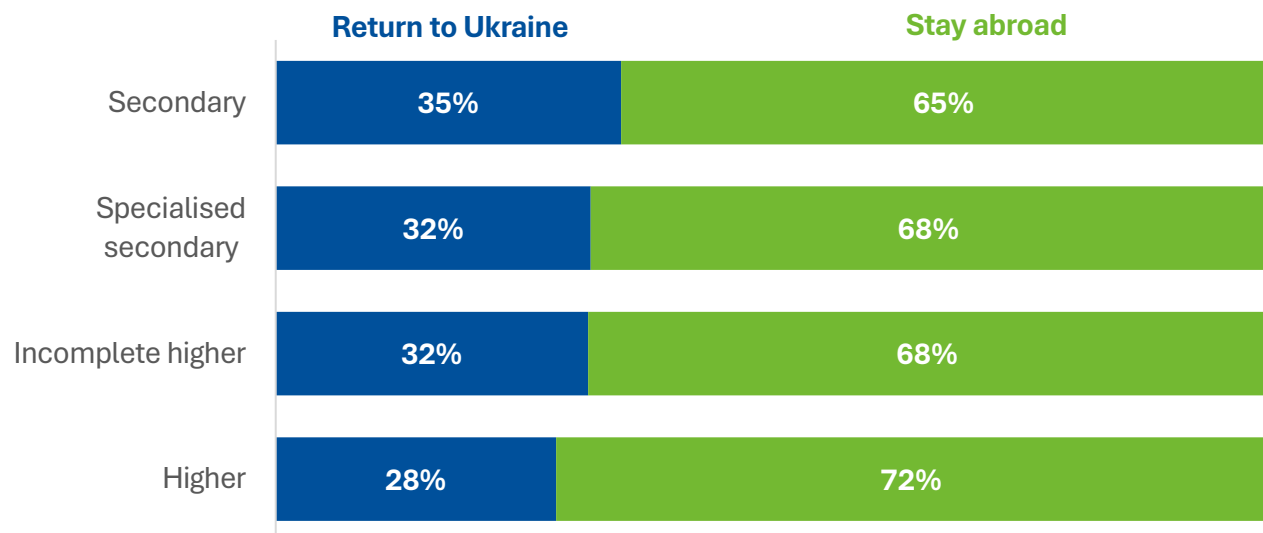
Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Figure 34. Distribution of Ukrainians who plan to return to Ukraine or remain abroad by highest level of education attained, according to the middle scenario



Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Figure 35. Distribution of Ukrainians who plan to return to Ukraine or remain abroad by highest level of education attained, according to the pessimistic scenario



Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025–January 2026.

Table 15. Number of adult Ukrainians who will return to Ukraine or remain abroad (excluding the Russian Federation and Belarus), depending on the highest level of education attained and the scenario, as of January 2026

	Optimistic	Middle	Pessimistic
Staying abroad:			
Higher	2.1 million	2.1 million	2.1 million
Incomplete higher	235 thsd	235 thsd	235 thsd
Secondary specialised	421 thsd	421 thsd	421 thsd
Secondary	219 thsd	219 thsd	219 thsd
Returning from abroad:			
Higher	1.1 million	760 thsd	595 thsd
Incomplete higher education	126 thsd	93 thsd	74 thsd
Secondary specialised	244 thsd	175 thsd	134 thsd
Secondary	133 thsd	97 thsd	76 thsd
Will remain abroad:			
Higher	1.1 million	1.3 million	1.5 million
Incomplete higher education	109 thsd	141 thsd	161 thsd
Secondary specialised	178 thsd	247 thsd	287 thsd
Secondary	86 thsd	122 thsd	143 thsd

Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025–January 2026.

In the context of return, the employment status of refugees is also important. If those who are currently working will have the same potential in the labour market after returning to Ukraine, their non-return will have a greater impact on Ukraine's economy. The number of refugees by employment status who are abroad and will return to Ukraine is presented in Table Table 16 .

Compared to previous waves of the survey, the number of employed refugees has increased. Currently, the majority of adult Ukrainians abroad are employed – 1.8 million are working and 1.2 million are not working. As in our previous estimates, we expect that a slightly smaller proportion of working refugees will return after the war: from 530,000 in a pessimistic scenario to 937,000 in an optimistic one. This is probably due to the link between employment and integration in a new place – refugees with independent sources of income abroad feel more stable.

Table 16. Number of adult Ukrainians who will return to Ukraine or remain abroad (excluding Russia and Belarus), depending on employment status and scenario, as of January 2026

	Optimistic	Middle	Pessimistic
Staying abroad:			
Working	1.8 million	1.8 million	1.8 million
Not working	1.2 million	1.2 million	1.2 million
Will return from abroad:			
Working	937 thsd	679 thsd	530 thsd
Not working	616 thsd	447 thsd	349 thsd
Will remain abroad:			
Working	859 thsd	1.1 million	1.3 million
Not working	565 thsd	735 thsd	832 thsd

Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025–January 2026.

11.3. IMPACT ON UKRAINE'S ECONOMY

We assessed the losses from the non-return of Ukrainian refugees using the same methodology as in previous reports, as well as additional labour market data that has become available since the previous survey.⁴³ Due to a slight increase in the total number of those who do not plan to return, the short-term annual losses from the non-return of refugees have marginally worsened.

As in previous reports, we use data on the number of Ukrainians who will and will not return from abroad in three scenarios – optimistic, average and pessimistic – for our calculations. The economic losses from the non-return of refugees are calculated using two methods – a decrease in consumption and a reduction in production due to labour shortages.

The calculation of the decline in consumption was carried out using two sets of data: data from the State Statistics Service on average monthly household expenditure in 2021 based on the results of a sample survey of household living conditions (HCLS/OUZHD)⁴⁴ and data from a nationwide sample survey of the socio-economic status of households (OSED)⁴⁵, conducted in December 2023 – February 2024.

According to calculations based on HCLS data, in 2021, the average annual household expenditure per adult was UAH 63,888, and per child – UAH 53,634. Accordingly, annual consumption losses from the non-return of migrants will amount to 2.3% in an optimistic scenario, 3.0% in a medium scenario, and

⁴³ [Ukrainian refugees after three years abroad. Fourth wave of research - Centre for Economic Strategy](#)

⁴⁴ [Household expenditure and resources in Ukraine in 2021 | State Statistics Service of Ukraine](#)

⁴⁵ [Socio-economic situation 25.07.24 \(1\).pdf.pdf](#)

3.4% in a pessimistic scenario of Ukraine's pre-war GDP (which is 0.4 percentage points more than last year's estimates using the same method).

According to calculations based on OSESD data, in 2023, the average annual household expenditure per person was UAH 155,052. Accordingly, annual consumption losses from non-return of migrants will amount to 4.9% in the optimistic scenario, 6.3% in the medium scenario, and 7.1% in the pessimistic scenario of Ukraine's GDP in 2023. The higher shares compared to calculations using 2021 data are explained, in particular, by an increase in the share of private consumption in GDP to 102.8% of nominal GDP in 2023 compared to 86.9% in 2021.

To estimate the losses from the reduction in the labour force, we assume that the same people who are currently working abroad would return to Ukraine to work, while other migrants would remain outside the labour force. Therefore, those who are currently working abroad and do not plan to return to Ukraine represent a net loss of labour, which will have a negative impact on GDP.

Since employment statistics during martial law are limited, we used data from 2021, when the State Statistics Service estimated the number of employed people aged 15-70 at 15.6 million. According to the OSESD, in 2023, the number of employed persons decreased to 13.3 million. Thus, in 2021, GDP per employed person was \$12.8 thsd, and in 2023, it was \$13.7 thsd. The growth in GDP per employed person in 2023 compared to 2021 is explained by changes in the structure of the economy and production links as a result of the full-scale war. Thus, the loss of infrastructure and production capacity and the reduction in the labour force were partially offset by an increase in labour productivity, which, in turn, was a significant factor in the recovery of economic activity despite the ongoing war.

According to this method, annual losses from the reduction in the labour force will amount to 5.5% in the optimistic scenario, 7.2% in the medium scenario, and 8.1% in the pessimistic scenario of Ukraine's pre-war GDP, or 6.5% in the optimistic scenario, 8.4% in the medium scenario, and 9.5% in the pessimistic scenario of GDP in 2023. A significant contribution to such high labour losses is the gradual increase in the employment rate among migrants.

Therefore, both the number of migrants abroad who do not plan to return and the short-term economic losses from their non-return are gradually increasing and, depending on the method and basis of assessment, will range from 2% of GDP for the optimistic scenario to 10% of GDP for the pessimistic scenario.

Long-term losses, including those resulting from refugee children remaining abroad, are currently difficult to assess given the uncertain duration of the full-scale war, the further adaptation of refugees to life abroad, and the policies of recipient countries regarding the retention or return of Ukrainians after the temporary protection regime expires in 2027.

At the same time, the risks of long-term negative impacts of significant military migration abroad on both the Ukrainian labour market and the demographic situation are increasing with the length of time refugees stay abroad. This requires an active policy on the part of the Ukrainian government, including cooperation with countries receiving Ukrainian refugees, to maintain the ties of Ukrainians abroad with Ukraine and create incentives for their return. It also requires maintaining the macro-financial stability

of the Ukrainian economy, continuing reforms, including in the process of EU accession, and addressing internal labour market and demographic issues.

Table 17. Economic losses from the non-return of refugees

	Optimistic	Middle	Pessimistic
Consumer losses (% of pre-war GDP)	2.3	3	3
Consumer losses (% of 2023 GDP)	4	6	7
Losses from workforce reduction (% of pre-war GDP)	5.	7.	8
Losses from workforce reduction (% of 2023 GDP)	6.5	8.4	9.5

Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by CES, December 2025–January 2026.

11.4. HOW MANY UKRAINIANS ARE CONSIDERING RETURNING IF TEMPORARY PROTECTION IS REVOKED?

Although EU countries now have general recommendations for preparing for the abolition of temporary protection status from March 2027 and a gradual transition to alternative permits or return assistance, for many refugees who currently have no other permits, such a transition is accompanied by uncertainty.

Apart from the above calculations, which are based on intentions to return, we also asked Ukrainians abroad about their willingness to return to Ukraine if temporary protection status is abolished. Such estimates can give a preliminary idea of the maximum number of people who may return to Ukraine as a result of changes in the rules for Ukrainians staying abroad.

Figure36 shows the distribution of refugees according to their situation in the context of the abolition of temporary protection status. Thus, about 21% (approximately 870,000 people) of Ukrainians abroad already have documents, in addition to temporary protection, that allow them to live there even if temporary protection is abolished. The rest – 3.4 million or 79% of refugees – do not yet have such documents and either plan to obtain them in the near future or are waiting for more information and plan to remain under temporary protection for the time being.

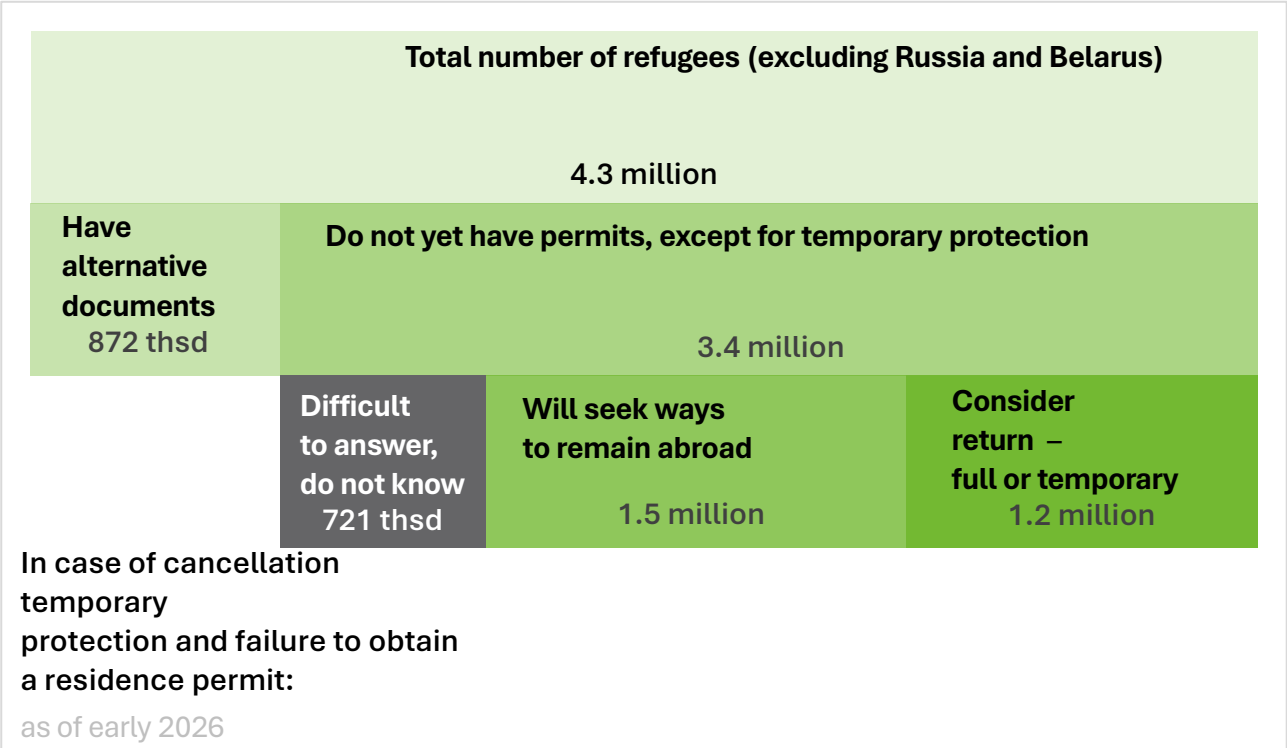
We asked those who do not yet have documents alternative to temporary protection how they would act if, after the cancellation of temporary protection, they were unable to obtain a residence permit in their country of residence. Almost 1.5 million refugees (47% of those without alternative documents) said

they would take other measures to remain abroad: they would seek opportunities to obtain a residence permit in another country or remain in their country of residence, even without a permit.

At the same time, about 1.2 million people are willing to consider returning to Ukraine if they do not obtain another status after the temporary protection is revoked. Of these, 871,000 are considering only returning, while the rest are willing to return and seek ways to remain abroad. If temporary protection is abolished and they are unable to obtain another residence permit, 691,000 will consider only a full return to Ukraine, which is about 16% of all refugees.

Respondents in this group are most likely refugees who either want to return to Ukraine or are very poorly rooted abroad. Accordingly, they are potentially the "easiest" category of refugees from the point of view of Ukraine's return policies. At the same time, it should be noted that this situation only represents the situation as of early 2026 and may change depending on conditions in Ukraine (in particular, the course of the war) and on how easy the host countries make the transition from temporary protection status to other statuses. The abolition of temporary protection and further actions leave uncertainty for many Ukrainians abroad. About 20% (720,000 people) of those who are still under temporary protection do not know what they will do if this status is abolished and they are unable to obtain an alternative one.

Figure36 . Distribution of Ukrainian refugees (except those in the Russian Federation and Belarus) by readiness for the abolition of temporary protection



Source: CES calculations based on an Info Sapiens survey commissioned by the CES, December 2025–January 2026. It is assumed that children have the same status as their parents.

12. CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

12.1. CONCLUSIONS

In this report, we have updated our estimates of the number of Ukrainians who left the country after the full-scale invasion, analysed who they are, their living conditions in Europe, and their intentions for the future. As of January 2026, there were 4.3 million Ukrainian refugees abroad (excluding the Russian Federation and the Republic of Belarus), while in Russia and Belarus there were about 1.3 million people. In total, we estimate that there are about 5.6 million Ukrainian citizens outside Ukraine due to the war.

With the decline in the number of Ukrainians leaving the country, the gender and age structure of refugees abroad has stabilised and has not changed significantly over the past year. As before, the majority of Ukrainians abroad are adult women (40%) and children (30%). The largest number of refugees are in Germany, Poland and the Czech Republic.

Currently, the main status allowing Ukrainian refugees to stay abroad is temporary protection. In the European Union, all Ukrainians are entitled to temporary protection status. Although this status grants the right to reside, work, receive education and medical care in all EU countries, living conditions and the amount of assistance received vary significantly for Ukrainians in different EU countries. Currently, EU countries anticipate that temporary protection status will end in March 2027. In September 2025, the Council of the EU adopted recommendations on the transition from temporary protection. They stipulate that EU countries will offer Ukrainians alternative national permits based on employment, education, family reasons, etc., as well as the creation of programmes for voluntary return to Ukraine.

Some countries are already encouraging Ukrainians to switch to general means of legal residence in their territory by applying for work or student visas. Thus, about 20% of refugees already have such alternative temporary protection statuses that allow them to stay abroad. Despite this, the abolition of temporary protection and further actions leave many Ukrainians abroad in uncertainty. About 20% (720,000 people) of those who are still under temporary protection do not know what they will do if this status is abolished and they are unable to obtain an alternative one. At the same time, about 1.2 million people are considering returning to Ukraine if they do not obtain another status after the abolition of temporary protection.

We conducted a cluster analysis and identified four groups of refugees and outlined their profiles. The first group is "New Life Trajectory," whose motives are dominated by pragmatic economic factors for leaving and unwillingness to return. The second group is "Strong ties": refugees who, despite being well integrated in their new country, miss Ukraine and are considering returning. The third group is "Economically vulnerable". This group has the weakest economic and social foundation in their new country, but they are focused on further integration. The fourth group is "Classic war refugees," who best fit the common perception of refugees from Ukraine. This cluster is also the largest; refugees who were assigned to it rarely want to integrate into their new country and are more focused on returning than other clusters.

The intentions of Ukrainian refugees to return have also stabilised over the past year. While previous waves of this study showed a downward trend in the proportion of refugees planning to return, in this wave of the survey, the proportion of refugees intending to return remained at 43%.

Among the barriers to return cited by refugees, war and its consequences continue to dominate. These include war and fear for safety (58% of respondents), infrastructure problems in Ukraine (41%) and the mobilisation of men (29%). Non-war-related factors also have an impact: better quality of life abroad (58%), successful adaptation (27%), and disbelief in Ukraine's future (27%). When it comes to factors that could encourage people to return, the end of the war (50%) and the absence of air strikes (35%) are important, but political and economic factors are also significant: improved living standards, the rule of law, anti-corruption measures, Ukraine's accession to the EU and NATO, etc.

We also conducted a regression analysis of factors related to the likelihood of Ukrainian refugees returning in the future. Our analysis shows that men are less likely to return to Ukraine than women, probably due to fear of mobilisation or losing the opportunity to leave the country again if they return. Older people are more likely to return to Ukraine. This may be due to the fact that they find it more difficult to adapt to life abroad than younger generations. Having children is associated with a lower desire to return, while having a partner in Ukraine is associated with more than twice the likelihood of returning.

Higher income before moving from Ukraine is associated with a higher probability of returning to Ukraine. This can probably be explained by a higher standard of living before moving. At the same time, higher income abroad is associated with lower intentions to return to Ukraine.

Refugees who continue to study or work remotely at Ukrainian institutions are more likely to return. Ukrainians who continue to send money to their relatives in Ukraine are also more likely to want to return to Ukraine.

The non-return of Ukrainians will have a significant impact on the Ukrainian economy. Both the number of migrants abroad who do not plan to return and the short-term economic losses from their non-return are gradually increasing and, depending on the method and basis of assessment, will range from 2% of GDP for an optimistic scenario to 10% of GDP for a pessimistic one.

12.2. RECOMMENDATIONS

We are updating our recommendations to reflect the changes that have taken place over the past year: the continuation of hostilities and the further integration of Ukrainian refugees abroad, the future termination of temporary protection for Ukrainians in the EU, and legislative changes in Ukraine. Some of last year's recommendations remain relevant. In some areas that we mentioned a year ago, there has been significant progress over the past year, while in others there has been little change. New recommendations have also been added. First and foremost, they are aimed at creating favourable conditions for Ukrainian refugees to return home.

12.2.1.COOPERATION WITH PARTNERS

- **Cooperation with EU countries on the return of Ukrainians after the abolition of temporary protection.** Ukraine must cooperate with its European partners to return Ukrainians in the process of developing policies that will replace temporary protection status. As we have shown in this study, if Ukrainian refugees remain abroad, the Ukrainian economy will suffer significant losses. Therefore, Ukraine must convey to its European partners that helping Ukraine return refugees will be a great support for it. Although if Ukrainians remain abroad, European countries will receive direct economic benefits, their return home will also bring indirect benefits for Europe. The return of refugees will strengthen Ukraine's economy and allow it to invest more in security and recovery, which means that it will need less European funding.
- **Cooperation with EU countries on social support for vulnerable categories of refugees.** The results of our survey show that older refugees and other vulnerable categories are more dependent on assistance and benefits in host countries and are more likely to consider returning to Ukraine if temporary protection or assistance is withdrawn. Ukraine should cooperate with European partners on programmes that will prevent a deterioration in the living conditions of these categories of refugees in the event of changes in the conditions of their stay in host countries.
- **Granting Ukrainian refugees freedom of movement and choice of residence on an equal footing with EU citizens.** Ukraine's goal is to join the European Union. Upon accession to the EU, Ukrainians will have the right to reside in any EU country. Granting this right earlier than will accelerate Ukraine's integration into the European Union. It will also be an important factor in encouraging Ukrainians to return, as they will be able to return without fear of losing their benefits or rights to reside abroad. In our opinion, Ukraine can encourage its EU partners to adopt this option by unilaterally introducing a similar right for EU citizens as soon as possible.
- **Recognition of work experience gained abroad in Ukraine.** Most Ukrainians abroad are involved in the labour market. At the same time, the process of recognising this work experience in Ukraine is often accompanied by bureaucratic difficulties. Reducing these obstacles could remove some of the barriers to return, particularly for middle-aged and older people.

12.2.2.CREATING ECONOMIC INCENTIVES FOR RETURN

- **Creating return programmes for young people.** According to the results of our research, young Ukrainians abroad are much less likely to return to Ukraine than older refugees. Among young Ukrainians abroad, the motives for better prospects abroad are more pronounced. Creating programmes aimed at the social and economic involvement of young Ukrainians abroad in Ukraine would encourage their return. Such programmes could include education, employment, financial assistance and other economic incentives to return.
- **Assistance programmes for people from affected and occupied regions.** This could include cash payments, housing provision or rental subsidies in regions of Ukraine that have not been damaged by the war. This will allow those who want to return to Ukraine now but have nowhere to go to do so.
- **Assistance in finding work in a safer region, retraining courses.** Although most refugees want to return only to their homes and regions, many Ukrainians, especially those who have left the combat zone, say that the opportunity to find well-paid work in a safer region would be a significant

incentive to return to Ukraine. Both state structures (such as the State Employment Service) and private organisations can help with this. For example, there are retraining programmes for refugees in Europe that are funded by both governments and charitable organisations. Such courses could also be held in safer regions of Ukraine to give refugees an incentive to return there.

12.2.3. INFRASTRUCTURE AND HOUSING

- **Investment in further improving transport links with Ukraine during the war.** Just as the state has made significant progress in establishing diversified routes for the export and import of goods, greater progress is needed in simplifying passenger transport links with Ukraine. This could involve large and complex decisions, such as opening airports, and a combination of smaller decisions, such as expanding rail connections, organisational measures to reduce travel and border crossing times, etc. These measures should result in fewer barriers for Ukrainians to come to Ukraine and "live in two countries" while spending more time in Ukraine.
- **Rapid post-war reconstruction of affected regions.** Survey data show that refugees often want to return to their region. In order for Ukrainians from regions affected by the war to have somewhere to return to, the destroyed regions need to be rebuilt quickly. At the same time, mistakes made during post-war reconstruction in other countries should be avoided: not only residential buildings but also infrastructure must be restored, and responsibility for the reconstruction of each facility must be agreed upon so that different organisations do not duplicate each other's functions.
- **Compensation for destroyed and damaged housing.** The government should scale up the compensation programme for destroyed housing, using the experience of the effective launch of certificates for IDPs. Increased funding from international partners (in particular, the EIB and the Council of Europe Development Bank) will accelerate housing reconstruction. It is also important to integrate support for IDPs into a long-term strategy, including municipal housing, employment, healthcare and education. The creation of a unified digital service system will simplify the compensation process and increase the transparency of fund distribution.
- **Development of public-private partnership mechanisms.** In order for investors to be willing to invest in the Ukrainian economy (for example, to build an industrial enterprise in a relatively safe region) without fears related to difficulties in finding labour, central or local authorities, in particular with the help of international partners, can build housing for potential employees. This will encourage the return of Ukrainian refugees, especially those who have left the combat zone, where their homes or cities have been destroyed, as well as those from the occupied territories, who will find it difficult to return to their home region immediately after the end of the war.

12.2.4. EDUCATION POLICY

- **Minimising barriers and encouraging Ukrainian graduates of foreign schools to return to Ukrainian higher education institutions.** Many Ukrainian schoolchildren who have left the country are receiving secondary education abroad and will therefore not have Ukrainian documents certifying their complete secondary education. Since the start of the full-scale invasion, the Ministry of Education and Science has been consistently removing barriers to admission to Ukrainian higher education institutions for applicants who are abroad. Further efforts should be directed towards expanding the network for taking the NMT abroad, facilitating the procedure for obtaining the

documents required for registration for the NMT abroad (e.g. identification code), integrating foreign certificates into the EDEBO system, and creating incentives for students to return to full-time study in Ukraine (housing, scholarships, future employment, etc.). An important step in this direction could also be admission to Ukrainian higher education institutions on the basis of final exams in the countries of residence of Ukrainian refugees, provided that there is a transparent and non-discriminatory procedure for converting foreign grades to the NMT scale.

- **Automatic nostrification and recognition of European diplomas in Ukraine.** Most Ukrainians returning to Ukraine will have education obtained in EU countries. At the same time, the process of legal recognition of such diplomas is not optimal, especially for those considering civil service. Further simplification and reduction of the cost of the procedure for recognising foreign diplomas, in particular through the creation of a "white list" of foreign universities and further digitisation of processes, will make it easier for specialists to return from abroad.

12.2.5. MAINTAINING TIES WITH UKRAINE AND WORKING WITH THE DIASPORA

- **Increase resources for communication with Ukrainians abroad through "unity hubs".** Regular meetings, consultations and information seminars can be organised for Ukrainian citizens who have left Ukraine. These measures will not only help to ensure adequate awareness of the opportunities and prospects for return, but will also create a platform for the exchange of experience and community building, as well as inform Ukrainians abroad about the legal aspects of cooperation with Ukraine (remote work for a Ukrainian company, cooperation with Ukrainian businesses, etc.). It is important that such events are truly effective in building ties between the Ukrainian diaspora and Ukraine, so it is worth trying out different formats for such events and retaining the most effective ones.
- **Keeping Ukrainian schoolchildren abroad in the Ukrainian educational field.** The return to Ukraine of schoolchildren who found themselves abroad due to the full-scale invasion will be more likely if they are included in the Ukrainian community. The priority areas should be the study of Ukrainian studies without creating an excessive burden on children abroad, financial and organisational support for a network of socialisation centres (Saturday and Sunday schools, clubs, etc.), and the organisation of short-term educational and reintegration trips to Ukraine for middle and high school students, as well as university students. Intergovernmental agreements with countries where many Ukrainian refugees currently reside could also help to include subjects from the Ukrainian studies component in school curricula in these countries (e.g., Ukrainian as a foreign language, etc.).

APPENDIX 1. DESCRIPTION OF THE METHODOLOGY FOR SELECTING VARIABLES FOR CLUSTERING

Too many variables in clustering can distort the results, as the influence of irrelevant or weakly informative features increases, adding noise and blurring the distances (or modes in the case of k-modes) between observations. As a result, this reduces the algorithm's ability to detect the true latent structure of the data, and the clusters formed become less stable, less interpretable, and more dependent on random initialisations and parameter choices. Therefore, for formalised variable selection within the unsupervised learning task, we used an instrumental approach that combines clustering with supervised learning algorithms.

In unsupervised learning tasks, there are no "true" class labels, so standard feature selection methods for classification tasks cannot be applied directly. To obtain a formalised criterion for evaluating the informativeness of variables, the study uses the "cluster as pseudo-label" approach: the results of clustering, i.e. the vector of observations belonging to clusters, are interpreted as a temporary artificial target variable (pseudo-label). The practical implementation of this approach is that for each individual run of the k-modes algorithm (with fixed values for the number of clusters k , the random initialisation parameter seed, and/or a specific subset of features), the resulting cluster membership vector is considered as the target variable in the classification task, while the feature matrix X corresponds to the set of variables used in the same clustering run.

The next step is to apply the Boruta method, a wrapper algorithm for feature selection built on top of Random Forest. Its key idea is to compare the importance of real features with so-called shadow features (artificial copies of variables in which values are randomly shuffled between observations). Such shadow features, by definition, have no systematic connection with the target variable and serve as a reference level of "pure noise".

During Random Forest training, the importance of both real and shadow features is evaluated. For each variable, Boruta compares its importance with the maximum importance among shadow features and, on this basis, classifies variables into three statuses:

- Confirmed – the feature is statistically consistently more important than the most informative shadow feature and therefore contains relevant information for reproducing the cluster structure;
- Rejected – the feature does not demonstrate informativeness higher than random noise;
- Tentative – a status of uncertainty when the available iterations are insufficient for a final decision.

The implementation uses the $\text{maxRuns} = 200$ constraint, which sets the maximum number of iterations during which Boruta refines its decision on the status of each feature. After this process is complete, the TentativeRoughFix procedure is applied, which transfers variables with Tentative status to the Confirmed or Rejected category according to a formalised rule, ensuring an unambiguous and reproducible result. This is necessary for further calculation of the frequency of inclusion of variables in a set of runs.

It should be emphasised that the use of cluster membership as a target variable does not mean that the clustering task is transformed into a full-fledged classification task. This step is purely instrumental and serves as a means of assessing which variables systematically contribute to the reproduction of the cluster structure found by the k-modes algorithm for a specific parameter configuration. Since the clustering results depend on the algorithm settings (in particular, the number of clusters, random initialisation, and the set of variables used), a single run cannot be considered a reliable basis for feature selection. The same variable may appear important in one configuration but lose its significance in another. Therefore, variable selection is based not on a single result but on their repeatability in many alternative scenarios.

In practice, this is implemented through a series of clustering runs in which key parameters are deliberately changed: the number of clusters, random initialisation of the algorithm, and the composition of the feature set. For each such run, a list of variables is determined that Boruta recognises as informative for reproducing the obtained cluster structure. In this variant, we additionally control stability not only "on average" but also within each feature_set scenario. Next, we analyse how often a variable appears among the important ones in the entire set of runs. First, the Confirmed share is calculated separately within each feature_set (confirmed_share_fs), i.e. "in how many runs of this subset was the variable Confirmed ". Variables that are consistently recognised as informative under different settings are considered more reliable and less sensitive to random factors.

The final set of variables is formed according to the principle of stability: a variable is included in the model only if it is recognised as important for a critical proportion of runs. In our version, a strict criterion is applied: the variable must reach the stability threshold in each feature_set, i.e., the "worst" indicator (min_share_across_fs) among all subsets is actually used. In our specification, stability_threshold = 0.70 is set. A diagnostic table of the overall frequency Confirmed is generated separately, but it is used only for control/output and is not the main selection rule.

To avoid a situation where, due to an overly strict threshold, too few variables remain in the final set for meaningful clustering, an additional safeguard mechanism is applied. If, after applying the stability criterion, the number of selected variables is too small, the fallback selects the top-N variables not by overall frequency, but by the highest min_share_across_fs value (i.e., by the "best of the worst" stability between feature_sets) until the minimum acceptable set size is reached (min_vars_needed = 8) is reached. This allows maintaining a balance between the strictness of selection and the analytical interpretability of the results.

After forming the stable_vars set, the final k-modes run is performed only on these stable variables.

APPENDIX 2. VARIABLES IN CLUSTER ANALYSIS

Below, in Table 18, is a list of variables that were included as candidates for clustering. Next, after selecting more informative and stable variables using the Boruta algorithm, only some of them were included in the final version of the clustering described in this study.

Table 18. List of variables on which the clustering was based

Variable name	Included in the final version of the clustering?
barrier_integration	No
barrier_quality_life	No
barrier_security	No
benefit_dynamic	No
diff_material	No
diff_psych	No
diff_social	No
econ_status	No
emp_status	No
has_local_friends	No
housing_type	No
lang_knowledge	No
living_situation	No
local_attitude	No
plan_return	No
push_factor_destruction	No

push_factor_safety	No
push_factor_soft	No
receives_cash_help	No
receives_housing_help	No
status_secure	No
barrier_integration	Yes
barrier_quality_life	Yes
diff_material	Yes
diff_psych	Yes
diff_social	Yes
econ_status	Yes
emp_status	Yes
has_local_friends	Yes
housing_type	Yes
lang_knowledge	Yes
plan_return	Yes
push_factor_safety	Yes
push_factor_soft	Yes
receives_cash_help	Yes
status_secure	Yes

Below is a description of the definitions of each variable.

living_situation ("Who do you live with now?")

This variable defines the composition of the respondent's household abroad:

- **"Alone"**: if "Alone" is selected (A2.1_1).
- **"Family"**: if at least one option from relatives is selected: children (A2.1_2, A2.1_3), grandchildren (A2.1_4), parents (A2.1_5) or husband/wife (A2.1_6).
- **"Friends/Other"**: if living with other relatives (A2.1_7), friends (A2.1_8) or other (A2.1_9) is selected.

housing_type ("What type of housing do you currently live in?")

Grouping of housing types (D1):

- **1 (Separate housing)**: "Separate flat or house" (D1=1).
- **2 (Room/shared accommodation)**: "Room with other Ukrainians (known)" (D1=2) or "Room with local residents" (D1=4).
- **3 (Collective housing and other)**: All other options, including dormitories, hotels, refugee centres or rooms with strangers (D1 = 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9).

lang_knowledge ("What is your level of knowledge of the language (name of the selected country)?")

Based on self-assessment (V3):

- **1 (Low)**: "No knowledge at all" or "Only at a minimal level" ($V3 \leq 2$).
- **2 (Intermediate)**: "At a basic level" or "At a sufficient level for communication" (V3 from 3 to 4).
- **3 (High)**: Understanding of texts, wide range or fluency ($V3 \geq 5$).

local_attitude ("How would you rate the attitude of local residents towards you in general?")

Based on the respondent's assessment (V5):

- **1 (Positive)**: "Positive" or "Rather positive" ($V5 \leq 2$).
- **2 (Neutral)**: "Neither positive nor negative" ($V5 = 3$).
- **3 (Negative)**: "Somewhat negative" or "Negative" ($V5 \geq 4$).

has_local_friends ("Do you have friends/good acquaintances among local residents (non-Ukrainians)?")

- = 1 if the respondent has friends among the locals: those he/she knew before ($V7_1=1$) or those he/she met here ($V7_2=1$).

emp_status ("What is your current employment status?")

Priority employment grouping (E2):

- **1 (Working in the country of residence)**: Full-time employment (E2_04), part-time employment (E2_05) or business in this country (E2_11).

- **2 (Working remotely in Ukraine):** Remote work at old (E2_01) or new (E2_02) job, or business in Ukraine (E2_10).
- **3 (Looking for work):** Actively looking for work in the country of residence (E2_06).
- **4 (Students):** Studying remotely (E2_07), at local institutions (E2_08) or on courses (E2_09).
- **5 (Inactive):** Pensioners (E2_12), disabled (E2_13) or those who are not working and not looking for work (household) (E2_14).

econ_status ("Select the statement that described your economic situation before moving from Ukraine")

Subjective assessment of well-being in Ukraine (E3):

- **1 (Low):** Saved on food or had just enough for food ($E3 \leq 2$).
- **2 (Average):** Had enough for food and clothing, or for household appliances ($E3 = 3$ or 4).
- **3 (High):** Could afford expensive items or everything necessary ($E3 \geq 5$).

receives_housing_help: = 1 if they receive free housing (G1_01).

receives_cash_help: = 1 if they receive social benefits (G1_04).

benefit_dynamic ("During your stay in (name of selected country), the amount of social benefits that you and your family receive")

How have benefits changed during your stay (G2):

- **1:** Increased.
- **2:** Decreased.
- **3:** They have not changed.
- **4:** Cancelled or suspended (options 4 "stopped paying" and 5 "did not receive initially").

plan_return ("Do you plan to return to Ukraine?")

Based on question J2:

- **1 (Planning):** "Definitely planning" or "Most likely planning" ($J2 = 1, 2$).
- **2 (No plans):** "Most likely not" or "Definitely not" ($J2 = 3, 4$).
- **3 (Hard to say):** "Hard to say" ($J2 \geq 5$).

status_secure ("In October 2025, the European Union adopted recommendations on the gradual abolition of temporary protection for Ukrainian refugees. Other countries may also gradually abolish special statuses for Ukrainians who left because of the war. Which of the following best describes your situation?")

Based on K1:

- **1 (Permanent/Other status):** Have documents other than temporary protection ($K1_1=1$).

- **2 (Temporary protection):** Planning other documents (K1_2=1) or remaining under temporary protection (K1_3=1).
- **3:** Other.

Variables created by combining the answer options to the question "What barriers are currently preventing you from returning to Ukraine?":

- **barrier_security (Security):** = 1 if "War, fear for safety" (J4.0_01), "Occupation of the region" (J4.0_02) or "Home in the combat zone" (J4.0_03) is selected.
- **barrier_integration (Integration):** = 1 if "Already adapted to life abroad" (J4.0_05) or "My family/relatives live here" (J4.0_10) is selected.
- **barrier_quality_life (Quality of life):** = 1 if "Better job" (J4.0_06), "Better quality of life/healthcare" (J4.0_07) or "Better social support" (J4.0_08) is selected.

Variables created by combining the answer options to the question about the main difficulties "What difficulties are you personally facing now in (name of selected country)? Select up to 5 biggest difficulties":

- **diff_material (Material):** = 1 if "Difficulties in finding a job" (J12_02), "Material difficulties" (J12_03) or "Finding housing" (J12_04) is selected.
- **diff_psych (Psychological):** = 1 if "Psychological problems" (J12_08), "I miss my homeland" (J12_09) or "Separation from family" (J12_10) is selected.
- **diff_social (Social):** = 1 if "Language difficulties" (J12_01), "Interaction with locals" (J12_05) or "Lack of friends" (J12_12) is selected.
- **push_factor_destruction:** = 1 if left due to occupation or destruction of housing (A3_04, A3_05).
- **push_factor_safety:** = 1 if you left due to immediate danger/hostilities/occupation (A3_01, A3_02, A3_03, A3_08).
- **push_factor_soft:** = 1, if they left due to "soft" factors (e.g., loss of job or significant part of earnings, better prospects abroad, education for children, work) (A3_06, A3_09, A3_10, A3_14).